

prism

VOLUME 4 • NUMBER 1

Fall 2024

The Third World Politics of
Malcolm X

HT Xue

The American Civil War Was Not
a Revolution

Molly O'Brien

Jeffersonian Vs Lincolnian Ideals

Henry Mannio



prism

A Youth Journal of History and
Social Science

Volume 4, Issue 1

Fall 2024

Editors-in-Chief

Molly O'Brien • Haotong Xue

Editorial Board

Oliver Sin • Anaïs Bricout

Avaneesh Siruvuri • Sissi Ma

Zidan Graham • Emlyn Joseph

Henry Mannino

Faculty Advisor

Joshua Emmott

Cover Image: United States Capitol Building - Andy Feliciotti

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Editors-in-Chief

Editor's Note

- 4 *HT Xue - Editor-In-Chief (Milton Academy)*
The Third World Politics of Malcolm X
- 23 *Molly O'Brien - Editor-In-Chief (Milton Academy)*
The American Civil War Was Not a Revolution
- 29 *Henry Mannino - Chief Layout Editor (Milton Academy)*
Jeffersonian Vs Lincolnian Ideals - An Examination Into The Southern Fear of
Equality During Reconstruction
- 34 *Rhys Adams (Milton Academy)*
“KEEP THEM IN THE CLOSET”: Lesbian Involvement in Second-Wave
Feminism, Queer Advocacy, and the Fight against HIV/AIDS
- 48 *Kasen Bookbinder (Milton Academy)*
The Case for Abolishing the Electoral College
- 52 *Rhia Patel (Milton Academy)*
Mending the Segregation in Healthcare: How the American Medical Association
Suppressed the Liberties of Black People
- 64 *Maddison Varone (Barrington High School RI)*
A Look into a 9/11 Experience
- 66 *Anaïs Bricout - Managing Editor (Milton Academy)*
The True Public Enemy: The War on Drugs' Role in Mass Incarceration and
Harsh Policing
- 80 *Cattien Huynh (Milton Academy)*
Breaking Point: An Exploration of the Psychosocial Factors Behind the My
Lai Massacre

TABLE OF CONTENTS

- 89 *Summer Girard (Bridgewater-Raynham Regional High School)*
Madison and the Federal Negative
- 91 *Emilia Ravoila (Milton Academy)*
Enslavement, Abortion, and “Race Suicide”: White Supremacist Reproductive Control in the Modern Era
- 105 *Sissi Ma - Associate Editor (Milton Academy)*
Tracking the Formation of a Culture of Exterminability in Armenia from 1878 to 1915

EDITOR'S NOTE

“Democracy is a process, not a static condition. It is becoming, rather than being. It can easily be lost, but never is fully won. Its essence is eternal struggle.”

—- Federal Judge William H. Hastie

When thinking of utopia, few leave out democracy from the world they imagine. Indeed, history is filled with people who, despite promising radically different visions of how the world should work, are united in their claims to want to give power to the people – from Thomas Jefferson to Mao Ze Dong, from the 2018 Yellow Vest Protestors in France to the 2024 pro-reform protestors in Georgia. Democracy draws its universal appeal and its power from its very nature; it serves the interests of the masses and thus comes in fundamental tension with the interests of those who seek to consolidate resources or power, of whom history has seen many. Thus it can be argued that the fight for the people to keep their power in the face of a powerful elite – in other words, the struggle for democracy – is the fundamental driving force of history.

But what is democracy in the first place? Where did it come from? To the first question, some might answer that democracy is a system in which people vote, others might answer that it is the natural final stage of a society's evolution toward equality. To the second question, some might suggest that the Ancient Athenians invented democracy, while others might point to the first European parliamentary systems as humanity's first exercise in democracy. Translated from its Greek roots, the word “democracy” means “rule by the people”. By this definition, democracy has existed since long before even the first organized governments. It is not a system of government, nor a stage of human development, but rather a reality of life. Every human who has ever lived in history has made decisions that affected the world around them, and the world is in terms the product of the gross sum of every human decision ever made. Democracy is the term used to describe this reality. Democracy was present in pre-agriculture hunter-gatherer communities in Sumeria, it was present in every popular revolution, it is present in every worker's strike, and it is present today in all the interactions in the world around us. Sometimes, despots and autocrats weaken the power of democracy, and people always fight to preserve it, but its existence is

a fact of life. Democracy gives weight to our choices, and thus frees us to shape our world, but also binds us to live by the consequences of our choices.

The 2024 US presidential election represented an upheaval in democracy, but one that is far from unprecedented. While America deals with the fallout of a transition of power, Israel, Georgia, Taiwan, and many other countries reckon with similar disturbances. Moreover, presidential elections in 2020 and 2016, the birth of a nation in 1776, the collapse of the Aztec empire in 1521, and the passage of the Voting Rights Act in 1965 all represent major changes in the democratic fabric of our country.

All of this is to demonstrate that democracy, along with its many turbulences, is a feature, not a bug of history. That's why this issue of Prism Youth Journal, in light of the recent election, compiled history papers concerning upheavals in not just democracy in America, but democracy as a value and a way of life to hopefully help you better understand what it means to live by our – the people's – own power. Henry Mannino's (Milton Academy '26) paper Jeffersonian Vs Jacksonian Ideals details the methods and motivations by which democracy was denied to formerly enslaved people during the Reconstruction era. Enslavement, Abortion, and "Race Suicide" by Emilia Raviola (Milton Academy '26) argues that reproductive control was a key avenue by which agency was denied to America's earliest victims of despotism. Anaïs Bricout's (Milton Academy '26) The True Public Enemy outlines how men in power use populism and scapegoating as a means to turn the might of democracy against its very own constituents. These, along with ten other papers from students at Milton Academy, Bridgewater-Raynham High School, and Barrington High School collectively explore small corners of the grand historical battle between democracy and that which seeks to suppress it. Some papers talk about democracy explicitly, while others require the reader to do some thinking of their own, and they all vary in length, tone, and content. Regardless, we are confident that you will learn something new from each of them, and we hope you enjoy this issue of Prism Youth Journal!

Yours Sincerely,
The Editors-In-Chiefs
Molly and HT

Like what you've read? SUBMIT to the next issue of Prism at prismyouthmilton@gmail.com!

THE THIRD WORLD POLITICS OF MALCOLM X

HT XUE

Milton Academy '26

4

The 1950's and 1960's were an era defined by the bipolarity of the Cold War. The struggle between Soviet Communism and the United States' neoliberal vision for the world, however, was not the only ideological movement taking place at the time. Indeed, a coalescence of various decolonization processes throughout the Global South provided the conditions for a rising Third World movement to unite much of Africa, Asia, and South America in a refusal of the dichotomy of the Cold War, wherein both major world powers lobbied burgeoning states for ideological and geopolitical influence. At the same time within the U.S., various grassroots social justice movements were gaining traction, giving rise to the civil rights leaders whose thinking and rhetoric shaped the U.S.' political discourse during that period. Perhaps the most infamous among these leaders was Malcolm X.

X, born Malcolm Little before renaming himself to sever his ties to the name given to him by the white man who had enslaved his ancestors, was known most for his fiery rhetoric and his advocacy of Black Nationalist Separatism, the belief that only "a separate nation for blacks could provide the basis for their self-improvement and advancement as a people." However, viewing X's career holistically and in the context of the complex ideological linkages with the Third World he developed in the decade prior to his death in 1965 reveals a far more complete and complex picture of his luminary understanding of civil rights, colonialism, and revolutionary politics. Indeed, while X's activism is often portrayed as the villainous foil to Martin Luther King-style nonviolence, X's ideology was ever-evolving and far from monolithic. Specifically, prompted by various Third World influences from 1955 to his death in 1965, Malcolm X's rhetoric reflected his shift from belief

in Black Nationalist separatism championed by the Nation of Islam to a realist vision of internationalist grassroots revolution.

Growing Pains

Born in May of 1925 to Black Nationalist and baptist preacher Earl Little and seamstress Louise Little in Omaha, Nebraska, Malcolm X lost his father and mother respectively in 1931 to a streetcar accident (which X died believing was the work of a white supremacist group) and in 1938 to a mental illness diagnosis and spent most of his teenage years with foster families. During this time, X developed a tendency for resistance against and hatred for the United States government, infamously declaring that he would “fight for the Japanese” after being drafted to fight in the Second World War in 1943 and subsequently being declared unfit for service. In 1946, at the age of 21, X was arrested on account of grand larceny after embarking on a stealing spree in Boston. X would spend his next six years in Norfolk County Prison in Massachusetts, where he experienced the dehumanizing nature of the U.S. prison system. In an interview with historian Manning Marable for his posthumously published biography *A Life of Reinvention*, X lamented that in prison, one “never heard [their own] name, only [their] number,” and that these numbers were “stenciled” on every aspect of their lives, from “all of their clothing” to the depths of “[their] brain”. That the US prison system disproportionately incarcerated black people racialized X’s time in prison, reinforcing his belief that black and white people were irreconcilably and inherently opposed to one another, and injecting his hatred of the state with a flare of revolutionary activism. X subsequently sought to consolidate this alienating conceptualization of racism, and succeeded in doing so after his sister Hilda Little introduced him to the thought of converting to the burgeoning Nation of Islam (NOI), a sect of black American Islamists who advocated for complete separation of black and white America and the use of self-defensive violence, headed by a preacher named Elijah Muhammed, and of which four of X’s siblings and his father had been a part. Hilda explained to X the Nation’s founding myth - in which Yacub, an evil black scientist, genetically engineered the creation of the white race 6000 years ago to commit crimes against black people; black separatism, and reverence of Allah, claimed the myth, was the only way to ensure the survival of the black race. The myth, in its scale and grandeur, provided an appealing historical justification for X’s hardline hatred for what he came to see as institutions of whiteness. Thus, following a series of letter correspondences with Elijah Muhammed, and after being

released from prison on parole in 1952, X officially joined the NOI, where he quickly rose through the ranks.

X's activism between his introduction to the NOI and his first major ideological exchange with the Third World in 1955 prominently featured the separatism and religious rhetoric of the NOI. Late in his time in Norfolk County Prison, for example, X produced a manifesto condemning the Charlestown county order that banned Muslim prisoners from leaving their beds after curfew for their evening prayers as an attack upon religious rights that threatened to redress the entire global community of Islamic faiths - work emblematic of his early career activism centered around religion as a primary avenue of anti-racism within the systemically racist prison system. Following X's release from prison, his first major exploit within the NOI would be in the form of participation in a documentary produced by journalist Michael Wallace named *The Hate That Hate Produced*, in which Wallace sought insight into what he saw as the hateful beliefs of the Black Nationalist movement. Wallace's documentary, which aired in 1956, launched the prominently featured X into national notoriety. In it, commenting on whether the NOI preached hate against white people, X claimed to not recognize "any historic example where [...] [white people] have, collectively, as a people, done good," highlighting a belief in the white-black dichotomy that demonstrated a simple concept of racism his later career experiences would force him to evolve beyond.

6

Lessons in Bandung

X's ideas regarding race and revolution would soon begin to shift due to his various international travels - in the first of which he attended the Bandung Conference. In April of 1955, heads of state from a coalition of recently decolonized third-world countries gathered in Bandung, Indonesia to discuss the formation of the Non Aligned Movement (NAM), a proposed pact to resist alignment with the bipolar powers of the U.S. and Soviet Russia; attending countries spanned Asia and Africa and were represented by delegations led by prominent heads of state like Egypt's Gamal Abdel Nasser and India's Jawaharlal Nehru. Following his rise through the ranks of the NOI, X was invited to attend the conference.

X's attendance at the Bandung Conference prompted him to reconceptualize racism as an aspect of global colonialism and the US's domestic policy as an aspect of its international colonial agenda; thus, he adapted his rhetoric to advocate for global unity

as opposed to dogmatic separatism in the struggle against colonial oppression. Specifically, Bandung began to erode X's binary view of racial struggle, and recontextualized his understanding of racism within the U.S. as part of the wider colonial system of the world. Premier Zhou Enlai of China's delegation address, which cited several struggles for sovereignty across Afro-Eurasia as part of the same conflict, encapsulated the thesis of the conference:

The struggle of the Egyptian people for the restoration of their sovereignty over the Suez Canal Zone, the struggle of the Iranian people for the restoration of sovereignty over their petroleum resources, and the demand for the restoration of the territorial rights of India over Goa and of Indonesia over West Irian, have all won sympathy from many countries in Asia and Africa. [...] This proves that the peoples of our Asian and African countries understand each other and have sympathy and concern for one another.

Zhou, speaking about the same struggles against oppression for national, and indeed racial, self-determination, mirrored the struggle X saw black Americans face, but framed as part of a struggle against white colonialism across Eurasia. Thus, speaking on his experience at the conference in his 1965 speech *The Oppressed Masses of the World Cry Out for Action Against the Common Oppressor*, X proclaimed that Bandung represented "one of the first and best steps toward real independence for nonwhite people," because it provided a space for "the people of Africa and Asia and Latin America [to get] together," highlighting his newfound belief in united global anti-colonialism. Moreover, X believed that the Bandung Conference was successful specifically in its exclusion of white people and inclusion of every other race, which is why in his 1963 speech *Message to the Grass-roots* he advocated against Black Nationalism and instead for unity both between Asian and African civil empowerment movements and among black people in the US, identifying the colonial power as the omnipresent "common oppressor, [...] common exploiter, and [...] common discriminator".

First Tour Abroad

Despite the influence of Bandung, X would continue his activism on behalf of the dogmatically Black Nationalist NOI, until, in July of 1959, X embarked on his second round of international travel as an ambassador for the NOI, touring Sudan, Nigeria, Egypt,

Ghana, Syria, and Saudi Arabia. This tour reshaped his understanding of the Black diaspora within the U.S. as part of a wider African world, inspiring his advocacy of pan-Africanism. Whereas Bandung brought Asians and other peoples of color into X's consideration of global colonialism, X's 1959 tour instilled in him a cognizance that racial identity was not fixed in the first place but relative: in an interview with historian Manning Marable, X reflected upon his visit to Egypt that the Egyptians he saw "ranged [in skin color] from regal black to rich brown," and thus that while black Egyptians were all his "brothers of color," they "could be [considered] white or Mulatto in another [country]". This realization inspired his newfound conceptualization of the American black diaspora not as an independent entity fighting an oppressive white establishment but as a critical part of the pan-African global diaspora which, despite their differing skin color, faced oppression from the same white-dominated global institutions. One way this new concern with African politics would materialize was in X's rhetoric: in his 1964 speech At the Audubon, X argued that Africa was invaluable in the great power conflict of the Cold War in its control of the Suez and Gibraltar trade routes and the continent's rich natural resource exports, and thus African states must unite in its resolution to resist alignment with either side to maintain its geopolitical agency. Moreover, X's 1959 tour challenged his belief in the Yacub story and convinced him to reject Black Separatism and embrace universal inclusion as the solution to the problem of race. Reporting to Marable that he had often been embarrassed during his travels by his lack of knowledge regarding "True Islam," X was prompted to reconsider his views regarding the NOI's strict doctrine against unity and grassroots activism. Writing for the Egyptian Gazette in 1964 in an article entitled Racism: the Cancer that is Destroying America, X stated that "[his] religious pilgrimage to Mecca has given [him] a new insight into the true brotherhood of Islam, which encompasses all the races of mankind" and thus that "the African struggle for liberation is a matter of human rights," as opposed to a binary conflict between white and black. This reorientation would result in the souring of relations with the NOI; in a 1965 interview on CBC Frontpage, X repudiated the separatist state the NOI advocated for, stating that he "[did not] believe in any form of segregation" and that he had begun "doubting [Elijah Muhammed's] action in bringing his solution [to racism] to reality".

A Cuban Dance

In the immediate wake of his return from Africa in April of 1959, however, X was

still a dedicated, albeit skeptical, member of the Nation. By late 1959, NOI leaders, including X, had “[grown] increasingly enamored with the successes and ideals of third world revolutionaries” beyond Africa; specifically, many within the NOI “saw in the Marxist struggle a better way of defining and addressing racial conflict,” particularly in an era of McCarthyism. During this time, the US’ tensions with Fidel Castro’s Cuban regime was reaching its height. While Castro, with his radically internationalist Marxist vision, took the opportunity to engage in ideological exchange with other grassroots movements in the U.S. – for example welcoming Robert Williams of the civil rights movement on a tour of Cuba – the NOI “held fast to its strict doctrine of separatism,” watching from a distance as it “had little to contribute to the dialogue over how to best change the existing order”. X himself, however, was more than comfortable rejecting the NOI’s dogma and engaging with Castro himself in various ways. For example, in September 1960, while on a diplomatic visit to New York City for international meetings at the United Nations headquarters, X met Castro upon the former’s invitation at Hotel Theresa in Uptown New York with his diplomatic delegation after the U.S. Department of State pressured Hotel Shelburne, where Castro was originally scheduled to stay, into canceling his booking.

While the exact details of what was said during the meeting were not documented, the motivations for the meeting were clear for Castro, and the outcome transformative for X. Castro leveraged his meeting with X, which was widely covered by national news, as a play of publicity to expose what historian Garrett Felber called the US’s ideological “Achilles Heel” during the Cold War – racial bigotry. While Castro’s anti-racism could only be described as half-hearted at best, as evidenced by the fact that his entire 80-person delegation to the U.S. was white, his conversation with X in New York, along with X’s study of the Cuban revolutionary regime, inspired X to fully commit to a reinvented view of the US’s place in the world.

X’s interactions with Fidel Castro from 1959 to the Cuban Missile Crisis in 1962 furthered X’s rhetoric regarding the United States’ role within the world as a colonial force and taught him that to understand the U.S.’ global influence was critical to understanding the state’s role in domestic racism. While X had, through his visit to Africa, begun seeing the black diaspora in the U.S. through a pan-African lens, his rhetoric by 1959 had yet to reflect a similarly globalized view of the US’s police state. The influence of Castro’s ideas, which positioned the US, along with the neoliberal West, as a global military state driven by profit, changed that fact. In his Audubon speech, X lamented that “in America, [black activists] have always thought that [they] were struggling by [them]selves,” and that such

struggle takes place “only because [they] don’t yet know where [they] fit in the scheme of things,” referring to the US’s place in the world as an oppressor; “when you and I are inside of America [...] she looks big and bad and invincible,” posited X, but approaching the state in any other context reveals the revolutionary methods most effective to dismantling systems. This rhetoric reflected X’s newfound Marxist ideology in that he began analyzing the profit motive of and specific methods of violence used by the Military Industrial Complex. For example, critiquing the US’s violent neoliberalism in his 1965 speech *A Global Rebellion of the Oppressed Against the Oppressor*, X repudiated the classification of racial conflict as a problem of “Black Against White” or as a “purely American problem” as “incorrect,” instead arguing that the Western world has “deliberately subjugated the Negro for economic reasons”. More specifically, in his *Oppressed Masses* speech, X’s critique of Congolese Prime Minister Moïse Tshombe – that his pro-Western and often violent military junta was “propped up by American dollars” via the hiring of South African mercenaries – demonstrated X’s recognition of the economic nature of the US’s global military supremacy and soft power influence which, in X’s eyes, allowed it to act as a brutal global police force. Moreover, his analysis of the Congolese state also reflected a Marx-esque critique of the U.S. media’s role in fueling the Military Industrial Complex. In his *Audubon* speech, he argued that depictions of Congolese “black women and children [...] being blown to bits by airplanes” from the U.S. are excluded from the press media simply because “they are American planes,” making any military action “humanitarian” in the eyes of the American public. That X took on a distinctly anti-U.S. stance in his rhetoric reflected a critical shift in how he conceptualized the place his activism had in the world - whereas his separatist belief had been grand in its religious scope yet limited in its real reach, his new rhetoric sought to deconstruct oppression as global, systemic, and profit-motivated, and pushed him further away from the simplistic and dogmatic violence the NOI advocated for.

The Hajj

On March 8, 1964, after years of deteriorating relations with the NOI and specifically Elijah Muhammed for what X perceived as a rigid view of social justice that no longer reflected his ideology, X announced his departure from the NOI. In April of that year, X, motivated by a desire to participate in a Hajj - the annual Islamic pilgrimage to Mecca - embarked on his second round of international travel, an experience which fully cemented the

influence from his first visit to Africa.

Malcolm X's Hajj in 1964 and his subsequent travels leading up to 1965 in Europe fully severed his connection with beliefs of the Nation of Islam in favor of traditional Islamic faith, a change which reinforced his belief that race was relative and that oppression was the fault of a system instead of of any one group, prompting him to realist political activism. An April 1964 letter written while in Egypt to American biographer and journalist Michael S. Handler, in which X reported having "eaten from the same plate, drunk from the same glass and slept on the same rug, while praying to the same God, with fellow Muslims, whose eyes were the bluest of blue, whose hair was the blondest of blonde, and whose skin was the whitest of white," yet from whom he felt the "same sincerity [he] felt among the black African Muslims of Nigeria, Sudan, and Ghana" revealed X's receding hatred of white people due to his sense of newfound religious spiritualism. While his prior international experiences had prompted him to develop a wider view of whom he considered to be the victims of systemic violence, his 1964 trip was the final nail in the coffin for his belief in race as an indicator of any inherent tendency to enact violence. Moreover, this Islam-rooted inclusivity found its way into X's views on race as a construct. For example, in a later letter to Handler, written in September of 1964, X argued that "True Islam removes racism, because people of all colors and races who accept its religious principles and bow down to the one God, Allah, also automatically accept each other as brothers and sisters, regardless of differences in complexion," a sentiment that starkly contrasted his earlier rhetoric, where he made categorical divides between the white and black races. Importantly, X did not let his rejection of the race binary negate his belief that global systems of oppression were racialized; in speeches made after this 1964 trip, X began referring to all people of color across the world as "black," indicating his continued belief that systems of violence still separated the white race as an oppressor from every other race. Indeed, in his 1965 Oppressed Masses speech, which he delivered to the African Student Union at the London School of Economics, X argued that while being Muslim prevented him from "seeing people by the color of their skin," America does not "believe in [the] brotherhood [necessary for societal buy-in to Islam]," and thus that he must be a "realist" in his approach to deconstructing racial divide. To X, racism was a system and a logic of dominance, and being a "realist" meant seeking a way out of that system; while religious revival was one option to him, X also began to fully appreciate the power of politics as he came to see the empowerment people of African descent when not in a country like the U.S. where political systems are designed to repress them. His new engagement with on-the-ground politics

came in contrast with his earlier staunch opposition to engaging with institutions like the U.S. government that he believed were run on the power of white supremacy.

Indeed, prompted by his learning from his Africa trip, X would seek to reconcile his visionary rhetoric with real political activism. For example, in June 1964, after his return from Africa, X founded the Organization for African American Unity (OAAU), inspired by the existing Organization of African Unity (OAU) – which was enshrined in 1963 in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia, as a political union for pan-African self-government. As historian Garrett Felber explained in his essay *Harlem is the Black World*, the OAAU, in its short term goals of addressing local, community-based issues like “rallying residents against police brutality, establishing a ‘Liberation School’, offering child care and self-defense classes, and launching political education and vote registration drives,” united a “larger vision of Pan-Africanism and human rights” with X’s experience in activism at the community level.

Moreover, X’s realist politics extended to the international scale. For example, during his trip, in July 1964 in Cairo, Egypt, Malcolm argued to the delegates of thirty-four African nations that “the United States government [was] morally incapable of protecting the lives and property of 22 million Afro-Americans,” attempting - albeit unsuccessfully - to convince them to sign a UN referendum condemning the US’s domestic human rights violations in the hopes that it would prompt greater funding to community initiatives helping African Americans, demonstrating X’s belief in the geopolitical power to undo the colonial system that African states wielded should they become united.

X’s internationalist view inspired by his engagement in African politics also reshaped X’s view on the domestic civil rights movement. Beginning in 1964, X stopped referring to “civil rights,” instead choosing to advocate for “human rights.” X explained the difference in a 1965 interview: “we believe that our problem is one, not of violation of civil rights, but a violation of human rights. Not only are we denied the right to be a citizen in the United States, we’re denied the right to be a human being.” In other words, X believed that one cannot speak of civil rights before first being recognized as a human by their government. Importantly, it was his visit to Africa which inspired this shift. As fellow activist and long-time friend Yuri Kochiyama explained in a 2006 interview, X saw that “African people don’t have to wait ‘til some president of another country, [...], would give civil rights [sic]” as their governments – many of which were struggling to rid themselves of colonial influence -- viewed them as inherently entitled to such rights insofar as they had the human right to dignity, and thus that human rights were prerequisite to civil rights.

Moreover, during his interactions with African political figures to the end of con-

vincing them to sign his referendum, X demonstrated a newfound willingness to curb his own blunt radicalism to appeal to those who had the political power to help him achieve his goals. For example, speaking to Seyyid Omar al Saghaf, Saudi Arabia's Vice Minister of foreign affairs, X said that "[X was] not anti-american, un-american, seditious, nor subversive" and that "[he doesn't] buy the anti-capitalist propaganda of the communists, nor [...] the anti-communist propaganda of capitalists"; Given the radically anti-US stance X's rhetoric would reflect even in his later speeches from 1965, this interaction is likely less an indication of a shift to a moderate stance, but more an indication of his willingness to be politically adaptive given his view of anti-oppression as a political exploit instead of a purely ideological one.

Revolution is People

Equipped with a renewed and grand understanding of racial struggle at the global level, and an understanding of pan-Africanism as a tool for political change, X returned to the U.S. from his Hajj in May of 1964, after which he would produce some of rhetoric that define his legacy beyond the black nationalist ideas of his career prior to 1955. But, before then, X had a friend to make, and an important takeaway to learn: while Fidel Cas-
tro was perhaps the most politically notorious of X's acquaintances, a Japanese American Woman by the name of Yuri Kochiyama was one of equal influence on X's politics. Born in 1921 in to Middle Class Issei (first generation Japanese Immigrant) parents, Kochiyama was incensed to a life of activism during the Second World War when [her] family was forcibly relocated to a[n] [internment] camp in Arkansas, where she witnessed the capacity of a society separated based on race to dehumanize and denigrate the politically vulnerable. Throughout her life, Kochiyama advocated for nuclear disarmament (helping pass the landmark 1988 Civil Liberties Act), supported the Puerto Rican independence movement, and -- most relevantly -- joined the struggle for African American rights under the mentorship of Malcolm X. The two met in 1964 -- prior to X's departure to Mecca -- at a Congress of Racial Equality (CORE) protest in Brooklyn, during which they exchanged brief remarks about the merits and drawbacks of advocating for racial integration, sparking a letter correspondence and eventually a close friendship featuring an abundance of ideological exchange.

In various ways, this friendship strengthened X's commitment to each new aspect of his activism. First, while his experiences in Bandung and on his first tour of Africa

showed X the importance of different political groups' political unity, Kochiyama's identity demonstrated the importance of personal empathy in creating such unity. Kochiyama's recounting of the story of her realization of the prevalence of racism directed at Black Americans revealed that her empathy and sense of personal responsibility primarily incited her activism. Kochiyama had been working her first job as a waitress; she recounted:

It was the first time I'm working with just black people, mostly the waitresses, so they were women, but there were waiters, too. And I finally, I asked... two of the guys were from the South. And so I mentioned to them that I lived a year and a half in Mississippi, and at a USO which serviced everybody, but no black soldiers came in. And so they said, "What was the address?" I gave the address, I couldn't forget, 222 Pine, he said, "That's the main drag. No black soldiers, even wearing a uniform, can go in anywhere on the main drag." They could not go on Pine Street or Main Street. I was shocked. Then, for the first time, it made me think more what America was about, the segregation. Then I got really interested and wanted to find out everything I could about what black people have gone through. And it made me ashamed when I could think of Asians were just as racist as whites towards blacks, anyway. That changed me.

14

Kochiyama was the first person X had met who had little personal stake in his movement (at least superficially – Asian Americans obviously had much to gain from a less racist America, but rarely perceived this fact to be true), yet provided the unity it so needed in abundance simply because of her care for her coworkers, and for her sense of responsibility to remedy the racial attitudes of other Asian Americans; in other words, Kochiyama was living proof that care and reciprocity are the lifeblood of social movements.

In late 1964, Kochiyama and her husband hosted a reception for X to meet "atomic bomb survivors (hibakusha) who, as part of the Hiroshima-Nagasaki World Peace Mission Study, were on a walking tour of the United States, Europe, and the Soviet Union to push for nuclear disarmament."⁴² There, X, Kochiyama, and leaders from the Japanese group discussed the immorality of the "bombs of racism, [...] connecting US intervention in a non-white country with racism at home" While X had already demonstrated a concept of American racism affecting people from other countries and of different races, the only non-Americans he had been personally acquainted with were international heads of state like those he had met at Bandung. X's speaking to regular Japanese people, many of whom possessed visible and permanent injuries from surviving an atomic bomb, represented one

of the first times he had personally connected with an on-the-ground victim of the racist military industrial complex he had come to despise.

At the same meeting, Kochiyama introduced X to anti-racist activists who were not black nationalists like he had been for much of his career, including white allies, civil rights movement advocates, and Puerto Rican independence advocates. As Kochiyama recounted, “people didn’t know whether they should go up to him and ask if they could shake his hand” given how different his ideology was to theirs. However, X eventually was “wonderful to each one” and demonstrated “how glad he was to meet all these people.” This experience allowed X to consolidate on a personal level with people he would have considered political enemies as part of the NOI. Perhaps Kochiyama’s work in showing X the importance of interpersonal connection and empathy in anti-racism was part of why X focused so much on solutions to racism that targeted bettering individual communities rather than seeking to topple the racist system itself, such as the OAAU, which Kochiyama eventually joined.

Moreover, Kochiyama’s work independent of X’s mentorship served as a proof of concept for each of the lessons X had learned throughout his career, in turn reinforcing his belief that internationalism, decolonialism, and methods like community work and direct action were superior doctrines of activism than black nationalism. After her attending the OAAU’s Liberation School, “the anti-imperialist views Malcolm X had instilled in Yuri inspired her support for the Puerto Rican independence movement,” as a part of which she famously led an occupation protest at the Statue of Liberty in 1977. That Kochiyama’s political goals were superficially different from X’s, but thrived off of the same revolutionary doctrines furthered X’s resolve in said doctrines.

15

The Ballot or the Bullet

While X’s rhetoric on the dynamics of global oppression approached its final form from 1964 to 1965, he still had much to learn in the way of revolutionary politics. Specifically, through the influence of the Kenyan Mau Mau revolutionary movement, X sought to reconcile his belief violence against black folk was structural and entrenched with a revolutionary method accessible to the common person. In December 1964, X heard of the Mau Mau revolutionary group at a rally held in the Williams Institutional CME Church in Harlem, New York, where the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee’s freedom singers performed a praise of Kenyan revolutionaries’ attaining Kenya’s independence from the

British on 12 December 1963. Subsequently, X began letter correspondences with Mau Mau leaders, and began studying the history of the group. The Mau Mau were a dramatically controversial movement: while unmistakably violent and demonized by Western media, many radicals like Malcolm X praised them precisely for their revolutionary methods. In his Audubon speech, X argued that the U.S. needed “the same type of Mau Mau here that they had over in Kenya,” identifying the Mau Mau’s most valuable trait as having realized that “the only thing standing in the way of the independence of the African in Kenya was another African,” in that Africans and African Americans who supported moderate methods such as caucusing were ineffective absent greater structural change. Indeed, X echoed this sentiment in his 1964 speech *The Ballot or the Bullet*, delivered at Cory Methodist Church in Cleveland, Ohio, where he proclaimed that “You and I in America are faced not with a segregationist conspiracy, we’re faced with a government conspiracy,” arguing that to be content simply voting was not enough to engage with democracy, as neither major political party were interested in advocating for black people.

X’s proposal for methods to make such structural change was inspired by the Mau Mau, was twofold, and was eponymous with his aforementioned speech: the ballot or the bullet.

16

On one hand, X supported non-traditional voting as a way to make systematic change. Speaking at the Ford Auditorium in Detroit in April of 1965 on the OAAU’s voter education project, X announced that he hoped to become “involved in a mass voter registration drive” for black community members in Harlem, but that he did not believe in voter registration without first educating voters in “the science of politics,” specifically through independent caucusing, leveraging the vote to empower grassroots politicians and to seek control of the “politics of your own community”. Moreover, in his 1965 speech entitled *Learn How to Think*, X advocated for the OAAU’s organization of “demonstrations and picketing, but not the kind that plays by the rules of the establishment” - specifically the kind that permitted the use of the threat of violence and the occupation of spaces without permits, demonstrating X’s simultaneous belief in the power of politics and his rejection of the US’s mainstream political systems.

On the other hand, however, X was also unafraid to advocate for violent revolution, albeit with far more nuance than the self-defensive, reactionary violence the NOI had supported. In his 1964 speech entitled *The Black Revolution*, which he delivered to a three-quarters white audience at the Militant Labor Forum in New York City, he threatened that the violent struggle his “brothers and sisters in Africa [...] [and] Latin America” had

engaged in against their former colonizers was imminently approaching the U.S.. Whereas his radical advocacy of violence prior to 1955 was motivated by a simple hatred for the white race, his rhetoric in 1964 isolated the efficacy of violence in the absence of any other effective method to dismantle an oppressive system that was designed to self-perpetuate.

The Politics of True Revolution

Ultimately, perhaps one of X's final speeches before his death on February 21, 1965, delivered at the Corn Hill Methodist Church in Rochester, New York, reflected best his fully formed vision for revolution; in stark contrast with what X, as a religious fanatic in the NOI, had told Michael Wallace in the latter's documentary, he called for a global revolution, in the aftermath of which there will be "a society in which everyone can live as human beings" regardless of skin color, and where "[blacks and whites] will eventually meet down the road," demonstrating his coming to prioritize human rights at an international scale over the binary race war proposed by the NOI, and his adoption of a nuanced revolutionary method. As historian Carl Oglesby writes in his article in the *New Left Reader* entitled "I Don't Mean Bananas," "[X's] political method had presupposed [...] the unity of nationalism and radicalism" since the beginning of his career - unity which eventually evolved into one "which therefore connected Mississippi with the Congo and Africa with Asia and which understood a viable politics for black Americans to require both a demand for African Hood and a conception of pro-African Hood as an explicitly anti-imperialist stance." Malcolm X's legacy today is incredibly controversial and complex, but peeling back the layers of extremism reveals a visionary who's understanding of violence and revolution that far transcended his time. More importantly, it reveals the story of a man who taught himself to undo resentment, to broaden his perspective, and to truly consider his worldview in the face of an upbringing that taught him to hate. In a modern America, where change is driven by movements of democratic will, X's remarkable life should serve as an example of how a genuine willingness to learn can inspire the compassion and illumination that moves people.

CITATIONS

EnCarmichael, Stokely. "Stokely Carmichael Explains 'Black Power,' 1967." In *Major Problems in American History since 1945: Documents and Essays*, by Robert Griffith, 259-63. Lexington, Mass.: D.C. Heath, 1992.

Enlai, Zhou. "Main Speech by Premier Zhou Enlai, Head of the Delegation of the People's Republic of China, Distributed at the Plenary Session of the Asian-African Conference." Speech presented at Bandung Conference, Bandung, Indonesia, April 19, 1955. Wilson Center Digital Archive. Accessed March 31, 2024. <https://digitalarchive.wilson-center.org/document/main-speech-premier-zhou-enlai-head-delegation-peoples-republic-china-distributed-plenary>.

Felber, Garrett. "A Bandung Conference in Harlem: The Meaning of Castro's Visit Uptown." *Black Perspectives*. Last modified December 1, 2016. Accessed March 29, 2024. <https://www.aaihs.org/a-bandung-conference-in-harlem-the-meaning-of-castros-visit-uptown/>.

Garrett Felber. "Harlem Is the Black World: The Organization of Afro-American Unity at the Grassroots." *The Journal of African American History* 100, no. 2 (2015): 199-225. <https://doi.org/10.5323/jafriamerhist.100.2.0199>.

The Hate That Hate Produced. Produced by Michael Wallace. Aired July 13, 1956, on WNTA-TV.

Malcolm X. "Message to the Grassroots." Speech presented in Detroit, MI, 1963. *Black Past*. Last modified August 16, 2010. Accessed March 26, 2024. <https://www.blackpast.org/african-american-history/speeches-african-american-history/1963-malcolm-x-message-grassroots/>.

Malcolm X and Fidel Castro greet each other upon meeting in New York City. Photograph. The Harlem Neighborhood Block Association. January 25, 2021. Accessed April 15, 2024. <https://hnba.nyc/10-days-in-harlem/>.

CITATIONS

Marable, Manning. "Becoming 'X.'" In *Malcolm X: A Life of Reinvention*. New York: Viking, 2011.

Clark, Steve. "In The Struggle for Dignity." In *February 1965: The Final Speeches*, by Malcolm X and Steve Clark. New York: Pathfinder, 1992.

Marable, Manning. *Living Black History: How Reimagining the African-American past Can Remake America's Racial Future*. New York: Basic Civitas, 2006.

Markle, Seth M. "Brother Malcolm, Comrade Babu: Black Internationalism and the Politics of Friendship." *Biography* 36, no. 3 (2013): 540-67. JSTOR.

Mickie Mwanzia Koster. "Malcolm X, the Mau Mau, and Kenya's New Revolutionaries: A Legacy of Transnationalism." *The Journal of African American History* 100, no. 2 (2015): 250-71. <https://doi.org/10.5323/jafriamerhist.100.2.0250>.

19

Nehru, Jawaharlal. "Prime Minister Nehru: Speech to Bandung Conference Political Committee, 1955." Speech presented at Bandung Conference, Bandung, Indonesia, 1956. *Internet Modern History Sourcebook*. Accessed March 31, 2024. <https://origin-rh.web.fordham.edu/halsall/mod/1955nehru-bandung2.asp>.

New-York Historical Society. "Life Story: Yuri Kochiyama (1921–2014)." *Women and the American Story*. Accessed June 30, 2024. <https://wams.nyhistory.org/end-of-the-twentieth-century/a-conservative-turn/yuri-kochiyama/>.

Oglesby, Carl. "I Don't Mean Bananas." In *The New Left Reader*. New York: Grove Press, 1969. Accessed April 1, 2024. https://platypus1917.org/wp-content/uploads/Malcolm-X-_I-Don_t-Mean-Bananas_.pdf.

Phelan, Joe. "Malcolm X: A Radical Vision for Civil Rights." EdSitement. Last modified May 5, 2017. Accessed April 4, 2024. <https://edsitement.neh.gov/closer-readings/malcolm-x-radical-vision-civil-rights>.

CITATIONS

Seidman, Sarah. "Yuri Kochiyama and Malcolm X." Museum of the City of New York. Last modified February 22, 2022. Accessed June 30, 2024. <https://www.mcny.org/story/malcolmx-and-yuri-kochiyama>.

Sukarno. "Address given by Sukarno." Speech presented at Bandung Conference, Bandung, Indonesia, April 18, 1955. Centre virtuel de la connaissance sur l'Europe. Accessed March 31, 2024. https://www.cvce.eu/en/obj/opening_address_given_by_sukarno_bandung_18_april_1955-en-88d3f71c-c9f9-415a-b397-b27b8581a4f5.html.

"Timeline of Malcolm X's Life." PBS. Accessed March 29, 2024. <https://www.pbs.org/wgbh/americanexperience/features/malcolmx-timeline-malcolm-xs-life/>.

"Appeal to African Heads of State." In *Malcolm X Speaks: Selected Speeches and Statements*, by Malcolm X and George Breitman. New York: Grove Weidenfeld, 1990. https://edisciplinas.usp.br/pluginfile.php/531360/mod_resource/content/1/Malcolm_X_Speaks.pdf.

"At the Audubon." 1964. In *Malcolm X Speaks: Selected Speeches and Statements*, by Malcolm X and George Breitman. New York: Grove Weidenfeld, 1990. https://edisciplinas.usp.br/pluginfile.php/531360/mod_resource/content/1/Malcolm_X_Speaks.pdf.

"The Ballot or the Bullet." Speech presented in Cleveland, OH, April 3, 1964. Social Justice Speeches. Accessed March 31, 2024. http://www.edchange.org/multicultural/speeches/malcolm_x_ballot.html.

"THE BLACK REVOLUTION." In *Malcolm X Speaks: Selected Speeches and Statements*, by Malcolm X and George Breitman. New York: Grove Weidenfeld, 1990. https://edisciplinas.usp.br/pluginfile.php/531360/mod_resource/content/1/Malcolm_X_Speaks.pdf.

CITATIONS

“The Fight Against Racism from South Africa to Australia to the USA.” In February 1965: The Final Speeches, by Malcolm X and Steve Clark. New York: Pathfinder, 1992.

“A Global Rebellion of the Oppressed Against the Oppressor.” In February 1965: The Final Speeches, by Malcolm X and Steve Clark. New York: Pathfinder, 1992.

“The Hate that Hate Produced.” In Malcolm X: A Life of Reinvention, by Manning Marable. New York: Viking, 2011.

“The Importance of Unity.” In February 1965: The Final Speeches, by Malcolm X and Steve Clark. New York: Pathfinder, 1992.

“Learn How to Think.” In February 1965: The Final Speeches, by Malcolm X and Steve Clark. New York: Pathfinder, 1992.

“Letters from Abroad.” In Malcolm X Speaks: Selected Speeches and Statements, by Malcolm X and George Breitman. New York: Grove Weidenfeld, 1990. https://edisisciplinas.usp.br/pluginfile.php/531360/mod_resource/content/1/Malcolm_X_Speaks.pdf.

21

Letter to M.S. Handler, “THE PILGRIMAGE TO MAKKAH,” April 26, 1964. Accessed March 29, 2024. <https://islam.uga.edu/malcomx.html>.

“Malcolm X’s Speech After the Firebombing.” Speech presented at Ford Auditorium, Detroit, MI, February 14, 1965. <https://www.icit-digital.org/articles/malcolm-x-s-speech-after-the-firebombing-feb-14-1965>.

Malcolm X on Front Page Challenge, 1965: CBC Archives | CBC. Youtube, 1965. Accessed April 1, 2024. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=C7IJ7npTYrU>.

May 5, 1962 - Malcolm X Speaks at Funeral of Ronald Stokes in L.A. Youtube, 1962. Accessed April 1, 2024. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=D-Da4b1HF6k>.

CITATIONS

“Not Just an American Problem but a World Problem.” In *February 1965: The Final Speeches*, by Malcolm X and Steve Clark. New York: Pathfinder, 1992.

“The Oppressed Masses of the World Cry out for Action Against the Common Oppressor.” In *February 1965: The Final Speeches*, by Malcolm X and Steve Clark. New York: Pathfinder, 1992.

“Time is on the side of the Africans against Exploitation and Oppression.” In *February 1965: The Final Speeches*, by Malcolm X and Steve Clark. New York: Pathfinder, 1992.

“The Worst Human Being is One Who Judges Another By the Color of His Skin.” In *February 1965: The Final Speeches*, by Malcolm X and Steve Clark. New York: Pathfinder, 1992.

22 “Zionist Logic.” *Egyptian Gazette*, May 2005, vol 4. No. 5 edition. https://www.marxists.org/history/etol/newspape/socialist-viewpoint-us/mayjun_05/mayjun_05_21.htm.

“Yuri Kochiyama.” National Park Service. Accessed June 30, 2024. <https://www.nps.gov/people/yuri-kochiyama.htm>.

“Yuri Kochiyama remembers first becoming aware of racism directed at African Americans.” Video. Densho Encyclopedia (denshovh-kyuri-01-0011).

“Yuri Kochiyama Remembers Malcolm X’s Assassination & Living at WWII Japanese American Detention Camp.” Video. Democracy Now. February 21, 2006. Accessed June 30, 2024. https://www.democracynow.org/2006/2/21/civil_rights_activist_yuri_kochiyama_remembers.

Zhou, Enlai, and Jawaharlal Nehru. “Minutes of the First Meeting between Premier Zhou Enlai and Nehru.” Conference session at Bandung Conference, Bandung, Indonesia, October 19, 1954. Accessed March 29, 2024. <https://digitalarchive.wilsoncenter.org/document/minutes-first-meeting-between-premier-zhou-enlai-and-nehru>.

THE AMERICAN CIVIL WAR WAS NOT A REVOLUTION

MOLLY O'BRIEN

Milton Academy '26

On December 20, 1860, South Carolina seceded from the United States after the election of Abraham Lincoln. Throughout the following months, six states joined South Carolina in secession. In February of 1861, the Southern states created an organized government in Alabama where Jefferson Davis was named president. The states created the Confederate Constitution, similar to the United States Constitution. On April 12, 1861, the Confederate troops fired on the Union-backed Fort Sumter in Charleston Harbor in South Carolina, marking the official start of the American Civil War. Over the following four years, the Union troops made their way into the Southern States, destroying communities along the way. Over 600,000 Americans lost their lives fighting on both sides of the conflict. Following the fall of the Confederate capital of Richmond, Southern General Robert. E Lee surrendered to General Ulysses. S Grant on April 9th, 1865 in Appomattox, Virginia. Historical evidence suggests that the American Civil War and Reconstruction were not a revolution because it was a continuation of the issue of slavery plaguing the country since the American Revolution. Additionally, the Civil War and Reconstruction focused on preserving the union, not fundamentally changing the structure of the government. Furthermore, the lack of a revolution allowed the United States government to remain largely intact post-war.

23

The Civil War was a continuation of the argument of slavery that had bedeviled society since the country's founding. When the founding fathers neglected to make a concrete decision on the issue of slavery, they set the roots of the Civil War in motion. In its Ordinance of Secession and Declaration of Independence, South Carolina referenced the

ongoing battle over slavery as one of the primary reasons for its secession. The document states "For twenty-five years this agitation [the Fugitive Slave Act] has been steadily increasing until it has now secured its aid and the power of the common government." (FTR 406) The issue of slavery had created a divide between the North and the South since the Constitution's ratification. The Southern states believed that their country had turned its back on them because the Fugitive Slave Act was not being upheld in the North. Additionally, the South Carolinians thought that with the election of Lincoln, their pro-slavery cause would be destroyed. Slavery, while not the only cause of the Civil War, was a root cause of the Southern secession. Since the signing of the Constitution, Southern states had been concerned about the North's handling of slavery. South Carolina waited to sign the constitution because they did not believe the right to own slaves would be protected. The country's official war on slavery was not fought until the 1860s, but a silent conflict had plagued the country since its founding. Abolitionist Frederick Douglass elaborated on the idea of slavery division increasing across the decades. In his *The Reasons for Our Troubles*, Douglass says that the worst of slavery is "in the character which contact with slavery has developed in every part of the country so that at least there seems to be no truth." (FTR 413) Douglass acknowledged that slavery had become a bigger issue than imagined. The country had suppressed the problem for too many years prior to the Civil War. When Lincoln took office, he knew that making any changes to slavery would hurt his cause. In his first inaugural address, Lincoln reassured Southern slaveholders that he would not take away their slave-owning rights. He stated, "I have no purpose, directly or indirectly, to interfere with the institution of slavery in the States where it exists." (Lincoln) Lincoln intended to settle fears that had existed since the time of his election. He was the first anti-slavery president, which threatened the Southern States. The fear of a slavery intervention had existed long before Lincoln. Southerners felt that the danger to the institution of slavery had started long before Lincoln came to power. The founding father's lack of a plan, when it came to the system of slavery, can be directly traced to the start of the war.

The Civil War was focused on preserving the Union, not fundamentally changing the system of government. In a speech to the Illinois Republican State Convention in Springfield in 1858, Lincoln referenced the Union's need to stay unified, saying "A house divided against itself cannot stand." (Lincoln) Lincoln realized the country could not hold together as half free and half slave. He desired a unified country, where one issue did not divide a nation. The divided house would only stand when a compromise was made. Lincoln did not expect that the government would fall. He continued in his speech, saying "I do not

expect the Union to be dissolved - I do not expect the house to fall.” (Lincoln) Throughout the war, Lincoln’s primary goal was to keep the Union intact. He did not believe that the war was a revolution because the Southern States had not left the union. Lincoln viewed the country as fractured, not broken. In a letter to Horace Greeley, founding editor of the New York Tribune, Lincoln said of the Civil War on August 22, 1862, “I would save the Union. I would save it the shortest way under the Constitution. The sooner the national authority is restored; the nearer the Union will be “the Union as it was.” Lincoln believed that restoring the Union was the primary objective of the war. The strong belief that the Civil War was not a revolution, and instead a rebellion, led Lincoln to believe that the country’s reunion was inevitable. Furthermore, he did not think that the South seceded from the union, but instead were rebels that needed control. Andrew Johnson of Tennessee, Lincoln’s Vice President, sought out similar views of union preservation. He stated in an interview with Major General John A Logan in May 1865, that “there is no such thing as reconstruction. These States have not gone out of the Union, therefore reconstruction is unnecessary.” Johnson viewed the Southerners as a ‘rebellion,’ rather than a revolution. He strongly believed that the idea of reconstruction was unnecessary because the union had never been broken. Johnson thought that the Southerners were never an independent nation like they had claimed. His belief in the preservation of the Union highlighted the forefront of the fighting during the Civil War.

25

The lack of revolution in the Southern States allowed the government to remain intact during the Civil War and into reconstruction. On December 20, 1860, the Senate established a “Committee of Thirteen” to examine plans to save the fractured union, after South Carolina’s secession. On January 9, 1861, Mississippi seceded. The act prompted Jefferson Davis to address the Senate, urging his fellow representatives to allow a peaceful succession for the South. On January 21, 1861, five senators from Florida, Alabama, and Mississippi left the Senate. The withdrawal of Southern representatives created a constitutional crisis. The remaining senators voted to take away the seats of their Southern colleagues. Despite the crisis in the Senate, Congress continued its legislative work while dealing with the economic consequences of the war. For example, they sponsored bills like the Revenue Act (1861), which established the first federal income tax to provide additional funding for the war effort. Before the end of the Civil War, Congress had prepared for a Union victory. On July 2, 1864, Congress passed the Wade-Davis Bill to provide representation to the ‘rebel’ states upon meeting certain conditions, such as giving black men the right to vote. In 1867, Congress passed the Reconstruction Act, formally establishing

the terms of admission and a formal reconstruction. The act stated that each state must write a new constitution and be approved by the majority of their voters, including black men. Each state was also required to ratify the thirteenth and fourteenth amendments. On June 22, 1868, the addition of the Confederate states began with Arkansas, formally beginning Reconstruction. The Southern states were able to be admitted because the North viewed the war as a rebellion, not a revolution.

CITATIONS

"Abraham Lincoln Elected President, Part III: Overcoming Adversaries and Preserving the Union." National Portrait Gallery. Accessed October 16, 2024. <https://npg.si.edu/blog/abraham-lincoln-elected-president-part-iii-overcoming-adversaries-and-preserving-union#:~:text=I%20would%20save%20the%20Union,do%20not%20agree%20with%20the.>

"The Civil War Senate Reacts to Secession." United States Senate. Accessed October 16, 2024. https://www.senate.gov/about/powers-procedures/expulsion/CivilWar_Expulsion.htm.

"The Civil War: The Senate's Story." United States Senate. Accessed October 16, 2024. https://www.senate.gov/artandhistory/history/common/civil_war/SenatesWorkContinues.htm.

"1861 Timeline of the Civil War." Library of Congress. Accessed October 16, 2024. <https://www.loc.gov/collections/civil-war-glass-negatives/articles-and-essays/time-line-of-the-civil-war/1861/#:~:text=The%20session%20of%20South%20Carolina,the%20Confederate%20States%20of%20America.>

United States Senate. Accessed October 16, 2024. https://www.senate.gov/artandhistory/history/common/civil_war/VictoryTragedyReconstruction.htm.

U.S. Dept. of the Interior. "Andrew Johnson and Reconstruction." NPS. Last modified January 9, 2024. <https://www.nps.gov/anjo/andrew-johnson-and-reconstruction.htm#:~:text=Andrew%20Johnson's%20view%20C%20as%20stated,sending%20representatives%20back%20to%20Washington.>

"Mississippi Secession." NPS. Last modified December 11, 2019. <https://www.nps.gov/articles/ms-secession.htm#:~:text=Mississippi%20seceded%20from%20the%20United,-to%20tell%20the%20world%20why.>

CITATIONS

“South Carolina Secession.” NPS. Last modified February 17, 2024. <https://www.nps.gov/articles/000/south-carolina-secession.htm#:~:text=South%20Carolina%20became%20the%20first,disunion%20across%20the%20slaveholding%20South.>

Zeller, Bob. “How Many Died in the American Civil War?” History.com. Last modified January 6, 2022. Accessed October 16, 2024. [https://www.history.com/news/american-civil-war-deaths.](https://www.history.com/news/american-civil-war-deaths)

JEFFERSONIAN VS LINCOLNIAN IDEALS

The Southern Fear of Equality During Reconstruction

HENRY MANNINO

Milton Academy '26

In the founding of America, the Jeffersonian vision of a country for white men was established. In practice, slavery secured this vision as it allowed white plantation owners to own the men who could rival their power. In abolishing slavery, however, Abraham Lincoln granted equal opportunity and liberty to the enslaved; thereby, in the eyes of many white businessmen, contesting the power of the white man. The formerly enslaved had longed for equal opportunity and so upon achieving it, they quickly worked their way up in society: During Reconstruction around 2,000 black Americans held public office, including 16 seats in Congress. (The Conversation) This further cemented the concerns of the white businessman; and so, many white extremists felt that they had to halt this progress while they still could. Through methods like sharecropping and the black codes, as well as through the use of incredible violence to secure those systems, black Americans were oppressed, and ultimately were blocked from achieving their dream of freely working and independently living. Their dreams of economic freedom having been ruined created a need for a civil rights movement rooted in equal opportunity, not in seeking reparations.

29

One fear of many whites during Reconstruction was that a newfound influx of available black labor would take black people away from plantations and lead them to other “white jobs.” If black people were no longer working on plantations, the plantation owners would lose labor and black people would begin to work elsewhere, taking up spots previously reserved for whites. To combat this, accessing education was made incredibly difficult. The Union as It Was, a political cartoon created in 1874, accurately depicts a burnt-down schoolhouse to the right of a lynched black man. The image, thereby, directly correlates a black child attending school to the consequence of their being lynched. Formerly enslaved people, through not having an education, were encouraged to work in

sharecropping. They were enticed by their having already mastered picking cotton, as well as the lack of job opportunities available without having an education. In sharecropping, the plantation owner has incredible power over the laborer, and the laborer has little control over their work (a relationship not dissimilar to that of an enslaver and the enslaved). As Henry Blake, a freedman who had taken to sharecropping in the early 20th century, explains, “No matter how good account you kept, you had to go by [the plantation owners] account” (Henry Blake) The lack of education in planters allowed whites to once again regain control over black laborers. By taking advantage of their heightened education, white men were able to take not only their cut of the profit made from cotton but also part of the cropper’s cut. Along with having to buy the tools necessary, the seeds to plant, and the necessities to sustain their family, planters had to also split their pay with others. In addition to their incredibly small income, which Blake later describes as only being enough to buy overalls and food, croppers had no guarantee of when they would ever receive their income. Plantation owners would take “a portion of every cropper’s part of the cotton to be made by [the plantation owner] when and where [he] chose to sell” (FTR 39 A Sharecroppers Contract) In having the right to take cotton made by planters and sell when and where he chooses, the plantation owner secures authority over the planters; the product is thereby not private. Through having their money taken, and their business controlled, the formerly enslaved were working under conditions not dissimilar to those of enslavement. Their dreams of economic freedom and of the ability to own private property were halted as they lived and worked on somebody else’s land, did not have control over their business, had to split their income, and had to live in subservience to a white overseer. It is therefore quite perplexing that the formerly enslaved would choose to continue under such conditions, though it is simply due to an inability to leave. Planters would amass such incredible debt that they could not find new employment.

Another way the newly freed black Americans were prevented from realizing their dream of economic freedom was through arrests and violence. The aforementioned Black Codes were a set of laws originating from the Mississippi that spread across the United States and focused on suppressing black freedmen. The Black Codes state in Section 2 of Vagrant Law that “all freedmen, free Negroes, and mulattoes in this state over the age of eighteen years found . . . with no lawful employment or business...[will be] imprisoned at the discretion of the court.” (The Black Codes) This clause made unemployment illegal and whilst prison time would be short, one could be re-imprisoned upon not regaining employment. Due to the 13th Amendment, slave-like servitude was permitted within

these prisons. This meant that being imprisoned included returning to a slave-like status, once again sacrificing one's economic freedoms; one had no way of achieving economic freedom if they were incarcerated and working for free. Much like a slave, they would live underneath the wardens, have no private possessions, and work hours of labor for free. Furthermore, many would be unjustly imprisoned under false pretenses as there was an incredible incentive for white people -especially those of lower income- to lock up black Americans: free labor makes greater profit for companies and cheaper goods for consumers. Not only did extremist whites use imprisonment as a means to oppress black people, extremist groups would enact terrorism as a fear-mongering and suppression tactic. In the testimony of Harriet Postle, it is noted that the horrific and violent acts committed towards her by the KKK were done in search of her husband. In looking for him, the KKK asked her if she "knew where [her] husband [was]" (Testimony of Harriet Postle) before attacking her and her kids for lying in regard to his supposed whereabouts. The KKK would break into homes and attack those living there, as a means to exert power over blacks, and cement their superiority: if a white man could at any time break into one's home and murder his kids, black people had plenty of incentive to do as he wished. The Klan wished all members to be "opposed to negro equality...[and support] re-enfranchisement...of the white man" (Organization and Principles of the Ku Klux Klan) Through placing white Americans as disenfranchised, and black equality as negative, many were led to believe that blacks must be killed or be returned to subservience to secure white power. Furthermore, when the white man's situation was described as so dire, people were incentivized to act quickly and to disenfranchise blacks by any means necessary. Afterward, thousands of Klansmen took to the streets to suppress the enfranchisement of black people. The subsequent fear of violence caused many black people not to chase their dream of economic and political enfranchisement as it could lead to Klansmen harming them and their families. Furthermore, in the eyes and words of the KKK, the only way in which peace can be achieved is through a return to inequality. The problem is that the ideas of the KKK and the dreams of the formerly enslaved people are mutually exclusive: whites can't be in complete power while blacks have equality. Additionally, due to the vague phrasing of the constitution, both of their arguments could be bent to have a constitutional basis and so they both feel entitled to their desired destiny.

31

Ultimately, the dreams of black Americans during Reconstruction, while they aligned with what Lincoln had promised them, were not awarded by society. While on paper, black Americans had equal economic opportunity as their white counterparts, in

practice this was not the case. Black people were blocked from education and forced into slave-like conditions in sharecropping and imprisonment. Furthermore, they were forced into inferiority and subservience by their jobs and by extremist groups such as the KKK. In modern times, a discussion of why reparations were not awarded to formerly enslaved people in reconstruction, or to their relatives after the 1960s civil rights movement, has become increasingly popular. In reconstruction, reparations were economically dubious and would not be agreed to by those who would owe -in the case of reconstruction, the South. With the fear of the inability to reform and rebuild the Union, the reparations policy was not implemented. Similar reasoning to the latter is often the response by many to the question of why the 1960s civil rights movements did not secure reparations. While appeasement politics did play a part in reparations not being granted, the more relevant reason they were not awarded is that reparations were not wanted by any Black Americans. Martin Luther King Jr, a prominent voice in the civil rights movement, explained in his 1967 book *Where We Go From Here* that “No amount of gold could provide an adequate compensation for the exploitation and humiliation of the Negro in America down through the centuries.” (King *Where We Go From Here*) It was not money which the disenfranchised black Americans wished for, but equal economic opportunity. They did not wish to be saved by the charity of white handouts, nor did they wish to continue reliance upon government programs, Black Americans wanted the ability to make their own money. They had trusted white Americans to control their post-slavery reconstruction, through subsidies and other attempted aid, but instead were granted further inferiority and similar economic situations to before reconstruction. Furthermore, reparations are a temporary solution, whereas economic equality is a permanent solution. Being paid a sum of money, but not being allowed the means to fairly amass wealth, means that future generations would face disenfranchisement and poverty. This idea ties to the cliché proverb of teaching a man to fish. If reparations are granted, then the generation they are given to may be granted moderate wealth; though, if economic freedom is awarded, future generations will all be able to secure economic prosperity. Through being simply granted economic freedom, black Americans can finally secure their Lincolnian dream, and create an America which is for them as well as others.

CITATIONS

The Conversation

Henry Blake

For The Record - A Sharecroppers Contract

The Black Codes

The Testimony of Harriet Postle

Organazation and Principles of the Ku Klux Klan

Martin Luther King - Where We Go From Here

“KEEP THEM IN THE CLOSET”

Lesbian Involvement in Second-Wave Feminism, Queer Advocacy, and the Fight against HIV/AIDS

RHYS ADAMS

Milton Academy '26

34

Queer agitators intended for the 1968 Stonewall Riots to harken the beginning of the end of homosexual silence. Activists hoped for the death of the old orthodoxy that gay people were to hide deep within the closets of their own shame. Although the male leaders of the gay rights movement sought to push their own out of the closet, they simultaneously, through dominance and ignorance, pushed their lesbian peers into the shadows. The lesbian rights movement spent the rest of the 20th century searching for its place in a society that reviled lesbians at every level for their gender and sexuality alike. Going from being second-wave feminists to female separatists to radical leftists, lesbians consistently missed out on the visibility and openness supposedly promised by Stonewall. Gay women in America did not receive this respect until the crucible for the queer community that was the AIDS crisis. From 1971 to 1992, the lesbian community underwent a gradual socio-cultural migration from homosexuals within the women's movement to women within the gay movement, setting the stage for a united queer front against the AIDS crisis. Both gay men and straight women spurned lesbian voices within their movements, but the equal footing between lesbians and gay men provided by the AIDS crisis allowed for the birth of a unified queer movement.

In 20th-century queer history, the disjunction of gay men and lesbians was an anomaly. Since the 1920s, the two groups depended on one another for beards, a form of social insurance against homophobia that kept gay men and lesbians in close quarters for the better part of the 20th Century, especially during the “Lavender Scare” of 1950-1956, during which suspected homosexuals were expelled en masse from government jobs at the behest of anti-communist moral crusader Senator Joe McCarthy. Moreover, in 1956,

America's first lesbian rights association, the Daughters of Bilitis, received funds from the era's leading gay male activist group, the Mattachine Society, to publish *The Ladder*, a lesbian advocacy magazine. Additionally, the radical activism of the 1960s brought gay men and lesbians together under the common cause of "free love"; most politically-involved openly queer Americans, then called "homophiles," leaned heavily to the left, and the queer activist space was able to mostly unite in favor of Black civil rights and against US involvement in the Vietnam War. This integration, however, masked profound internal schisms within the queer community. The eventual political isolation of lesbians, part defection and part ostracism exemplifies the extent to which few 20th century movements accommodate intersectionality. Two societal overtones prompted the collapse of gay-male/lesbian concord in the years following the Stonewall Riots of 1969: sexism and feminism, a push and a pull factor respectively.

Gay male misogyny in the late sixties incited antipathy with lesbians. A year before the Stonewall Riots, radical feminist Valerie Solanas, whose writings encouraged women (perhaps ironically) to "destroy the male sex," attempted to assassinate the gay pop artist Andy Warhol, leaving behind a menstrual pad at the scene of the shooting. Other radical feminists interpreted this attack as a protest against the casual misogyny and entitlement of bourgeois gay men like Warhol. This tension came to a head on August 26th, 1970, when the Daughters of Bilitis and associated lesbian groups protested a general meeting of the North American Conference of Homophile Organizations (NACHO) held on the same day as the National Women's Strike. Lesbian feminist Del Martin recounted the rumpus at the conference in a pamphlet entitled *If That's All There Is*: "They [gay men] decried the segregationist organizations which we represented, but would not address...the underlying reason for...separate women's organizations — that the female homosexual faces sex discrimination not only in the heterosexual world, but within the homophile community." By "segregationist" Martin referred to the rising tide of "lesbian separatism," an ideology that advocated the decoupling of lesbian life from all-male society, heterosexual and homosexual alike, and sometimes, more radically, from straight women's spaces as well. Most separatists did not adopt such an anti-straight-women bent, as mere separation from men was more compelling due to the fear of male violence. Working alongside straight women did not offend lesbians, emphasizing the pull factor that stopped the gay-male/lesbian coalition from making it out of the sixties—lesbian involvement in second-wave feminism.

Around the turn of the 1970s, lesbian activists manifested their discontent by becoming second-wave feminist foot soldiers. Concrete policy achievements like the Equal

Pay Act in 1963 and the promulgation of battered women's shelters around 1968 gave feminism more mainstream credibility than ever, especially with upper-middle-class straight White women who may have been otherwise wary of the radical, sex-positive youth movements that defined the decade. Lesbians saw straight feminists as a more widely tolerated group than gay men, and in the early seventies, second-wave feminists were amenable to National Organization for Women (NOW), the seventies' most influential feminist group, "adopt[ed] a resolution declaring lesbian rights a 'legitimate concern of feminism,'" although historian Diane Perrault posits that this resolution included a stealthily homophobic caveat: the "plank...was euphemistically entitled 'sexual Preference,' with the word 'lesbian' carefully avoided, reflecting the emphasis on sexual orientation as a choice." Despite these latent conservative elements of the movement, most lesbian activists migrated into mid- to high-level roles within mainstream feminist organizations. Compounded with elevated frustration over gay male sexism, the allure of mainstream feminism harkened the end of the united queer front and largely dissociated lesbians from their male counterparts. Queer historian and postmodernist philosopher John D'Emilio labels this period "the gendered seventies," emphasizing that lesbian and gay male neighborhoods grew farther away from one another throughout the decade. Dr. Emily Hobson, a sexuality scholar, challenges the "gendered seventies" framework in her book *Lavender and Red: Liberation and Solidarity in the Gay and Lesbian Left*, but the only examples of gay-male/lesbian solidarity she cites in between the Stonewall Riots and the AIDS crisis are immigrant communities, who united for other reasons, and the White Night Riots, which took place in San Francisco, a notable exception to the physical segregation of gay and lesbian neighborhoods. Elsewhere in America, according to lesbian AIDS activist Torie Osborn in a 2011 interview, "lesbian-feminists created new woman-identified spaces in the public sphere where they could congregate, organize, and socialize. Women-centered coffee shops, bars, clubs, restaurants, bookstores, sports teams, parks, health clinics, and shelters popped up... during the second boom of feminism, in large part due to...lesbian feminists."

Problematically, however, these lesbian feminists had joined a movement plagued with a fundamental ideological divide between radical and liberal feminism. Gender history professor Martha Rampton believes the second wave represented "an effort to demonstrate that race, class, and gender oppression are all related," illustrating the continuation of sixties radicalism present across feminist thought. Conversely, legal scholar Rachel Moran argues in the *Hofstra Law Review* in 2004 that "second-wave feminism forgot the single woman" and focused too heavily on merely tweaking patriarchal institutions like

marriage and capitalism. In many ways, the ideological rift present within feminism at the time formed a hole that was jarringly lesbian-shaped. Social historian Christine Bedikian believes that female homosexuality is the answer to some intra-feminist tensions: "If society as a whole is being dependent on male culture to define and control the definition of a lesbian, no woman can really be free. Heterosexual male culture should not be able to define womanhood." Of course, many straight feminists objected at the time to identifying with lesbians. At a NOW conference in 1969, Betty Friedan, the group's founder, called lesbian activists a "lavender menace," asserting "that outspoken lesbians were a threat to the feminist movement." Friedan partially retreated from this rhetoric during the 1970-71 lesbian migration into the mainstream women's movement and ended up working alongside NACHO dissenter Del Martin and her partner Phyllis Lyon, the first lesbian couple elected into leadership positions at NOW, but dissatisfaction with lesbians never truly vacated second-wave feminist organizations. Bedikian argues that lesbians were "blatantly discriminated against and excluded from the women's liberation movement" even after Friedan's backpedaling. National leadership may have tolerated lesbians during the "gendered seventies," but lower-level advocacy groups broadly failed to make the same shift. In fact, when "sexual preference" came to the table at national women's caucuses in 1976, the Mississippi delegation hoisted banners bearing a less-than-liberationist slogan: "KEEP THEM IN THE CLOSET." Much of this backlash was a continuation of straight feminists' distaste at being compared to lesbians. In its seminal 1970 manifesto *The Woman-Identified Woman*, queer agitation group Radicalesbians derided liberal feminists' skittishness to join arms with their lesbian sisters: "[a]s long as the label 'dyke' can be used to frighten women into a less militant stand...keep her from giving primacy to anything other than men and family—then to that extent she is controlled by the male culture." This self-identification crisis, however dormant amongst the top brass at NOW and its contemporaries, propelled much of the eventual lesbophobia that would come to haunt liberal feminists. Even so, lesbians won several foundational feminist victories during the seventies, Unfortunately for mainstream feminism's new footsoldiers, the return of "family values" on the right and "assimilation" at the center did not spare the women's movement. According to lesbian feminist Jill Johnston in a 1982 reflection on her experiences within second-wave feminism, the "politics of assimilation has dominated feminism since 1975," a reframing that inspired liberal feminists to turn their backs on lesbians. This pivot especially affected upper-middle-class straight White women, who, by the middle of the decade, had arguably consummated the (admittedly meager) goals they had set: no-fault divorce and credit in-

dependence aided intramarital balance, and the Equal Pay Act brought American women closer than ever to respect in offices. Accordingly, the question remained: why would upper-middle-class women resign themselves to victimhood when they could maintain their power as mothers, as community leaders, and as otherwise privileged Americans? Many would argue that their fight was not over or that such a perspective disregarded doubly oppressed women, but White women by and large had made their decision: the group swung 18 points rightward from the 1976 to 1984 Presidential Elections while their Black female counterparts swung emphatically leftward. A turning point for increased reactionary sentiment among White feminists came at the 1977 National Women's Conference.

38 Federally funded under executive order by Jimmy Carter, the NWC sought to draw up 26 "planks," suggested feminist federal and state policy reforms. The hot ticket item was Plank #11, the Equal Rights Amendment; conference organizers thought the convention could galvanize public support for the constitutional sex-nondiscrimination edict, which required ratification from only three more state legislatures. The amendment never passed, the event's traction being mostly filched by the "Pro-Family Rally," antifeminist Phyllis Schlafly's counter-event held just sixteen miles across Houston on the second day of the NWC. The Pro-Family's keynote speakers, Schlafly and Republican Congressman Bob Dornan, attacked "lesbian privileges" and "sexual perversion" respectively in their responses to the NWC, and many liberal feminists blamed Plank #23 for Schlafly's outmaneuvering, many even siding with Schlafly. In the coming years, Schlafly's ideas about lesbians would become a powerful tool for pulling women rightwards.

This ideology of fear drove White women's repatriation into the Republican Party circa 1980. As gender theorist Andrea Dworkin describes in her 1983 book *Right Wing Women*, "[t]he only dignity and value women get is as mothers...[w]ithout [motherhood], women know they have nothing. Homosexuality for women means having nothing." This urge to cling to the lone vestige of social power for traditional women motivated much of Schlafly's activism as well: she described the Equal Rights Amendment as "depriv[ing] wives and mother of [their] rights," as it would allegedly obliterate motherhood by eroding heterosexual marriage. Additionally, the sublimation of women's fear of male violence onto passive lesbian subjects resolved some psychological discord many conservative or moderate women felt about the men closest to them. "For women, the world is a very dangerous place," Dworkin points out, "the Right then manipulates the fear". Intimate partner violence, especially against housewives, peaked in the 1980s. However, if leaving an abusive husband meant renouncing the role of homemaker, the only traditional archetype

that validated women's personhood, then the fear of domestic violence was displaced onto a foreign body. During the Reagan Revolution, that body was lesbians. Dworkin attended the NWC and recalled how "Right-wing women consistently spoke to [her] about lesbians as if lesbians were rapists... [of] women and girls... She [the lesbian] was the dangerous intruder, encroaching, threatening by her very presence a sexual order that cannot bear scrutiny or withstand change." The rehabilitators' "family values" during the late seventies and early eighties manipulated the genuine dual threats of patriarchal sidelining and male violence into reactionary hatred for "lesbian privilege" and "lesbian rapists."

As a new conservative dawn broke over America, lesbians found themselves increasingly politically homeless. Spurned by the people for whom they had fought the hardest and self-segregated from their gay male opposites, lesbians could no longer rely on self-sufficient separatist communities, either. Lilian Faderman explains in her 1992 article "The Return of Butch and Femme," that "The 1980s gave birth to new attitudes toward butch/femme relationships among many lesbian radicals," attitudes that more closely resembled the gritty "cruising culture" of the era's gay men, a far cry from the egalitarian, polyamorous love Faderman found so endemic in the seventies. Separatism was on the wane at the same time as the lesbian community's traditional allies were nowhere to be found, so gay women arrived at a profound internal crisis that Jill Johnston called a period of "weak...lesbian identity." During this cultural exile, the most important queer issue of the late 20th century appeared in the United States: HIV/AIDS.

The AIDS epidemic ravaged the gay community, killing 100,777 Americans, mostly queer men, between 1981 and 1990 and hundreds of thousands more in the following decade. The Reagan administration laughed off the plague, and when AIDS patients protested the federal government for access to healthcare in 1987, "[p]olice carried out rough assaults and expressed disgust for people with AIDS by wearing bright-yellow rubber gloves," signifying the level of popular contempt HIV+ people faced at the time. Lesbians, however, defied this stigma by stepping up to operate gay men's health centers at a time of rampant medical discrimination and to form joint gay/lesbian AIDS advocacy groups after over ten years of separation, helping found the AIDS Coalition To Unleash Power (ACT UP), the most prominent American queer political group of the 1990s.

Historians have contended that gay men welcomed their lesbian guardian angels with open arms. This analysis oversimplifies the transition of lesbians into AIDS advocacy roles: while many gay men did display tolerance, gay women had to fight topline lesbophobia to find their place within the movement. AIDS activists divided themselves into two

camps, which Hobson delineates as the “‘treatment’ and ‘social action’ agendas,” representing top-level, lobbying-focused gay people and community-focused mutual aid activists respectively. The “increasingly conservative-minded” lobbying-oriented gay men of the time saw lesbians as a poisonous distraction from earning the favor of the straight politicians who controlled AIDS drug funding, wanting “to get rid of those at the margins of the gay world.” Moreover, Hobson chronicles the entitlement that characterized well-off White gay men’s AIDS activism, noting “the sense of betrayal of privilege present” at an ACT UP demonstration in 1987. Privileged gay men were pursuing the same strategy many liberal feminists undertook in the late seventies, a strategy of apathy towards all causes but one’s own that Hobson calls “single-issue politics”; the most influential male-only “treatment agenda” AIDS groups, if not most of the larger movement, trafficked in single-issue politics before widespread lesbian entry into anti-AIDS roles, making said entry far from seamless. Nonetheless, lesbians eventually achieved in the queer movement what they could not in second-wave feminism: institutional respect and political reciprocity. That difference emerged due to the style in which lesbians integrated themselves into AIDS organizing.

40

The political strengths of lesbian activists in the mid-to-late eighties complemented those of gay men. Torie Osborn recalled that lesbians “cut their teeth on the women’s movement,” equipping them with what historian Maggie Shackleford refers to as the “grassroots, organizing, leadership skills, and direct-action radicalism” to accompany and strengthen the “social action agenda” wing of the burgeoning queer movement. The lesbian assumption of care roles during the AIDS epidemic, however, did not spring from a coordinated surge of compassion for gay men but rather from a straightforward need for the precise skills learned by lesbians in their fight for women-centered spaces; Osborn stated that women “took their rifle places next to [gay] men because they needed us. They needed our grassroots organizing skills; they needed our policy skills; they needed our health, education, research...and medical skills.” In her thesis “Unsung Heroes: Lesbian Activists in the AIDS Epidemic in North Carolina and California, 1981-1989,” Shackleford maintains that “lesbian activists faced little sexism from gay men and easily moved into positions of power in previously male-dominated work environments,” but her analysis misses two key points. Firstly, many gay male activists in such positions of power succumbed to AIDS by 1990, leaving roles available for lesbians. Additionally, the more nuanced, multi-issue politics that sprung out of AIDS-era radicalization meant that lesbians wound up welcome in bottom-up anti-AIDS spaces but not in top-down ones. On account of the close proximity to bottom spaces offered, lesbians and gay men began to define themselves by their rela-

tionships with one another for the first time since the 1960s.

The connotations attached to lesbians by both themselves and others took on a distinct tenor around the early nineties. According to Shackelford, "the actual experience working in the AIDS crisis that made lesbian activism [...] simultaneously a professional and personal commitment," that the gay-male/lesbian bond grew because of AIDS crisis centers. This sociocultural shift extended far beyond friendships with gay men; it redefined how lesbians interacted with one another. Primarily, increased collaboration with gay men all but obliterated political lesbianism, which gradually lost its appeal. Around 1989, radical feminist Jinx Beers lambasted lesbian AIDS activists in an article for *Lesbian News*, accusing them of "betraying [their] people" and "no longer putting lesbians first." Separatist objections, however, were receding rapidly at the time, putting Beers decidedly in the minority. The majority of lesbians adopted a new image, one of dramatic disruption and performance politics, the very qualities from which lesbian groups, before partnering with AIDS patients, shied away.

In the early nineties, lesbian activism shifted away from a struggle of isolationist commune-building to a campaign of radical visibility, grabbing society's attention and demanding that it give lesbians the respect it had previously denied them. In 1992, six lesbians established the Lesbian Avengers "to fight for lesbian survival and visibility." Lesbian separatists had the luxury of being culturally irrelevant, but the new lesbians of the nineties needed the acknowledgment of popular culture as a pulpit from which to preach for their rights. In the Avengers' founding document, the "Dyke Manifesto," the group urged America's gay women to "get out of the beds...and into the streets," a mandate that could not have been more different from the behind-the-scenes organizing of the gendered seventies. Lesbians learned from the over-the-top demonstrations typical of gay male activists that to "ignite" and "fight," as the Manifesto put it, garnered a sense of begrudging respect and acknowledgment that allowed for the negotiation of rights. The anonymously distributed pamphlet "Queers Read This" said the same: "being Queer... is about the freedom to be public." As this new-age activism came into play, lesbian health organizing helped reduce AIDS casualties until the disease became treatable in 1998. Simultaneously, gay-style advocacy helped lesbians gain a cultural foothold, with journalist Martha Gever calling the mid-nineties "the entry of lesbians into our collective consciousness," fighting ignorance and systemic lesbophobia in the process. Lesbian involvement in fighting AIDS saved not only the lives of thousands of patients but also the future of the lesbian movement itself.

Homosexuality, in theory, rooted in affirming one's love, nevertheless appears in

the eyes of heterosexuals to be a denial, whether of morals, of childbearing or of the mainstream. In the highest act of affirmation, lesbian activists edified their own community's strength and helped gay men at their most vulnerable. The triumph of the human spirit over the HIV/AIDS epidemic was the greatest queer victory since Stonewall, and the lesbian compassion that contributed to that victory was a direct rebuke of both the gay sexism and female homophobia that tried to resign lesbians to the shadows. Lesbian AIDS activism affirmed lesbian pride, exposing a vital truth of social justice advocacy: no group can win liberation while tolerating their own degradation at the hands of other activists.

CITATIONS

“73. Dyke Manifesto: Lesbian Avengers” In *Feminist Manifestos: A Global Documentary Reader* edited by Penny A. Weiss, 339-342. New York, USA: New York University Press, 2018. <https://doi.org/10.18574/nyu/9781479805419.003.0077/>
Aldrich, Robert. *Gay Life and Culture: A World History*. London: Thames & Hudson, 2006.

Banales, Meliza. “ACT up.” In *Encyclopædia Britannica*. Last modified February 8, 2024. Accessed March 26, 2024. <https://www.britannica.com/topic/ACT-UP>.

Bedikian, Christine. “Lesbians and Their Role within the Women’s Liberation Movement in the Early 1970s.” In *Gender and Sexuality throughout World History*, compiled by Wake Forest University, HST 114/WGS 214, 190-201. Winston-Salem, NC: Wake Forest University, 2020. Library Partners Press.

Borneman, John. *Journal of the History of Sexuality* 4, no. 3 (1994): 478–80. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/3704366>. 43

Bowman, Karlyn, and Samantha Goldstein. *The Exit Polls: A History and Trends over Time, 1972–2020*. January 11, 2022. Accessed April 17, 2024. <https://www.aei.org/research-products/report/the-exit-polls-a-history-and-trends-over-time-1972-2020/>.

Bravmann, Scott. *Queer Fictions of the Past: History, Culture, and Difference*. Cambridge, U.K. ; New York, NY: Cambridge University Press, 1997.

Calhoun, Cheshire. “Separating Lesbian Theory from Feminist Theory.” *Feminism, the Family, and the Politics of the Closet*, September 12, 2002, 25-48. <https://doi.org/10.1093/0199257663.003.0002>.

CITATIONS

Centers for Disease Control. "Current Trends Mortality Attributable to HIV Infection/ AIDS -- United States, 1981-1990." CDC. Last modified January 25, 1991. Accessed April 17, 2024. <https://www.cdc.gov/mmwr/preview/mmwrhtml/00001880.htm>.

Christensen, Kyle. "Containing Voices of Memory: Lesbianism, Second-Wave Feminism, and the Queer Mnemonic Voice-Outtake in MAKERS: The Women Who Make America." QED: A Journal in GLBTQ Worldmaking 6, no. 1 (2019): 48–71. <https://doi.org/10.14321/qed.6.1.0048>.

Deem, Anna, and Lesbian Avengers. "Dyke Manifesto." In *The Literature of Propaganda*, edited by Thomas Riggs. Farmington, MI, USA: Gale, 2013. Credo Reference.

44 Dolan, Jill. "Feeling Women's Culture: Women's Music, Lesbian Feminism, and the Impact of Emotional Memory." Speech presented at Cornell University 'Resoundingly Queer' Conference, Ithaca, NY, April 1, 2012. *The Feminist Spectator*. Last modified April 1, 2012. <https://feministspectator.princeton.edu/lectures-2/feeling-womens-culture/>.

Dworkin, Andrea. *Right-wing Women*. New York, NY: Putnam, 1987. Accessed April 18, 2024. <https://archive.org/details/rightwingwomen00dwor>.

Faderman, Lillian. "The Return of Butch and Femme: A Phenomenon in Lesbian Sexuality of the 1980s and 1990s." *Journal of the History of Sexuality* 2, no. 4 (1992): 578–96. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/3704264>.

Garcia, Ashley. "Pro-Family Rally (1977)." TSHA. Last modified March 4, 2021. Accessed April 17, 2024. <https://www.tshaonline.org/handbook/entries/pro-family-rally-1977>.

Heller, Dana. "Shooting Solanas: Radical Feminist History and the Technology of Failure." *Feminist Studies* 27, no. 1 (2001): 167. <https://doi.org/10.2307/3178456>.

Hobson, E. *Lavender and Red: Liberation and Solidarity in the Gay and Lesbian Left*. Oakland, CA: University of California Press, 2017.

CITATIONS

Hobson, Emily. "What's Left of Pride?" UC Press Blog. Entry posted June 6, 2018. Accessed April 17, 2024. <https://www.ucpress.edu/blog/28113/whats-left-of-pride/>.

Jackson, Ashawnta. "Daughters of Bilitis." JSTOR Daily, October 1, 2022. <https://daily.jstor.org/daughters-of-bilitis/>.

Johnston, Jill. "Lesbian/Feminism Reconsidered." *Salmagundi*, no. 58/59 (1982): 76–88. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/40547565>.

Leila Armstrong. "Mainstreaming Martina (Navratilova): Lesbian Visibility in the '90s." *Canadian Woman Studies* 16, no. 2 (1996): 10-14. Gale Academic OneFile.

"Lesbian Avengers." In *Historical Dictionary of the Lesbian and Gay Liberation Movements*, edited by Joanne Myers. Lanham, MD, USA: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, 2013. Credo Reference.

McNeill, Melissa A. "Who Are We? Exploring Lesbians Involvement in AIDS Work." Master's thesis, Smith College School for Social Work, 1991. Accessed April 2, 2024.

Moran, Rachel F. "How Second-Wave Feminism Forgot the Single Woman." *Hofstra Law Review* 33, no. 1 (2004). Accessed April 15, 2024.

https://scholarlycommons.law.hofstra.edu/hlr/vol33/iss1/5?utm_source=scholarlycommons.law.hofstra.edu%2Fhlr%2Fvol33%2Fiss1%2F5&utm_medium=PDF&utm_campaign=PDFCoverPages.

Napikoski, Linda. "Lavender Menace: the Phrase, the Group, the Controversy." ThoughtCo. <https://www.thoughtco.com/lavender-menace-feminism-definition-3528970> (accessed April 9, 2024).

Olson, Hope A. "The Feminist and the Emperor's New Clothes: Feminist Deconstruction as a Critical Methodology for Library and Information Studies." *Library and Information Science Research* 19, no. 2 (1997): 181-98.

[https://doi.org/10.1016/s0740-8188\(97\)90042-6](https://doi.org/10.1016/s0740-8188(97)90042-6).

CITATIONS

Perlstein, Rick. *Reaganland: America's Right Turn, 1976-1980*. New York, N.Y.: Simon & Schuster Paperbacks, 2021.

Perrault, Diane. "Lesbianism, Feminism, and the National Women's Conference of 1977: A Turning Point." *Augsburg Honors Review* 2, no. 1 (2009). Accessed April 5, 2024. https://idun.augsburg.edu/honors_review/vol2/iss1/1/?utm_source=idun.augsburg.edu%2Fhonors_review%2Fvol2%2Fiss1%2F1&utm_medium=PDF&utm_campaign=PDF-CoverPages.

Powers, Ráchael A., and Catherine Elizabeth Kaukinen. "Trends in Intimate Partner Violence." *Journal of Interpersonal Violence* 27, no. 15 (2012): 3072-90. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0886260512441077>.

Queers Read This! Print. 1990. Digital Transgender Archive, <https://www.digitaltransgenderarchive.net/files/df65v8092> (accessed April 01, 2024).

Radicalesbians, *The Woman-Identified Woman* (Know, Inc., 1970), <https://repository.duke.edu/dc/wlmpc/wlmms01011> (accessed October 2, 2020).

Rampton, Martha. "Four Waves of Feminism." *Pacific Magazine*, Fall 2008. Accessed April 15, 2024. <https://www.pacificu.edu/magazine/four-waves-feminism>.

Resources [Newspaper Clippings]. 1970-1995, Undated, Item 10. Documents. Resources [Newspaper Clippings]. 1970-1995, Undated, 1970. <https://jstor.org/stable/community.32540617>.

Sandilands, Catriona. "Lesbian Separatist Communities and the Experience of Nature." *Organization & Environment* 15, no. 2 (2002): 131-63. <https://doi.org/10.1177/10826602015002002>.

CITATIONS

Schulman, Sarah, Danzig Alexis, and Lisa Amin. *The Lesbian Avenger Handbook : A Handy Guide to Homemade Rebellion*. Edited by Kelly Cogswell. First Homocom Books edition. New York, NY: [The Lesbian Avengers], 2021, 1.

Shackelford, Maggie, "Unsung Heroes: Lesbian Activists in the AIDS Epidemic in North Carolina and California, 1981-1989" (2011). Dissertations, Theses, and Masters Projects. William & Mary. Paper 1539624393. <https://dx.doi.org/doi:10.21220/s2-efqp-s525>
Smith, Joseph. "Making Trouble: Essays on Gay History, Politics, and the University John D'Emilio." JSTOR Journals. Last modified October 1, 1993.
<https://research.ebsco.com/linkprocessor/plink?id=7f76743c-3df2-371c-9982-f773562e623b>.

Wyne, Zaahira. "The Women Who Fought AIDS: 'It Was Never Not Our Battle.'" Vice (Brooklyn, NY), August 28, 2015. Accessed April 1, 2024.
<https://www.vice.com/en/article/mbqjqp/the-women-who-fought-aids-it-was-never-not-our-battle>.

47

Yaeger, Lynn. "For Del Martin, Lesbian Rights Pioneer, the Last Act of Activism Was the Most Personal." *Vogue*, May 5, 2017. Accessed April 9, 2024.
<https://www.vogue.com/article/del-martin-lesbian-rights-pioneer-birthday>.

Yellen, Janet L. "The History of Women's Work and Wages and How It Has Created Success for Us All." Brookings. Last modified May 20202. Accessed April 17, 2024.
<https://www.brookings.edu/articles/the-history-of-womens-work-and-wages-and-how-it-has-created-success-for-us-all/>.

THE CASE FOR ABOLISHING THE ELECTORAL COLLEGE

Re-examining the American Electoral System

KASEN BOOKBINDER

Milton Academy '26

48

Since the ratification of the Constitution in 1788, the Electoral College has been the voting system used to elect the President of the United States. The number of electoral votes attributed to each state is determined by the number of Representatives in the House of Representatives plus the number of Senators. The Electoral College was created partly as a compromise between states that wanted a popular vote and states that wanted the President to be elected by the Senate; it was not a theory of governance or political ideology but a political compromise. The Electoral College should be removed and the election for the President of the United States should be switched to a popular vote because elections under the Electoral College system are unfair, most Americans prefer a popular vote, and a popular vote is more democratic, upholding the “one person, one vote” principle. Historians have criticized the Electoral College since its inception for being undemocratic and worse than the other option, a popular vote. A popular vote means simply counting every vote in the country; the winner is then the candidate that receives the most votes. In the past 200 years, “more than 700 proposals have been introduced in Congress to reform or eliminate the Electoral College.” That is more proposed Constitutional Amendments than on any other subject.

The biggest challenge to removing the Electoral College is that the majority party (currently the Republicans) believes the Electoral College is just fine because it keeps them relevant. After all, the Republicans would not have won the elections in 2000 and 2016 if they were by a popular vote. In 2016, 69% of Republicans said they would prefer to keep the electoral college. Of course, this is just after Trump won the election without winning the popular vote.

For a country that prides itself on its freedom and democracy, the United States

PRISM: YOUTH JOURNAL OF HISTORY AND SOCIAL SCIENCE

has a system of voting for a President that fails democracy. In 2000, the Republican candidate, George Bush, won the Presidency without winning the popular vote – the first time since 1876. In 2016, the Republican candidate (this time Donald Trump) again won the Presidency while losing the popular vote by almost 3 million votes. Popular vote elections are much more democratic because the winner is simply the person who wins more votes, not the candidate who is the most popular in key swing states. Also, popular votes are much kinder to third-party candidates and provide more competition besides the two major political parties. For example, in 1992 Ross Perot, an independent candidate, won 19 percent of the popular vote but he “did not win any electoral votes since he was not particularly strong in any one state.” Even if the election was held by popular vote Ross Perot would not have won, he would have done better than he did in the electoral college, with zero electoral votes.

Since the Electoral College was created in 1788, the elections it has produced have been unfair. For example, a vote in Massachusetts matters much less than a vote in Georgia. Massachusetts will vote Democratic, so candidates spend little time and money there. Georgia is a swing state with lots of electoral votes, so candidates are more inclined to campaign there. Also, a group of voters concentrated in a few states can have a big impact, even if they are the national minority. The electoral college can be manipulated as exemplified by George Wallace, the former Governor of Alabama. Wallace, a famous segregationist best known for his line “segregation today, segregation tomorrow, segregation forever” hoped to get just enough electoral votes to stop the other two candidates, Richard Nixon and Hubert Humphrey, from getting the 270 electoral votes needed to win. If no candidate gets 270 votes, the decision goes to the House of Representatives, where Wallace hoped he could win. Wallace’s plan might have worked had his running mate, Curtis LeMay not said that he was not opposed to nuking Vietnam. In a popular vote, this loophole Wallace hoped to win through would not exist.

Not only is removing the Electoral College imperative to American democracy’s future, but it is also very popular. After Wallace’s campaign in 1968 proved to many Americans that the electoral college was heavily flawed, “polling showed public support for the direct vote of the president at 80 percent, up 22 points in two years.” Regardless that the Electoral College heavily favored him, as he beat Hubert Humphrey in 1968 by 110 electoral votes despite only receiving 800,000 more votes, Nixon approved an amendment to abolish the Electoral College in 1969. It sailed through the house, passing 339 to 70. The amendment was stopped in the Senate because segregationist senators from the South

were happy with the Electoral College because it favored them, an overall minority. The Pew Research Center reports that in 2000, 61% of Americans favored changing the system to a popular vote, in 2012, 62%, and in 2024, 63%. Just because the Electoral College is unpopular in 2024 does not mean it needs to be removed, but the Electoral College has been unpopular for over 200 years.

While the United States is not a government defined by the will of the majority, who determines the President should be a popular vote because the President is the most powerful person in the country and should be decided by the direct will of the majority.

CITATIONS

Brockell, Gillain. "Of the 700 Attempts to Fix or Abolish the Electoral College, This One Nearly Succeeded." *The Washington Post* (Washington D.C.), December 5, 2020. Accessed October 3, 2024. <https://www.washingtonpost.com/history/2020/12/04/abolish-electoral-college-george-wallace-trump-bayh/>.

"Electoral College History." National Archives. Accessed October 3, 2024. <https://www.archives.gov/electoral-college/history>.

Kelley, Jocelyn. Majority of Americans Continue to Favor Moving Away from Electoral College. September 25, 2024. Accessed October 5, 2024. <https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2024/09/25/majority-of-americans-continue-to-favor-moving-away-from-electoral-college/>.

"1968 Presidential Election." 270 to Win. Accessed October 5, 2024. https://www.270towin.com/1968_Election/.

"2000 Presidential Election." 270 to Win. Accessed October 3, 2024. https://www.270towin.com/2000_Election/.

"2016 Presidential Election Results." *The New York Times*. Last modified August 9, 2017. Accessed October 2, 2024. <https://www.nytimes.com/elections/2016/results/president>.

MENDING THE SEGREGATION IN HEALTHCARE

A look into the American Medical Association

RHIA PATEL

Milton Academy '26

52

Race: the fictional concept that divided Americans from skin to soul, leaving a legacy of discrimination and abuse of power within the American healthcare system. Throughout the history of America, racial divide has been significant in schools, government, and hospitals. In a profession where individuals are meant to assist and save lives, the stigma within race based treatment has prevented doctors from treating all Americans equally, resulting in higher mortality rates and fear of accessing healthcare by minority populations due to systematic stress factors stemming from historical mistreatment. In recent history, presidents have advocated for equality in healthcare, yet surprisingly, the largest opponent of universal healthcare was not the government, but rather the American Medical Association, who's doctors and physicians opposed assisting underprivileged communities for fear of losing their own income. Indeed, after slavery was abolished in 1865, the majority of underprivileged communities of color were denied their rights to healthcare, and faced discrimination not only from white physicians but also from state laws. Thus, the fight for morals-based equality within healthcare lasted until the late 1900's. In a profession stating the importance of taking care of one's self and others, discrimination based on race was so prominent that when Harry Truman proposed universal health care, corporations including the American Medical Association immediately fought the idea due to their fear of a powerful central government who would control a doctors practice and their income; nevertheless, a segregated healthcare system continues a lack of access to effective healthcare for minorities communities throughout the country.

During early colonial rule of America, indentured servants from Europe and African countries were oppressed by white men in power, leading to a 1667 rebellion causing

white men to frantically reconsider their laws and ways of ruling in order to better sustain their regime: a system enshrining the division of lower classes by race to prevent them from uniting against the state. Following Virginia's 1661 anti-miscegenation law, Maryland, prompted by the rebellion, banned all interracial marriages, preventing minority communities from working together to create a system of equality and limiting equal representation in society. Forbidding interracial couples created a superior race that could not be 'mixed' with another race to preserve the white purity. Black people were quickly looked down upon in society and later reduced to slaves and nothing more, causing Black people to be treated as property and not as humans.

The injustices within healthcare began in the era of slavery with doctors medically experimenting on enslaved individuals due to their misguided belief that Black people could not feel pain. White doctors, more often than not, got away with malpractice and were later praised for their experiments. Enslaved women were forced to take part in experiments that they had not consented to as permission was obtained from their masters. For example, James Marion Sims – widely considered the Father of Gynecology – performed experiments on at least “seven enslaved Black women and girls” between 1845 to 1849. One experiment on a young enslaved woman named Lucy, who “endured excruciating pain” on an “operation [that] failed,” nearly killed her due to Sims' lack of precautions. Only after he was sure that Black women could survive his new techniques did he practice on white women using anesthesia, exhibiting the lack of thought that Black women's lives were important though he did the same surgeries on both races. However, his refusal to use anesthesia “was based on his misguided belief that black people didn't experience pain like white people did,” a common myth which also led Black people to be forced into labor intensive jobs. Nevertheless, Sims continues to receive praise by a vast community of individuals. Despite being unsuccessful in his surgeries, Sims, in showing no remorse for his gross failure, demonstrated how pervasive the dehumanization of black women was in the medical world.

Following the 1865 passage of the 13th Amendment, in which slavery was abolished, Americans were divided even further through segregation and Jim Crow laws created by states populated by a majority African-American population, in fear that the white population would lose their power and status in controlling the government. Most, if not all, Black people in the south were forced to enter the field of sharecropping. In this system, land-owners received “half of the [cash crops]” and were able to keep the majority of the income whereas the Black farmers were placed into persistent debt. Because of this preven-

tative measure, individuals working on farms in the sharecropping system could not afford any sort of healthcare or medication to compensate for the rough conditions that they worked in. Additionally, if workers were sick they would not be able to miss a day's worth of work as missed labor would add to their debt. Through *Plessy v. Ferguson*, the United States Supreme Court declared that Americans could be "separate but equal," a statement that allowed for individual states to divide any public space they felt necessary. Up until the 1960's—before the second Civil Rights movement—hospitals in America were divided such that the care of white versus Black Americans was drastically different. Where white Americans had clean, spacious hospitals, Black Americans were "housed in basements or crowded into the halls. That everything in these hospitals [was] separate, except the sewage, they [allowed] that to flow together," exhibited that the divide was purely based on the fact that doctors did not want to treat those of different skin color even though they required the same procedures. Education for doctors was also separate, especially "in much of the South, [where] a...system of hospitals existed to serve black communities and as a place where black physicians could be trained and practice"; the limited number of physicians of color who were forced to form a mutual aid patchwork, whereas a historically large population of white doctors ensured steady white access to healthcare since long before the Civil War. In a time where Black physicians and their hospitals were limited, white doctors' prevention of treating people of color led to an increase of avoidable mortality. In 1931, for example, two Black women in Georgia who were involved in a car crash were "refused" by a local hospital due to their race before their injuries killed them. In 1915, Black male patients were not allowed to be treated by white nurses as Alabama passed a law that would make "it [...] unlawful for any white female nurse to nurse in wards or rooms in hospitals... [where] negro men are placed for treatment, or to be nursed." This law signifies that the government feared any discomfort or sexual harassment of white women yet did not protect, equally, Black women from white doctors who may also conduct any form of sexual misconduct. The 'colored' hospitals and their patients were extremely underfunded due to the lack of opportunities that the previously enslaved population faced, preventing sustainable healthcare.

Leading into the Gilded Age, Black people found themselves working for railroad companies, where they were forced to work more dangerous jobs and paid less leading to an economic lack of opportunities for populations of color. European co-workers with limited English language skills were paid more, signifying that the wage divide was not based on the immigration or linguistic skill of an individual, but purely on their race. Capitalist

railroad companies suppressed the rights of Black labor workers more frequently than they did the rights of white workers, forcing Black people to perform historically racist dances, serving food, and cleaning on the trains: a way of taking advantage of a train being the only safe way for a person of color to travel. To protect against the exploitation at the hands of capitalists, workers formed labor unions. However, the largest labor union was exclusively for all white workers and did not allow for Black laborers to join their agenda. This exclusion further pushed Black folks away from equality, even within the working class. It also led to Black people filling the vacant positions of white workers in companies, yet for a fraction of the pay as capitalists needed their factories to run and Black people needed jobs. Between the years of 1880 and 1900, the average life expectancy for Black people was 35 to 36 years old whereas for white Americans the expectancy was 39 to 40 years old, illustrating that through constraint of both healthcare access and financial discrimination, Black Americans were more likely to suffer in the so-called “pursuit of happiness”. Exclusionary care also extended to during health crises. For example, during a cholera epidemic in 1941, Black Americans in Philadelphia “suffered a case rate almost twice as great as that of whites.” The government’s resistance to provide more affordable protection led non-profit organizations such as the Alpha Kappa Alpha to provide stations for free dental and physical care in rural Black communities. Their mission was to “keep democracy alive... and to make democracy a reality in our nation,” where all citizens are granted the protection promised to them through representation, which was currently absent within the government system as white representatives were in power and would not advocate for rural communities of color.

55

Following World War II, President Harry Truman devised a plan to create a universal healthcare system, instilling fear specifically in white doctors of becoming government-funded, which would prevent them from generating a larger income and bar them from exclusively treating the affluent patients like they preferred. Truman believed that more Americans could have fought in the American military but were not able to due to their lack of access to proper healthcare and nutrition. He stated the importance of “action to help them attain that opportunity and protection,” within healthcare moving beyond the scope of race base divide. Truman believed that his job as the president was to “represent the whole 155 million people- the people who haven’t any pull or lobby,” or in other words, those whose representatives are in a minority community and voices are oppressed in the Federal Government. In his 1945 speech to Congress, Truman stated the need for healthcare “regardless of residence, station, or race--everywhere in the United States,” and

though his motives originate from a war torn world, his goal would benefit an ongoing fight for equality. The major significance of mentioning race is that though the country believed they moved on from racial divide due to the abolishment of slavery, Truman was explicitly calling out white Americans for their discrimination. If all Americans had healthcare, there would be a higher probability of effective education for all citizens, pushing Americans to attend higher paying jobs. Within his speech, Truman addressed the rumors of his plan to “socialize the country,” a state of propaganda spread by the American Medical Association as they believed that “doctors would work as employees of the government.” However, much of the controversy in passing such a bill stemmed from the idea that “taxpayers’ money” would be used for “free services, free clinics, and public hospitals,” something that low wage earning Americans would not be able to afford nor a tax that wealthy Americans would find the need to pay for. The idea, which consolidated tax money spending power in the federal government, was immediately perceived as Communist and was thus received negatively in an early Cold War environment.

56

The American Medical Association (AMA) strongly opposed universal healthcare, stemming from their fear of losing their monopoly which would lead to communist system in American healthcare; universal healthcare would make the medical field a low paying, public service profession. Wealthy white doctors controlling the AMA were treating proportionally wealthy patients, meaning that their income was also greater. The AMA portrayed accessible healthcare as “socialized medicine,” spreading fear that Americans would end up paying more in taxes to the government. Additionally, the AMA benefited from painting Truman’s party as “followers of the Moscow party line,” inserting fear in Americans that Truman would turn America into a communist country and therefore destroying the idea of competition in the economy and reducing Americans to poverty. Though the AMA seemed to have declared their opposition due to the government’s “attack” on the doctors “freedom,” the association also declared that free healthcare would lead to “lower standards of medical care, higher payroll taxes, [and] loss of incentive and damage to research,” meaning that many medicine related jobs would decrease and any research done would be as the government preferred. Thus, a larger financial burden would be placed on the doctors who would generate a smaller income then when they were able to charge their patients as they wished. Dr. Henderson Ewing from the AMA argued that the government was pursuing an “invasion of privacy” on the association and doctors who wanted to independently practice; many doctors of the AMA were supportive of all white chapters, creating a discriminative workforce, which would be abolished if the government forced

doctors to treat all patients equally. The National American Association, the all Black physician group, pushed for the “1948 Hill-Burton Hospital Survey and Construction Act” to create more resources for rural communities, such as hospitals. However, the AMA spent “\$1,110,000, the entire sum to be spent during two weeks in October ” for propaganda against the government, including newspaper and radio advertisements. This large sum of money could have been spent on “one year’s average medical costs for more than 160,000 families in the \$3,000-a year bracket.” The American Medical Association’s fight against universal healthcare is connected to their lack of inclusivity. Hardly any Black doctors were able to speak up for the conditions that they worked in as “only one black physician in the state had been admitted to its medical society,” restricting Black patient population and their healthcare predicament to be represented through the lack of resources. The AMA, though said to be an organization representing all doctors, kept the association segregated by allowing all white chapters, signifying their lack of wanting to empower Black doctors and listen to their voices, which in turn oppressed liberties of Black communities by restricting their representation and equal access to healthcare.

The American Medical Association, along with major capitalists in America, benefited from free healthcare being accessible only to white individuals working low paying jobs as it was a way to control labor in the country. Capitalists could warn white workers that if they were to leave their jobs, their spot could easily be replaced by a Black worker willing to be employed for a fraction of the cost due to the lack of jobs available to people of color. If an employer was to have provided healthcare benefits, “contributions for health benefit plans were generally tax deductible as a business expense and were to be excluded from employees’ taxable income,” meaning that the company owners would also take away a higher income that was not lost in taxes to the Federal Government. If universal healthcare became accessible, underpaid workers would leave their jobs and find new ways and resources to generate a larger income, and in doing so halt monopolies throughout the country. In 1946, a Sargent from Wisconsin wrote to Truman stating that Americans “do not feel that 4% salary deduction is the answer,” as a man who would be earning just \$3,600 a year would be forced to pay \$144 for healthcare, which they were not used to paying to the Federal Government. As the Declaration of Independence states, liberty, including the liberty to live a healthy life, is entitled to all Americans. Though Truman’s plan would benefit many Americans in poor working conditions, the flat tax it imposed would have disproportionately burdened low income families. The AMA and capitalists only offer healthcare if hired through underpaying, discriminatory jobs protecting the preferred white workers,

which left black folks unprotected within the healthcare system and workforce.

Contrary to the modern AMA's claim that "legally sanctioned racial segregation in hospitals ended with the Civil Rights Act of 1964," the effects of discrimination lasted through the 1964 Civil Rights movements till today. Additionally, the AMA still requires physicians to pay a fee in order to become a member of the organization, meaning that doctors in marginalized communities would find it difficult to join such an advocacy group and would not be able to advocate for underserved communities. Even during the first Civil Rights movement, advocates for equity questioned white doctors' silence. Even in factory jobs, it was not immigration status or lack of linguistic skills that prevented workers from equal pay by large companies, but simply deliberate and explicitly racial employment discrimination, which in turn led to inaccessible healthcare. Still today, Black women are "2 to 3 times more likely to die from a pregnancy related cause than white women." Due to redlining, the lack of access to "supermarkets with fresh and affordable food" have an impact today as communities of color are more likely to be disadvantaged, restricting their access to the improvement of health. Truman fostered a healthcare plan that would have matched America's global standings economically yet the societal discrimination and the inability to accept all people equally has held back Americans from being a land of all people.

CITATIONS

Aflac. "Labor Day and the History of Health Insurance—an Ongoing Legacy." In Aflac. Last modified August 2022. Accessed April 8, 2024. <https://www.aflac.com/docs/brokers/articles/labor-day-and-the-history-of-health-insurance-an-ongoing-legacy.pdf>.

"Alabama Bars Treatment of Black Men by White Nurses." Equal Justice Initiative. Last modified September 29, 1915. <https://calendar.eji.org/racial-injustice/sep/29>.

Alpha Kappa Alpha. "Mississippi Health Project Annual Report No. 7." In Mississippi Health Project. Last modified January 1, 1941. Accessed March 28, 2024. https://dh.howard.edu/aka_misshealth/.

American Medical Association. Accessed March 31, 2024. <https://www.ama-assn.org/member-benefits/personal-member-benefits-discounts/6-reasons-join-ama>.

Azar, Alex M., Robert R. Redfield, and Jennifer H. Madans, eds. "Health, United States." Center for Disease Control. Last modified December 1, 2018. Accessed March 4, 2024. <https://www.cdc.gov/nchs/data/hus/hus18.pdf>.

Battalora, Jacqueline M. *Birth of a White Nation: The Invention of White People and Its Relevance Today*. London: Routledge, 2021.

Begeman, Jean. "American Medical Association vs National Insurance." *The New Republic*. Last modified October 2, 1950. Accessed March 29, 2024. <https://newrepublic.com/article/122400/american-medical-association-vs-national-insurance>.

"The Challenge of National Healthcare." In National Archives. Accessed April 8, 2024. <https://www.trumanlibrary.gov/education/presidential-inquiries/challenge-national-healthcare>.

CITATIONS

Chinn, Juanita J., Iman K. Martin, and Nicole Redmond. "Health Equity Among Black Women in the United States." National Library of Medicine. Last modified February 2, 2021. Accessed March 4, 2024. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC8020496/>.

Darden, CA. "Integration Battlefront." In *Journal of the National Medical Association*. N.p., 1957. https://scholar.google.com/scholar_lookup?journal=Journal+of+the+National+Medical+Association&title=Integration+Battlefront%E2%80%94Mississippi&author=CA+Darden&volume=49&issue=5&publication_year=1957&pages=353-4&.

Division of Reproductive Health. Infographic: Racial/Ethnic Disparities in Pregnancy-Related Deaths — United States, 2007–2016. Center for Disease Control. Last modified April 13, 2022. Accessed March 4, 2024. <https://archive.cdc.gov/#/details?url=https://www.cdc.gov/reproductivehealth/maternal-mortality/disparities-pregnancy-related-deaths/infographic.html>.

60

DuBois, W.E.B. "W.E.B. DuBois's Challenge to Scientific Racism." JSTOR. Last modified June 1981. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2784074>.

Ewbank, Douglas C. "History of Black Mortality and Health before 1940." In *The Milbank Quarterly*, 65th ed., 100-28. University of Pennsylvania, 1987. Last modified 1987. Accessed March 4, 2024. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/3349953>.

Ewing, Dr. Henderson Raps. “Voluntary Health Insurance Called Better, Cheaper Than Compulsory.” The Courier-Journal, May 5, 1949. Accessed March 29, 2024. https://www.newspapers.com/image/110399218/?clipping_id=34189651&fcfToken=eyJhbGciOiJIUzI1NiIsInR5cCI6IkpXVCJ9.eyJmcmVlZXZpZXctaWQiOjExMDM5OTIxO-CwiaWF0IjoxNzExNzMxNjE5LCJleHAiOjE3MTE4MTgwMTl9.VmIjySsIS5QR-grR1UqTUmwoWEaQP0PtBvR3h0oEHjE94.

Grimes Family. "Sharecropping Contract." In *For the Record: A Documentary History of America: From Reconstruction to the Present*, 8th ed., by David Emory Shi and Holly A. Mayer, 37-39. New York: W.W. Norton & Company, 2022.

CITATIONS

Hacker, David. "Decennial Life Tables for the White Population of the United States, 1790–1900." National Library of Medicine. Accessed April 15, 2024. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC2885717/>.

Hoffman, Beatrix. "The Medical Civil Rights Movement And Access To Health Care." Circulating Now. Last modified January 14, 2016. Accessed April 1, 2024. <https://circulatingnow.nlm.nih.gov/2016/01/14/the-medical-civil-rights-movement-and-access-to-health-care/>.

Thomas Jefferson, et al, July 4, Copy of Declaration of Independence. -07-04, 1776. Manuscript/Mixed Material. <https://www.loc.gov/item/mtjbib000159>

"Laws That Banned Mixed Marriages." Jim Crow Museum. Accessed April 16, 2024. <https://jimcrowmuseum.ferris.edu/question/2010/may.htm>.

LeBlond, F.C. Letter from F. C. LeBlond to President Harry S. Truman. Photograph. National Archives. November 1945. <https://www.trumanlibrary.gov/library/research-files/letter-f-c-leblond-president-harry-s-truman>.

Letter from W. I. Sargent to President Harry S. Truman, January 4, 1946. Photograph. National Archives. January 4, 1946. Accessed April 8, 2024. <https://www.trumanlibrary.gov/library/research-files/letter-w-i-sargent-president-harry-s-truman>.

Leviero, Anthony. "Truman Assails Power Concerns; May Ask Inquiry." New York Times, May 27, 1952, 22.

Lynch, Sarah. "Father of modern gynecology performed experiments on enslaved Black women." USA Today. Last modified June 19, 2020. Accessed April 2, 2024. <https://www.usatoday.com/story/news/factcheck/2020/06/19/fact-check-j-marion-sims-did-medical-experiments-black-female-slaves/3202541001/>.

CITATIONS

Makel, Dr. Howard. "69 years ago, a president pitches his idea for national health care." PBS News Hour. Last modified November 19, 2014. Accessed April 8, 2024. <https://www.pbs.org/newshour/health/november-19-1945-harry-truman-calls-national-health-insurance-program#:~:text=The%20first%20was%20to%20address,it%20difficult%20if%20not%20impossible>.

Marquez, Denisse Rojas. "Segregation in Health Care." Journal of Ethics, January 2023. Accessed March 30, 2024. <https://journalofethics.ama-assn.org/issue/segregation-health-care#:~:text=Structural%20racism%20is%20deeply%20embedded,payment%20structures%20implemented%20in%201966>.

McKoy, Jillian. "Racism, Sexism, and the Crisis of Black Women's Health." The Brink. Last modified October 31, 2023. Accessed March 8, 2024. <https://www.bu.edu/articles/2023/racism-sexism-and-the-crisis-of-black-womens-health/>.

62

"Medical Exploitation of Black Women," Equal Justice Initiative, last modified August 29, 2019, accessed April 18, 2024, <https://eji.org/news/history-racial-injustice-medical-exploitation-of-black-women/>.

Moser, Whet. "How the AMA Scared Us Away From 'Socialized Medicine' and Prepared Us For Obamacare." Chicago Magazine, October 2012. Accessed March 29, 2024. <https://www.chicagomag.com/city-life/october-2012/how-the-ama-scared-us-away-from-socialized-medicine-and-prepared-us-for-obamacare/>.

Mott, Lucretia. A Sermon to the Medical Students. N.p., 1849.

Ng, Kenneth, and Nancy Virts. "The Black-White Income Gap in 1880." In *Agricultural History*, 2. Vol. 67. N.p.: Duke University Press, 1993. JSTOR.

Ojanuga, Durrenda. "The Medical Ethics of the 'Father of Gynaecology', Dr J Marion Sims." In *Journal of Medical Ethics*. Vol. 19. Alabama, USA: University of Alabama, 1993.

CITATIONS

Plessy v. Ferguson. "Plessy V. Ferguson (1896)." In *For the Record: A Documentary History of America: From Reconstruction to the Present*, 8th ed., by David Emory Shi and Holly A. Mayer, 39-41. New York: W.W. Norton & Company, 2022.

"Rethinking the Legacy of Marion Sims." Equal Justice Initiative. Last modified January 9, 2023. Accessed April 2, 2024. <https://eji.org/news/rethinking-the-legacy-of-marion-sims/>.

Samuelson, Kristin. "Neighborhood racial segregation linked to shorter life spans." *Northwestern Now*. Last modified July 14, 2023. Accessed February 29, 2024. <https://news.northwestern.edu/stories/2023/07/neighborhood-racial-segregation-linked-to-shorter-life-spans-by-four-years/>.

Schumpeter, Joseph. "Origins and Evolution of Employment-Based Health Benefits." *National Library of Medicine*. Last modified 1938. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/books/NBK235989/>.

63

Shi, David Emory, and Holly A. Mayer. *For The Record: A Documentary History of America*. N.p.: Norton, 2022.

Smith, David Barton. "The Politics of Racial Disparities: Desegregating the Hospitals in Jackson, Mississippi." *National Institute of Health*. Last modified June 2005. Accessed March 4, 2024. [https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC2690142/#:~:text=Until%20the%201960s%2C%20as%20with,and%20practice%20\(Gamble%201995\).](https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC2690142/#:~:text=Until%20the%201960s%2C%20as%20with,and%20practice%20(Gamble%201995).)

Truman, Harry S. "Special Message to the Congress Recommending a Comprehensive Health Program." In *National Archives*. Speech.

A LOOK INTO A 9/11 EXPERIENCE

Re-Examining September 11th

MADDISON VARONE

Barrington High School (RI) 26'

64

September 11, 2001, was the day of the deadliest terrorist attack on United States Soil. The group that orchestrated the attacks was called Al-Qaeda, and they hijacked 4 planes. Their goal was to send two planes to the Twin Towers, one to the Pentagon, and the last plane to the White House. The first strike occurred at 8:46 AM at the North Tower. Next followed the South Tower and the Pentagon. The plane heading towards the White House was overtaken by passengers and landed in a nearby field in Shanksville, Pennsylvania. All of the passengers on each of these flights sadly passed, and many others were injured.

The person I chose to interview was my grandfather, Daniel Sesti. At the time of 9/11, he was 54 years old. He worked on 8th Avenue in downtown Manhattan at the World Wide Plaza. He had been working for 45 minutes before the first tower was hit. Suddenly, he received a phone call from his colleague's son about what was happening. He ran to the cafeteria a few floors up and was looking out the window at the North Tower. He was standing with his co-worker, and they were both in a state of shock and confusion. Everybody was gathered around the window when the South Tower was struck. Once he realized what was actually happening, he ran down to the train station and caught the first train out of Manhattan. When he was on the train, he said that everybody was quiet and nobody said anything the entire train ride. He said that he and everybody else were very unsure of what was going to happen next, whether there were going to be another attack, and unsure of how long this would last. After the attacks, he thought that the sense of patriotism was stronger because it brought people together for the same reason. People were sad, grieving over the loss of thousands of people and first responders. Things were very

chaotic for the next few days, with people trying to figure out what to do, where to go, and what their futures may look like, and how those were affected.

9/11 was a very emotional time for people. It makes me very emotional today. I picture the tumultuous times people had to go through on that day, like trying to leave the city but not knowing where their family was, what their future was, etc... I do agree that this strengthened America's patriotism by bringing everyone together, but we all wish it wouldn't happen that specific way. While 9/11 is very emotional for people, I believe it is still very important to teach because we should know about our history and the importance of it. I would say my feelings changed after this interview. It made me put things into perspective more and realize the hardships people were facing. It made me realize how people are traumatized; I could not even imagine what it was like for my grandfather to be watching 9/11 through the window. I got to hear from him what it was like being in Manhattan, which made me more emotional, seeing how difficult this was for so many families.

THE TRUE PUBLIC ENEMY

The War on Drugs' Role in Mass Incarceration and Harsh Policing

ANAÏS BRICOUT

Milton Academy '26

66

In June 1971, President Richard Nixon declared an offensive on drugs. Thrown into action by a supposed all-time high of drug use in 1979 and by the media's sensationalization of this phenomenon, newly elected, neoconservative president Ronald Reagan continued his predecessor's campaign against this "enemy" of the United States. Especially as race began to split the country, more liberal white groups shifted to the movement of conservatism, which held more religious and traditional values. With the over-sensationalized media coverage of black-on-white crime and the importation of drugs into the country, the presidential administration furthered a new, harsher stance towards drugs, colloquially known as the "war on drugs," which influenced how the criminal "justice" system would define crime and approach punishment going forward, especially for African-Americans. The war on drugs of the late 20th century shaped mass incarceration and harsh policing against people of color in America through the militarization of the police, the creation of a tough-on-crime public opinion, which led to the perceived "crack baby" epidemic and harsh mandatory sentencing policies, and through the disproportionate legislation of crack vs. powder cocaine users. Ultimately, these initiatives influenced cycles of generational poverty amongst African Americans and advanced racial inequality.

The militarized mentality of the initiative against drugs in the 1980s, which took form in governmental programs and presidential policies, guided the surge in mass incarceration and the beginnings of harsh policing in America. Nixon declared drugs, in 1971, as "public enemy number one," requiring an "all-out offensive." In this speech, with the repetition of such aggressive military language around enforcement and legislation, Nixon encouraged a direct attack against drugs. As such, the war on drugs militarized counter-drug

initiatives and shaped them to become harsher and more aggressive, which explains harsh policing. The people in the Roxbury community, feeling that drugs had become a serious threat in 1988, called for the National Guard; indeed, the call for militarization and the perception of drug abuse as an “enemy” shifted public opinion. They began to believe that military interference was necessary to end drugs, when in fact, as Senator Carey explained, it only worsened the situation. Consequently, as noted by students in *The Montgazette*, the use of the military in counter-drug initiatives directly connected to mass incarceration; in fact, when the Navy and Coast Guard, both part of the U.S. armed forces, collaborated in Florida with the Federal Bureau of Investigation and the Drug Enforcement Administration, an organization formed for the sole purpose of countering drugs, arrest rates for drugs “doubled overnight.” The militarized arrest initiative would increase the rate of conviction, and as *The Montgazette*’s writers further explained, these increased rates would require the expansion of “prisons [which were] already grossly overcrowded.” As such, militarization, as it correlated to more aggressive language and military initiatives against drugs, contributed greatly to mass incarceration and harsh policing.

Similarly, the militarized outlook of police officers contributed to racially biased harsh policing. As William Celester, a Roxbury deputy superintendent who oversaw the operations of crime prevention and of police management, argued for stop-and-search in 1990 and repeated “war,” police militarized themselves through stop-and-search because they began to believe that “some people need[ed] to be scared, because [...] that [was] the only thing [they] under[stood].” Celester’s assertion that fear was necessary to counter drugs illustrates how fear became a primary factor in policing, for police officers saw themselves as fighting a perceived ‘war’ on drugs. Roxbury Police Department highlighted that stop-and-search was a direct result of militarization because it was through this policy that they could use “fear” to fight the “war.” Moreover, the most frequent victims of this militarization that took form in stop-and-search were African-American men. In fact, in a news report about Roxbury in the face of the war on drugs in 1988, police officers stopped an African-American man unjustifiably and frisked him as citizens asked for an increased police presence to put an end to drug crime. This interaction not only exemplifies the pattern of how police officers used only their “reasonable” suggestion to stop Black men but also how police officers linked drug crime innately with African Americans, which resulted in these unreasonable stops. As *Vice Magazine* revealed during the rise of Black Lives Matter in response to George Floyd’s murder, this internally biased association between Black people and drugs came from “a long time ago, with white folks worried about Black folks

being violent on drugs.” Furthermore, because the number of drug offenders arrested were primarily from minority communities, especially African-Americans, these initiatives of stop-and-search would directly cause racially biased mass incarceration. Even with supposedly softer drugs, like cannabis, than those of the 1980s which led to the massively disproportionate and unfair incarceration of Black people, police officers justified their attacks because they had been taught that this measure against drugs was a ‘war.’ Hence, according to Dr. Reed T. DeAngelis, a public health scholar who investigated this behavior in her article “Systematic Racism in Police Killings,” through the lens of a perceived need for military action within the police, police officers disproportionately stopped and used violence against Black men in inner-cities, perpetuating racial biases and stereotypes. As a result, police brutality has persisted as a systematic problem, despite the objections and movements of many communities fighting racial injustice.

68

Simultaneously, the militarization of the police force through the police department’s expanded access to military arms also shaped harsh policing. In 1997, the National Defense Authorization Act permitted that the government “[might] transfer to Federal and State agencies [...] small arms and ammunition, that [...] [were] [...] suitable for use [...] in [...] counter-drug [...] activities.” In doing so, the increased police funding for fighting drug-related crimes, the adoption of more militarized equipment like large caliber weapons, and the creation of Special Weapons and Tactics (SWAT), which all increased the rate of drug convictions, militarized the police. Additionally, Dr. Zach Baumgart, a sociologist who has specialized in race and criminal justice, proved in his dissertation that this phenomenon of mass incarceration and convictions influenced by the war on drugs’ militarization of police disproportionately affected African-Americans, especially in poorer communities. For example, the militarization of the police by the war on drugs made it so that the majority of interactions between armed police and unarmed black people were about drugs, which were then used to supposedly justify the violent behavior of that same officer. SWAT, a symptom of the militarization of police in the 1980s, carried out more search warrants than any other targeted action, warrants which used no-knock raids most commonly and have been shown to disproportionately affect Black people. Furthermore, these no-knock raids were legally ambiguous as judges relied almost exclusively on the opinion of police officers to determine the validity of the warrant. Most often, a simple estimation that the suspect might be “armed” was “reasonable” enough to provide a no-knock warrant, except neither physical nor proof of past actions of the warrant’s subject was provided. As such, the police’s expanded access to military arms during the war on

drugs perpetuated massive racial inequality and mistreatment in the criminal justice system. Comparatively to other races and people living in higher-income communities, the war on drugs ensured that poor Black people in fact would not receive the same regard, and it characterized poor Black people by a historical stereotype fueled by these counter-drug actions.

During the same period, the misconception of the “crack baby” epidemic led to a shift in public opinion toward a more tough-on-crime mentality, which incited the cycle of biased mass incarceration. In 1998, surveys conducted by the Washington Post indicated that public opinion had become increasingly tough on crime, even as crime rates as well as drug use dropped. This disparity between fact and perception displays how the public’s tough-on-crime opinion was based on many misconceptions. Such misconceptions, most especially concerning cocaine mothers and babies, were present particularly in Nancy Reagan’s “Just Say No” initiative. In her first address to the nation on this policy in 1986, she asserted that “one of the main purposes” of the war on drugs, was to create a “new awareness of how terrible and threatening drug abuse [was] to [American] society,” especially in the case of a “child born to a mother with a cocaine habit,” a child who “suffer[ed] as a result.” She emphasized how much influence the public had over the harsher sentences during the period of the late 20th century by calling the public on to “create an out-spoken intolerance for drug use” and to “be unyielding and inflexible in [their] opposition to drugs.” Her calls to action hence demonstrate how essential it was for the campaign against drugs that the public maintained a harsh and punitive stance on drug use, further illustrating how this strict outlook on crime developed with this over-sensationalized fear of unfounded issues like perceived “crack babies.”

69

However, this supposed epidemic was not as dire as stated by Mrs. Reagan and still carries effects in modern times. False studies and the misinterpretation of symptoms resulting from premature birth, not cocaine, fueled the perception of a “crack baby” epidemic, and mass media facilitated this falsified spread with its broadcast of superficial information, as Michael Winerip admitted retrospectively in *The New York Times*. Finally, misconceptions from this perceived epidemic stigmatized drug users, particularly Black women who lived in inner cities. Indeed, Adrianna Finnamore, a scholar in the field of public history, posited in 2022 that this treatment not only caused contempt but also systematic mistreatment, especially in the justice system, against victims of drug use that did not exist. Misconceptions from the war on drugs era, surrounding “crack babies” and an alleged epidemic, still affect people of color in modern times, especially Black women.

The disproportionate rate of drug testing for Black women compared to white women, according to *The New York Times*, despite the increased likelihood of white women to test positive, explains how an unfounded public panic from the 1980s has caused the contemporary marginalization and discrimination against Black women. Moreover, the same *New York Times* article revealed deeper issues; in a modern case study of a mother supposedly using drugs in the Bronx, neither did government services have proper grounds to remove the child from the mother nor did the hospital in which the child was born acquire the mother's consent before drug-testing her and her child. The complete disregard for the legal rights of motherhood for this Black woman demonstrates how the rights and protections of Black people, women especially, have been consistently violated because of public misconceptions. As such, the misconceptions and over-sensationalized media reports of the war on drugs had and have continued to perpetuate real consequences that have affected the lives of new Black mothers and that have created a system in which Black women are not treated equally compared to their white counterparts.

70

While misconceptions fueled mistreatment, the public's increasingly aggressive outlook on crime simultaneously caused the large phenomenon of mandatory sentencing policies, which created a system of disproportionate punishment, particularly against people of color. In a radio address to the nation in 1982, Ronald Reagan, president at the time, asserted that the "mood toward drugs [was] changing in [America]" and that "the momentum [was] with [the movement]." President Reagan's public statements proved that initiatives of shifting public opinion and appealing to the public, as Mrs. Reagan had just been doing, were highly effective at the time in turning the public tough on crime. In fact, by using the pronoun "we" in his claim that no drugs would be tolerated at all, he was gathering the population in his movement and claiming the war on drugs as a collective initiative that the people had to participate in. Consequently, as the public shifted to a more tough-on-crime mentality, the Anti-Drug Abuse Act of 1988, a key legislative action of the war on drugs, established that once an individual had committed a third offense "after two or more prior convictions for a felony drug offense [had] become final, such person [would] be sentenced to a mandatory term of life imprisonment without release and fined in accordance with the preceding sentence." The Pew Research Center, a reputable non-partisan think tank, exhibited in a 2001 report that endorsement for mandatory minimum sentencing policies and mass incarceration for drug users increased as a result of the fear of drug-related crimes and perception of drugs as a top national priority, even as crime and drug use decreased. Yet, disproportionate convictions existed under the ini-

tatives of mandatory sentencing. This unequal treatment targeted Black drug offenders, as before mandatory sentencing, white people were more likely to be convicted of drug trafficking than Black people were, but this trend reversed as mandatory sentencing appeared. Presidential addresses to the public served to shift the public's opinion on crime to a more punitive one, and this aggressive mentality resulted in policies of minimum mandatory sentencing policies. As such, the system of mandatory sentencing invoked a racial disparity in sentencing, that then has catalyzed not only mass incarceration and overcrowded prisons but also systemic cycles of crime and generational poverty for people of color who further involved themselves in crime as a result of their time in prison and their stigmatized status as felons. These policies fueled by public advocacy have hence created a system in which Black people could not escape the cycle they have been trapped in, enclosed in a box of America's racially unjust history and its persistence in the modern age.

Concurrently, the difference in punitive legal actions in response to powder versus crack cocaine users created a major disparity in the mass incarceration that disproportionately affected Black people. In 1986, the Anti-Drug Abuse Act instituted a policy that a person possessing "500 grams or more of a mixture or substance containing a detectable amount of [...] cocaine" compared to "5 grams or more of a [...] substance [...] which contain[ed] cocaine base [...]" would "be sentenced to a term of imprisonment [...] not [...] less than 5 years and not more than 40 years." However, The Roanoke Times noted in 1996 that crack, being cheaper, was more common in low-income minority communities, which caused 90% of drug offenders sentenced for crack possession to be Black whereas most users of powder cocaine were white. As such, this 100-to-1 disparity between powder and crack cocaine unreasonably targeted more people in low-income communities, even though the two substances shared almost identical chemical compositions and crack did not instigate any more violence than the powdered cocaine. As Craig Reinerman and Harry Levine reviewed in the Social Justice journal, in the middle of the 1980s, crack use spread toward inner cities, consisting primarily of poor African-Americans and Latinos, while before that, users of crack were wealthy, white celebrities, at which point the response to crack use was not imprisonment but rehabilitation. Subsequently, the decision of the court case *State of Minnesota v. Russell* in 1991 agreed that there existed a racial disparity in the users of crack cocaine vs. cocaine powder, which led to a larger percentage of black people being arrested for possession of crack cocaine than white people were. In this case, the threshold for intent to sell, which held a more punitive sentence, was lower for crack cocaine than for powder cocaine, and as users of crack cocaine were more Black

than white individuals, this threshold fueled racially biased mass incarceration. Finally, the Supreme Court of Minnesota affirmed that the distinction was unconstitutional, having violated the equal protection clause of the Constitution's Fourteenth Amendment. Hence, in a country where people espoused justice and celebrated liberty, Black people during the war on drugs lived a contradictory experience, in which their own country violated their supposedly guaranteed rights. The difference in the legislative punishment for powder versus crack cocaine users highlights the inherently racial nature of the war on drugs, where Black men faced both disproportionate violence and punishment for crimes not so different from those of their white counterparts. Also, though the Fair Sentencing Act of 2010 has replaced the previous 100:1 ratio between crack and powder cocaine sentencing with a ratio of 18:1, scientific evidence hereinabove has demonstrated that the dangers of the two substances are not so different that such a ratio may be acquired. Crack versus powder cocaine legislation thus reveals an innate bias that pervaded in the era of the war on drugs and its policies. Furthermore, Nathália Duarte Bard in her article, "Stigma and prejudice: the experience of crack users," confirms that while progress has been made, the effects of this imbalance still ring clear, as crack users face considerably more stigma than cocaine users, glorified from Wall Street to Hollywood as hard-workers using drugs for fun. Consequently, apart from political and social inequality, American culture from the war on drugs, still persistent in the modern-day, has also sustained a system of white worship and Black condemnation.

Though some might argue that both Nixon and Reagan held plans for rehabilitation and research, rehabilitation was neither properly pursued nor were the initiatives of these presidents based on reliable research. If Nixon and Reagan had pursued that rehabilitative approach, the punitive nature of that era, which caused mass incarceration and harsh policing, would then be negated. For example, in a Special Message to Congress in 1969, Nixon, during his presidency, declared that "psychologically dependent regular users and the physically addicted [were] genuinely sick people," and that consequently, "federal, state and private programs of rehabilitation were being operated" and "all Federal prisoners, who [had] been identified as dependent upon drugs, [would] be afforded the most up-to-date treatment available." Yet, Nixon's specific language of the operation of programs and of the promise of treatment disguised the fact that Nixon did not affirm any actual progress or benefit for drug addicts and made only a promise, without results, that prisons would treat drug offenders. Moreover, John Erlichman, a co-conspirator in the Watergate scandal and Assistant to the President of Domestic Affairs during the Nixon administration admit-

ted in a more contemporary interview that Nixon felt he had two problems: “the antiwar left and black people,” which Nixon felt the war on drugs would criminalize “hippies” for their association with marijuana and “blacks” for theirs with heroin, which would allow law enforcement to abuse their power. Accordingly, Nixon could not have advocated for rehabilitation if he wanted to use the war on drugs to punish his two supposed problems. Furthermore, though drug treatment programs did exist to a certain extent in the 1980s, they were only available to less than 5% of the prison population. This unavailability of treatment to the majority of the population hence negates Nixon’s assertions and proves them to be unfounded. Additionally, Ronald Reagan, later on, in believing that drugs could not be controlled and in perceiving that he was at “war,” sought to pour money into law enforcement rather than into rehabilitation and prevention programs, to the extent that 80% of the federal drug budget was allocated to prosecution & policing. Finally, Senator Carey, when he had to face the militarized response to the public on crime in 1988, noted how Reagan was not building the promised treatment centers and that the public was much more focused on punitive action than rehabilitation. Therefore, despite the promise of the creation of rehabilitation centers, neither Nixon nor Reagan fulfilled their assurances to the nation and instead turned to more punitive policies in response to drug use and addiction.

73

The war on drugs’s policies of police militarization in several forms, its shifts in public opinion toward a tough-on-crime stance, and its unequal legislation of crack versus powder cocaine furthered mass incarceration and harsh policing behind the backdrop of a racially-charged American history. As a result of the war on drugs, racially biased mass incarceration & harsh policing have perpetuated cycles of racial inequality and marginalization. As a continuation of the sullied history of America in regards to the treatment of Black people, abused in the justice system, the war on drugs makes it necessary to consider how people contemporarily respond to these injustices, like through movements of Black Lives Matter and Defund the Police, to investigate the efficacy of modern responses to historical controversies. Consequently, though part of society believes that it has progressed from the era of America’s racist past, American systems remain deeply entrenched in the cycles of inequality that have pervaded history and thus require equitable & general affirmative action to break the glass ceiling of systemic racism.

CITATIONS

Aired October 2, 1982. Accessed April 3, 2024. <https://www.presidency.ucsb.edu/documents/radio-address-the-nation-federal-drug-policy>.

Allosso, Dan. "The New Right." In *US History II: Gilded Age to Present*, edited by Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project. Accessed April 11, 2024. <https://mlpp.pressbooks.pub/ushistory2/chapter/the-new-right/>.

Anti-Drug Abuse Act of 1988, 21 U.S.C. § 1501. Accessed April 2, 2024. <https://babel.hathitrust.org/cgi/pt?id=uc1.31210018767325&seq=1&q1=penalty>.

Anti-Drug Abuse Act of 1986, 21 U.S.C. § 801. Accessed April 2, 2024. file:///Users/anaisbricout/Downloads/99TH_CONGRESS_PL_99-570_ANTI-DRUG_ABUSE_ACT_OF_1986.pdf.

74

Bard, Nathália Duarte, Beatriz Antunes, Cristine Moraes Roos, Agnes Olschowsky, and Leandro Barbosa de Pinho. "Stigma and prejudice: the experience of crack users." *Revista Latino-Americana de Enfermagem*, March 28, 2016. Accessed April 12, 2024. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC4809178/>.

Baum, Dan. *Legalize It All*. April 2016. Accessed April 6, 2024. <https://harpers.org/archive/2016/04/legalize-it-all/>.

Baumgart, Zach. "Crime, Arrests, Legitimacy or Race? Militarization of American Police from 1990 to 2007." PhD diss., University of Wisconsin - Madison, 2016. Accessed April 2, 2024. <https://asset.library.wisc.edu/1711.dl/VTYXIMY7HII5N8T/R/file-a371d.pdf>.

Chapman, Roger. "War on Drugs." In *Culture Wars in America: An Encyclopedia of Issues, Viewpoints, and Voices*, 2nd ed., edited by Roger Chapman and James Ciment. N.p.: Routledge, 2010. Credo Reference.

CITATIONS

Daly, Max. "How the War on Drugs Enables Police Brutality Against Black People." *Vice Magazine*, June 8, 2020. Accessed April 3, 2024. <https://www.vice.com/en/article/3azbek/how-war-on-drugs-enables-police-brutality>.

DeAngelis, Reed T. "Systemic Racism in Police Killings: New Evidence from the Mapping Police Violence Database, 2013–2021." *Race and Justice*, October 19, 2021. Accessed April 12, 2024. <https://doi.org/10.1177/21533687211047943>.

Editorial Staff. "Crack vs. Cocaine: Differences & Myths." Editorial. Oxford Treatment Center. Accessed April 16, 2024. <https://oxfordtreatment.com/substance-abuse/cocaine/crack-vs-cocaine/>.

Fair Sentencing Act of 2010, Pub. L. No. 111-220, 124 Stat. 2372. Accessed April 16, 2024. <https://www.congress.gov/111/plaws/publ220/PLAW-111publ220.pdf>.

Fallin, Gregory P., Harry K. Wexler, and Douglas S. Lipton. "Drug Treatment in State Prisons." In *Commissioned Papers on Historical, Institutional, and Economic Contexts of Drug Treatment.*, edited by Gerstein and Harwood. Vol. 2 of *Treating Drug Problems*. Institute of Medicine, 1992. [https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/books/NBK234751/#:~:text=Chaiken%20estimated%20that%2C%20in%201987,programs%20\(Chaiken%2C%201989\)](https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/books/NBK234751/#:~:text=Chaiken%20estimated%20that%2C%20in%201987,programs%20(Chaiken%2C%201989)).

Finamore, Adrianna. "Geeking and Freaking: Black Women and the 1980s Crack Epidemic." *Abstract. California History* 99, no. 2 (2022): 59-80. Accessed April 6, 2024. <https://doi.org/10.1525/ch.2022.99.2.59>.

Free, Marvin D., Jr. "Impact of Federal Sentencing Reforms on African Americans." *Abstract. Journal of Black Studies* 28, no. 2 (1997): 268-86. Accessed April 3, 2024. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2784855?seq=9>.

Knight, Judson. "DEA (Drug Enforcement Administration)." In *Encyclopedia of Espionage, Intelligence and Security*, edited by K. Lee Lerner and Brenda Wilmoth Lerner, 312-15. Vol. 1. Detroit: Gale, 2004. Gale: U.S. History.

CITATIONS

Letson, Al. "American Rehab Chapter 5: Reagan with the Snap." July 25, 2020. In *American Rehab*, narrated by Shoshana Walter. Podcast, audio transcript, 35:16. Accessed April 12, 2024. <https://revealnews.org/podcast/american-rehab-chapter-5-reagan-with-the-snap/>.

Lind, Dara. "Cops do 20,000 no-knock raids a year. Civilians often pay the price when they go wrong." *Vox*. Accessed April 14, 2024. <https://www.vox.com/2014/10/29/7083371/swat-no-knock-raids-police-killed-civilians-dangerous-work-drugs>.

The Montgazette (PA). "Reagan declares war." December 3, 1982, Editorial, 2. Accessed April 2, 2024. https://digitalarchives.powerlibrary.org/papd/islandora/object/papd%3Aamccc-mgztt_2662#page/2/mode/2up.

76 Moore, Lisa D., and Amy Elkavich. "Who's Using and Who's Doing Time: Incarceration, the War on Drugs, and Public Health." *American Journal of Public Health*, May 2008, 782-86. Accessed April 6, 2024. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC2374804/#r7>.

Morin, Richard. "A Public Paradox on the Drug War." *Washington Post*, March 23, 1998. Accessed April 3, 2024. <https://www.washingtonpost.com/wp-srv/politics/polls/wat/archive/wat032398.htm>.

Moss, Thomas W. "Delegate Thomas W. Moss offers bills for state pay hikes for city cops and firemen, and 'stop and frisk' law." Interview. Video. University of Virginia. Posted January 30, 1970. Accessed April 2, 2024. <https://curio.lib.virginia.edu/view/uva-lib:2382641>.

National Defense Authorization Act for Fiscal Year 1997, Pub. L. No. 104-201, 110 Stat. 2422 (Sept. 23, 1996). Accessed April 6, 2024. <https://www.congress.gov/104/plaws/publ201/PLAW-104publ201.pdf>.

CITATIONS

Newman, Andy. "She Smoked Weed, Legally, Then Gave Birth. New York Took Her Baby." *The New York Times*, May 17, 2023. Accessed April 6, 2024. <https://www.nytimes.com/2023/05/17/nyregion/marijuana-mother-child-removed-lawsuit.html?searchResultPosition=4>.

"The 1980s: Law and Justice: Overview." In *American Decades*, edited by Judith S. Baughman, Victor Bondi, Richard Layman, Tandy McConnell, and Vincent Tompkins. Vol. 9. N.p.: Gale, 2001. Gale: U.S. History.

Nixon, Richard. Letter, "Special Message to the Congress on Control of Narcotics and Dangerous Drugs," July 14, 1969. Accessed April 3, 2024. <https://www.presidency.ucsb.edu/documents/special-message-the-congress-control-narcotics-and-dangerous-drugs>.

———. "Remarks About an Intensified Program for Drug Abuse Prevention and Control." Speech presented in the Briefing Room, White House, June 17, 1971. American Presidency Project. Accessed April 2, 2024. <https://www.presidency.ucsb.edu/documents/remarks-about-intensified-program-for-drug-abuse-prevention-and-control>.

Oliver, Mary Beth. "African American Men as 'Criminal and Dangerous': Implications of Media Portrayals of Crime on the 'Criminalization' of African American Men." *Journal of African American Studies* 7, no. 2 (2003): 3-18. JSTOR.

Pew Research Center. *Interdiction and Incarceration Still Top Remedies*. March 21, 2001. Accessed April 3, 2024. <https://www.pewresearch.org/politics/2001/03/21/interdiction-and-incarceration-still-top-remedies/>.

"PUBLIC ENEMY NUMBER ONE: Nixon's War on Drugs (1972)." In *Opinions Throughout History: Drug Use & Abuse*. N.p.: Grey House Publishing, 2018. Credo Reference.

"Race Relations." In *American Decades*, edited by Judith S. Baughman, Victor Bondi, Richard Layman, Tandy McConnell, and Vincent Tompkins. Vol. 9. N.p.: Gale, 2001. Gale: U.S. History.

CITATIONS

Reagan, Nancy, and Ronald Reagan. "Address to the Nation on Drug Abuse Campaign." Address presented in White House, September 14, 1986. Video. Youtube. Posted by Reagan Library, April 27, 2016. Accessed April 6, 2024. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pwpciZ7R8UU>.

Reinarman, Craig, and Harry G. Levine. "Crack in the Rearview Mirror: Deconstructing Drug War Mythology." *Social Justice* 31 (2004): 182-96. Accessed April 3, 2024. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/29768248>.

"THE RISE of THE CARTELS: The International Drug Trade (1980s)." In *Opinions Throughout History: Drug Use & Abuse*. N.p.: Grey House Publishing, 2018. Gale: U.S. History.

78 The Roanoke Times. "THE CRACK-COCAINE DISPARITY." The Roanoke Times (VA), December 30, 1996, Editorial. Accessed April 2, 2024. https://go-gale-com.ezproxy.milton.edu/ps/retrieve.do?tabID=News&resultListType=RESULT_LIST&searchResultsType=SingleTab&retrievalId=6fe7db40-5570-4bae-9b2c-7154d42b8701&hitCount=33&searchType=AdvancedSearchForm¤tPosition=3&docId=-GALE%7CA72529472&docType=Brief+article%2C+Editorial&sort=Relevance&contentSegment=ZXAA-MOD1&prodId=UHIC&pageNum=1&contentSet=GALE%-7CA72529472&searchId=R3&userGroupName=miltona_s_miltona&inPS=true.

Roodman, David. The impacts of incarceration on crime. September 2017. Accessed April 12, 2024. https://www.openphilanthropy.org/files/Focus_Areas/Criminal_Justice_Reform/The_impacts_of_incarceration_on_crime_10.pdf.

Spohn, Cassia. "Criminality and Social Factors." In *Encyclopedia of Race and Racism*, 2nd ed., by Patrick L. Mason. N.p.: Gale, 2013. Credo Reference.

State of Minnesota v. Russell, 477 N.W.2d 866 (Dec. 13, 1991). Accessed April 3, 2024. <https://law.justia.com/cases/minnesota/supreme-court/1991/c3-91-22-2.html>.

CITATIONS

Ten O'Clock News. "Deputy Supt. William Celester." Video. Boston TV News Digital Library. January 2, 1990. Accessed April 3, 2024. https://bostonlocaltv.org/catalog/V_5D-MC0L5K4WQS1NF.

———. "Roxbury demands end to drug crime." Video. Boston TV News Digital Library. August 22, 1988. Accessed April 2, 2024. https://bostonlocaltv.org/catalog/V_X7UBD-DVHS0AOLLJ.

"The War on Drugs: Policing during the War on Drugs Era (1980)." In *Opinions Throughout History: Law Enforcement in America*. N.p.: Grey House Publishing, 2021. Credo Reference.

Winerip, Michael. "Revisiting the 'Crack Babies' Epidemic That Was Not." *The New York Times*, May 20, 2013. Accessed April 6, 2024. <https://www.nytimes.com/2013/05/20/booming/revisiting-the-crack-babies-epidemic-that-was-not.html>.

BREAKING POINT

An Exploration of the Psychosocial Factors Behind the My Lai Massacre

CATTIEN HUYNH

Milton Academy '26

80

The haunting photograph of the moments before American rifles gunned down a group of Vietnamese women and children during the My Lai massacre of 1968 stands as a poignant emblem of one of the darkest and most shameful chapters of United States history. On March 16, 1968, roughly 200 American soldiers entered the village of My Lai and, in a span of four hours, killed an estimated 500 unarmed Vietnamese villagers. The mental poisoning of the soldiers that allowed this slaughter took root in the failures of the military to regulate its troops, failures that began in basic training. From 1965 to 1973, entrenched in a divisive and bloody conflict on foreign land against the communist government of North Vietnam, American soldiers encountered unthinkable violence and savagery. As the Vietnam War toiled on, taking the lives of more and more American men, the resulting public debate over military withdrawal spread throughout the nation, prompting the United States to pressure its army to produce favorable results. Thus, American combat troops implemented policies of attrition motivated by racism and the desire to satiate public discourse. However, failures in leadership in every step of a soldier's path to Vietnam from their beginnings in military training to their physical experience in the foreign country rapidly eroded the men's sense of identity and morality, which materialized in outbursts of extreme hatred and violence. Ultimately, the soldiers found themselves desensitized to killing the enemy, forced to weather the Vietnamese climate while surviving the mines and booby traps, and conditioned to follow orders without question, a confluence of factors that pushed them to commit atrocities like they did with the My Lai massacre. The fragmentation of the soldiers' identities during basic training, followed by the final shattering of their minds in Vietnam, enabled these factors to materialize.

The initial military training, which aimed to equip the young soldiers with the ca-

pability to obey commands and with an indifference to killing, stripped the men of their individuality and fractured their minds. The introductory stage of basic training ordered a class-wide shaving of heads, removing a piece of the cadets' self-expression, their hair, and demanding uniformity from the beginning. Commanding officers disciplined the young and impressionable recruits, many of whom were eighteen or nineteen years old, into believing that the ideal soldier embodied complete obedience and diligence to orders. Private First Class (Pfc.) Timothy Robinson of the Charlie Company (C.Co) Second Battalion wrote in letters home that the army was a "mad world of uniformity" that teaches to "do what you are told and not to think for yourself." During basic training, commanding officers demanded strict adherence to this standard, forcing the soldiers to embrace the notion that they were no longer human, now simply obedient instruments of the military. Marine veteran Gene Holiday stated that:

[Military officials] tore you down. They tore everything civilian out of your entire existence---your speech, your thoughts, your sights, your memory---anything that was civilian they tore out and then they re-built you and made you over. But they didn't build you from there up. First they made you drop down to a piece of grit on the floor. Then they built you back up to being a marine.

Exploiting the unquestionably obedient behavior instilled in the troops, drill sergeants further fragmented the minds of the soldiers with constant training to build a desensitization to death. "In boot camp they gave us bayonets and instructed us to stab at dummies while screaming 'die, die, die,'" remembered Paul Brabant of the First Battalion, 13th Armored Division in a personal interview with Cattien Huynh. The military trained its broken soldiers to become indifferent to the act of killing, enforcing the notion that violent acts were nothing more than carrying out orders. Lieutenant William Calley C. Co First Battalion, the commander of the platoon responsible for the My Lai massacre, recounted in his memoir that: "[the sergeant] said don't slit a man's throat if you don't want a sound: an ughughugh sucking sound[...a] good place to stab a man from behind is down through the shoulder, the sergeant said: the left shoulder, preferably, where the heart is, that's how to kill someone best."

The soldiers, conditioned by their superiors, learned the most optimal methods to eliminate their enemy with ruthless aggression, seeking to carry out their orders with the utmost efficiency. Their training officers replaced the men's sense of humanity and free will with unwavering compliance and obedience. Military correspondent Gustav Hasford of the First Marine Division remembered that his drill instructor told recruits that they

would be turned into “minister[s] of death, praying for war.” The superiors promoted the idea that the sole purpose of the men was to kill. Any free thought or moral objection to orders was silenced. “You still have to do it even if it doesn’t make any sense,” stated Michael Bernhardt C. Co First Battalion, one of the soldiers involved in the My Lai massacre. The loss of the soldier’s individuality and the inhumane violence, conditioned into them during basic training, created the first cracks in their minds and began their descent into thoughtless violence in Vietnam.

Now armed with the ability to kill, the broken soldiers were subsequently mentally prejudiced against the Vietnamese. Once desensitized to death, soldiers were then desensitized to their enemy. General William Westmoreland believed that “the Oriental [did not] put the same high price on life as does the Westerner.” Indeed, he argued that “[I]f life is plentiful, life is cheap in the Orient,” and, “[as] the philosophy of the Orient expresses it, life is not important.” This belief allowed Americans to justify their violence against the Vietnamese, arguing that if their opponent’s race did not put value on life, then there would be no harm in taking it. The racism interwoven into the combat training and military strategy, brought about by a psychologically supposed racist superiority, encouraged a merciless implementation of the skills primed in military school. Classes at military school promoted a casual racism that enforced the perception of Vietnamese people as caricatures rather than real human beings as the inhabitants of Vietnam. Instructors used the term “gook” to refer to the Vietnamese, accompanied by stereotypical descriptions of slanted eyes, to disparage their enemy and remove any essence of humanity within them. This prejudice diminished the Vietnamese from being seen as real humans into nothing more than dangerous enemies that must be conquered. The fear that the Vietnamese desired the blood of Americans loomed over the soldiers’ shoulders, influencing their subsequent actions. Lieutenant Calley wrote in his memoir that his drill instructors’ emphasis that “in combat [they] haven’t friends[...but] enemies” produced his belief that “everyone in Vietnam would do [him] in.” The military teachers instilled a mindset that kept the soldiers on high alert at all times, instructing them to not trust anyone and to stay on guard. Calley decided to embrace this notion. He, alongside the rest of those he trained with, was constantly paranoid that everyone around him was the enemy. With the idea that “everyone is his enemy,” those he encountered lost their humanity in his eyes, stripped down to purely “the enemy,” Gary Garfolo C. Co First Battalion, a perpetrator of the My Lai massacre stated that “you think it’s war [...] and it’s either you or them” during a personal interview. Fighting against those considered both less than human and representative of the antithe-

sis of their combat training, while also fighting to preserve their lives, the soldiers sunk into a brutish state of violence before even stepping foot in Vietnam.

While the men's conditioning before deployment led to the first cracks in their psyches, the unique experience of Vietnam shattered it. Once in Vietnam, the hostile Vietnamese jungle and its scorching climate compiled physical exhaustion upon their mental fatigue. The experience of being in the country forced the soldiers to endure laborious and exhaustive daily activities that further strained their bodies. Pfc. Robinson wrote in letters home that daily tasks included one to twelve mile hikes throughout the mountainous terrain and vast rice paddies while carrying 65-pound packs of gear. The physical demands of each day drained the little energy still remaining in the exhausted men, who slowly crept toward the end of their mental capacity. Corporal Mike Jeffords wrote to his parents that the jungle's unfamiliar 90° heat and humidity of one day combined with the tumultuous monsoon weather of the next assaulted the physical well-being of the men, constantly tormenting them with one extreme after another. The brutal yet volatile atmospheric conditions punished all of its inhabitants who remained helpless to its change, exacerbating the soldiers' daily struggle and raising tensions. American journalist and veteran Philip Caputo wrote that:

For weeks we had to live like primitive men on remote outposts rimmed by alien seas of rice paddies and rain forests. Malaria, blackwater fever, and dysentery... took their toll. The sun scorched us in the dry season, and in the monsoon season we were pounded numb by ceaseless rain. Our days were spent hacking through mountainous jungles whose immensity reduced us to an antlike pettiness.

The merciless environment placed even more strain on the fatigued soldiers, demanding an exhaustive yet unwavering determination for survival. The weary Americans fought in a ground and air war on unforgiving land that unapologetically displayed its spectrum of destructive conditions. The stress of the ruthless environment combined with the apathy to life fractured the soldiers into a similarly merciless and violent group. Furthermore, combat with an enemy concealed by the jungle intertwined adrenaline-soaked battle fatigue with layers of tension and frustration. Journalist Philip Caputo wrote that while enduring the weather and fighting the conditions, troops helplessly waited for incoming Vietnamese assailants to emerge from the dark. Under the shadows of the jungle's thick bushels and dense trees, soldiers anxiously waited on guard for the moment the Viet Cong would attack from their hiding spots in the flora, pushing the men into a state of tense nervousness that threatened to rupture. More specifically, guerrilla-fighting

broke the mentalities of the soldiers. Utilizing a form of warfare that saw the coordination of small surprise attacks that weakened the Americans by attrition, slowly picking them off one by one, the Viet Cong consolidated control over combat. In defending against an enemy that abused their superior knowledge and command of the land to wear down American forces, the stress of needing to stay alert in case of attack at all times created a platoon-wide nervous composition that threatened to snap at any small action. Caputo wrote that:

Some men could not withstand the stress of guerilla-fighting: the hair-trigger awareness constantly demanded of them, the feeling that the enemy was everywhere, the inability to distinguish civilians from combatants created emotional pressures which built to such a point that trivial provocation could make these men explode with the blind destructiveness of a mortar shell.

84

Those who broke under the extreme pressure unleashed a violent and ruthless fury that was facilitated by basic training. Caputo further wrote that the war was a matter of enduring long spans of expectant waiting with random intervals of vicious manhunts throughout the dense jungle where the enemy would pick off the soldiers slowly. However, the instances when Vietnamese chose to fight pitched battles allowed for the release of weeks of bottled-up tensions, seeing bursts of violent screaming and wild gunfire. To worsen the situation, a third of all engagements between the combatants were ambushes, with the Vietnamese executing three times as many as the Americans. The frustrated troops further lost control over the war, bending to the will of the rebels and whether or not they decided to interact. Losing a war to an invisible enemy distressed and angered the troops beyond measure. Despite a constant state of alert, American soldiers still wielded no control over contact with the enemy and continued to be caught off guard. The Viet Cong dictated the flow of battle, controlling the external factors of combat: the time, the preparedness of the opponent, and the location. During ambushes, the rebels maintained power over the Americans. Chaplain Ray Stubbe recalled being awoken at 5 am to the sound of incoming rockets and mortars exploding outside his tent. Even during sleep, a time of supposed peace and calm, soldiers were helpless to the will of their enemy which aimed to kill them. Fighting a seemingly unseen opponent hidden by an oppressive forest destroyed the last bit of the tense soldiers' self-control.

Anger and frustration toward the deaths caused by mines and booby traps provided the final push toward the fragmentation of the soldiers' minds that manifested in the violence in My Lai. On top of the punishing weather and unforeseen ambushes, troops

suffered at the hands of an intangible enemy: mines and booby traps. During the weeks before the My Lai massacre, in the Charlie Company's unit of little more than 120, four men were killed, and 38 were wounded by explosives and traps. With the small number of interactions that physically staked the American men against other men, the soldiers grew increasingly frustrated at the lack of direct action they could react with. The absence of a physical enemy wrecked the psychologies of the soldiers who found themselves lost in how to react or avenge their allies. The distinction between civilian and combatant quickly eroded as their anger clouded their judgment. Jocko Willink remembered that his high school teacher once said that

We would walk around a village and one of our guys would hit a booby trap every-day, every other day. And the villagers are out there walking on the same trails, but they're not getting blown up. And so, after weeks and then months of this happening, of me losing two guys, three guys, six guys, getting blown up, getting killed, losing their legs, losing their arms, losing their lives. And the Vietnamese villagers aren't hitting anything. Eventually in our minds, they become guilty.

The frustration of constantly losing their men to an unseen enemy's devices compounded the stress of being in Vietnam, which turned their attention toward the civilians. Their anger and disappointment toward themselves for being helpless in stopping the continuous loss of life was alleviated by placing the guilt onto innocent villagers. Garfalo from C. Co admitted that "[they] were feeling pretty down about all these people that were getting hit by these mines[...] There's nothing [they could] do about it. A lot of [them] wanted a little bit of revenge [...] to see them and get into them because they were always hiding." With a physical human being to assign culpability for the deaths of their comrades, despite no tangible evidence that they were liable, the soldiers reclaimed control and were able to avenge their comrades. The desperate hunger for retribution drove the broken men toward the indiscriminate violence in the My Lai massacre.

The need for revenge and the desire to complete "the mission" culminated in the definitive order to wipe out My Lai the night before. General Ernest Medina, fueled by the burning desire for revenge, briefed his platoon to be indiscriminate in killing the villagers. General Medina instructed that "when we go into My Lai, it's open season. When we leave, nothing will be living. Everything's going to go. Nothing [will] be walking, growing, or crawling. They're all VCs, now go in and get them. We owe them something."

Hours before the massacre, the superiors commanded the troops to lay waste to the village, encouraging a mindset that viewed every Vietnamese person as the enemy, which,

combined with the intense desire for revenge, caused the ruthless and chaotic bloodbath of the My Lai massacre. Gary Garfalo recalled that General Medina “said shoot everything[...] that could aid the VC (Viet Cong). Every living thing, that was the order.” The soldiers felt as though they were simply following orders, a mindset their training had prepared them to assume. Their mission to be the perfect soldier, carrying out orders without question—along with their desire for an excuse to release their insurmountable feelings of frustration and stress—took over any moral objection in their mind. Garry Crossley C. Co First Battalion stated in a personal interview that “this is the type of thing that during training you’re told to do.[...] You don’t question it,” and, to an interview question about if a search and destroy mission justified brutalizing the people, he responded “right.” Not only did the environment and tensions create a hostile realm, their superiors encouraged violence. The soldiers were motivated to avenge their fellow soldiers with the only language they understood: violence. This savageness did not spare anyone. Varnado Simpson C. Co First Battalion argued that they believed that every villager was either Viet Cong or had the potential to grow into one so all inhabitants of My Lai, including the children, were to be disposed of. The paranoia and stress of fighting in Vietnam had shattered their minds, to the point of justifying pedicide. The final shattering of the men’s minds, exploited by their superiors, resulted in the violence of the destruction of My Lai.

The My Lai massacre of 1968 exemplified the systemic erosion of the soldiers’ moral compasses and the psychological toll of warfare on American soldiers during the Vietnam War era. The atrocity epitomized the disastrous consequences of a rapid breakdown of the human psyche, that in 1968 was cultivated by the desensitization to killing and the enemy, the Vietnamese climate and terrain, the threat of mines and booby traps, and the adherence to a culture of unquestioning obedience. The factors that compiled into such a tragedy provides an understanding of the psychological damage caused by the failures ingrained into American systems. Demolishing the long-standing myth of American exceptionality and forcing the world to confront the reality that Americans are as susceptible to barbarity as any other nationality under the appropriate circumstances, the senseless violence seen in 1968 stands not as an isolated incident, but rather as the shining example of the failure of the American government to properly discipline its troops and enforce combat ethics. With the term “My Lai” being synonymous with the atrocities of war, the massacre serves as a lesson to the world of the horrific dangers of unchecked power on the human condition and the barbaric nature of war, reminding us of historian Roger Spiller’s declaration that “we are all one step away from My Lai.”

CITATIONS

Appy, Christian G. *Patriots: The Vietnam War Remembered from All Sides*. New York: Penguin Books, 2004.

Appy, Christian G. *Working-class War: American Combat Soldiers and Vietnam*. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1993. Digital file.

Bilton, Michael, and Kevin Sim. *Four Hours in My Lai*. New York: Viking, 1992.

Brabant, Paul. Interview by the author. Braintree, MA. April 14, 2024.

Calley, William Laws, and John Sack. *Lieutenant Calley: His Own Story*. New York: Viking Press, 1971.

Carroll, Andrew. *War Letters: Extraordinary Correspondence from American Wars*. New York: Simon & Schuster, 2002.

87

Dunnigan, James F., and Albert A. Nofi. *Dirty Little Secrets of the Vietnam War*. New York: Thomas Dunne Books, 1999.

“Four Hours in MY LAI, Anatomy of a Massacre.” Video. Posted February 2015. Accessed April 7, 2024. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1NwnnLnvQYA>.

Haeberle, Ronald. *A Group of Civilian Women and Children before Being Killed by the U.S. Army during the Massacre*. Photograph. March 16, 1968. Digital file.

“Interviews with Veterans of My Lai.” Video. Youtube. Posted by Veterans for Peace Chapter 180- Fresno, March 2018. Accessed April 5, 2024. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Vp-6WFSXO4o>.

“Jocko Podcast 31 with Echo Charles - ‘Four Hours in My Lai’ Book Review.” Video. Posted July 15, 2016. Accessed April 7, 2024. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Wb-ceeWI1gOs>.

CITATIONS

Leffler, Warren K. Young Soldier Who Has Just Been Drafted into the U.S. Army, Getting His Head Shaved by a Barber at Fort Jackson, Columbia, South Carolina. Photograph. May 15, 1967. JPEG.

McMahon, Robert J. Major Problems in the History of the Vietnam War: Documents and Essays. 4th ed. Boston, MA: Houghton Mifflin, 2008.

Peers, William R., Joseph Goldstein, Burke Marshall, and Jack Schwartz. The My Lai Massacre and Its Cover-up: Beyond the Reach of Law? : the Peers Commission Report. New York: Free Press, 1976. Digital file.

Sim, Kevin, and Michael Bilton. Four Hours in My Lai. London: Penguin, 1993.

MADISON AND THE FEDERAL NEGATIVE

SUMMER GIRARD

Bridgewater-Raynham Regional High School

During the post-Revolutionary War era, after fighting for seven years to separate itself from Great Britain, the newly formed United States was struggling to establish a functioning and stable country. The weak economic status post-war did not help in this endeavor. According to historian Kenneth Moss, "Congress had accumulated 27 million in debt during the war." This debt resulted from the cost of fighting the war and from borrowing money from their allies like the French Republic. The loans needed to be paid back immediately to improve the country's credit; however, the Articles of Confederation, the document that, at the time, gave the federal government its power, did not allow the government to impose national taxes. To combat this, most of the debt was passed on to the states, and in turn, Moss states, "many state governments raised taxes to pay off war debts." This aided in the economic recession which left many citizens in difficult financial positions. Individual debtors found it difficult to pay back their obligations. Additionally, soldiers from the war had to accept bonds as payments. Consequently, many people started petitioning for debt relief. State legislators responded to this "by issuing substantial amounts of paper money, thereby allowing debtors to repay their debts in inflated currency" (Moss). While a good idea in theory, the more money that was in circulation, the less value it held, causing in high inflation rates.

89

Like many of the other founding fathers, James Madison was a well-educated and well-read man. During the post-revolutionary era, he studied a multitude of books spanning thousands of years that he hoped would provide insight on how to improve the United States government. His readings ranged from ancient Greek confederacies to recent French works from the Enlightenment, and "he noted that several confederation

governments had been unable to control their members, even in areas where they held explicit authority” (Moss 9). Madison connected the failures of these past confederacies to the struggles of the United States, drawing the conclusion that more power at the federal level was necessary to uphold a nation. These theories were in fact true; the new government already seemed to be failing under the authority of the Articles of Confederation. For example, in the Shays’ rebellion, “Daniel Shays was so angry at the plight of the farmers [...] [that] he helped to lead a growing rebellion in western Massachusetts”, which the federal government was useless in stopping (Moss 8). This and other incidents like the struggling economy and the states’ disregard for the Treaty of Paris proved that a stronger government was of the utmost importance for the longevity of the United States.

90 During the Constitutional Convention, James Madison and other delegates from across the United States came together in 1785 to discuss amending the Articles of Confederation. It is here where Madison first proposed the accumulation of all his readings, the federal negative. In summary, the federal negative gives the federal government the power to veto laws. Madison proposed a partial federal negative which “limited Congress’s veto to only state laws contriving in the opinion of the national legislator” and “all laws which Congress should judge to be improper” (Moss 14). However, there were discussions of an absolute federal negative in which all laws could be vetoed by the government; yet, these discussions provoked fear in some as they believed this would “enslave the states” (Moss 15). Additionally, this power could help stop the conflict between states and could make it more difficult for foreign nations to take advantage of the United States as a whole.

ENSLAVEMENT, ABORTION, AND "RACE SUICIDE"

White Supremacist Reproductive Control in the Modern
Era

EMILIA RAVOILA

Milton Academy '26

Abortion is often defined as a modern-day issue. While it is true that the last fifty years have been significant in the debate over reproductive rights, abortion has been contentious in the United States since before the country's founding. In the antebellum United States, enslavers controlled enslaved women's reproduction in order to expand the institution of slavery. Midwives, many of them women of color, initially provided the majority of reproductive care on plantations. However, because midwives were more likely to participate in resistance against slavery, such as by providing abortions, white male doctors replaced the majority of midwives by the late nineteenth century. After the abolition of slavery in 1865, white male doctors saw how lucrative obstetrics and gynecology could be and sought to monopolize the industry, pushing midwives out of the field and using abortion bans as a strategy to do so. The eugenics movement of the late 1800s, fueled by white supremacy and fears of "race suicide"—the imagined end of the white race—motivated further reproductive control and restrictions. Additionally, the xenophobic response to increased immigration to the U.S. in the late 1800s and early 1900s exacerbated this control. White supremacist ideologies initiated reproductive restrictions in the U.S.; this motivation began with control over reproduction during slavery, continued with medicalization of reproduction, and persisted within the eugenics and anti-immigration movements in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries.

91

In a pre-Civil War America with an economy built upon the labor of enslaved people, midwives provided essential reproductive care. The first enslaved people in the U.S. colonies were "forced on to Virginia's shores by a Dutchman in 1619." While European indentured labor had been the norm in the colonies up until that point, "by 1675 slavery

was well established...With plentiful land and slave labor available to grow a lucrative crop, southern planters prospered, and family-based tobacco plantations became the economic and social norm.” Bacon’s Rebellion in 1676 solidified slavery on a governmental level. Mary Elliott and Jazmine Hughes write that “in the wake of Bacon’s Rebellion, in which free and enslaved black people aligned themselves with poor white people...against the government, more stringent laws were enacted that defined status based on race and class. Black people in America were being enslaved for life, while the protections of whiteness were formalized.” With legislation like this, slavery became a form of racialized control of people and their labor, and, as a result, reproduction became a crucial issue. Reproduction served to protect the future of slavery; thus, enslavers sought to control it. Abortion didn’t become a nationally contentious issue in the United States until the 1800s. Annalies Winny writes that before then, “the U.S. attitude toward abortion was much the same as it had often been elsewhere throughout history: It was a quiet reality, legal until ‘quickening’ (when fetal motion could be felt by the mother). In the eyes of the law, the fetus wasn’t a ‘separate distinct entity until then,’ but rather an extension of the mother.” Reproductive care was largely unregulated—skilled midwives provided essential care. Midwifery was interracial, as half of reproductive healthcare providers were Black women, and others were Indigenous and white. “In colonial times, midwifery reflected women from all backgrounds, including enslaved Black women, who worked as enslaved midwives in the antebellum South...midwives learned through apprenticeship from experienced, older midwives. They traveled to homes to care for mothers and their babies. Midwives were critical to their communities and often the only primary care providers.” In the context of the institution of slavery, midwives were essential.

Extensive control over reproduction by enslavers and by governments allowed for the strengthening and perpetuation of the institution of American slavery. In 1662, legislators in Virginia passed a law determining that “all children borne in this country shalbe held bond or free only according to the condition of the mother.” This law made slavery legally hereditary and made it profitable for white enslavers to get the women they enslaved pregnant. Reproduction was therefore the foundation of the perpetuation of slavery. On January 1, 1808, the Act to Prohibit the Importation of Slaves took effect federally, making it illegal to import enslaved people into the United States. This furthered the impacts of the 1662 legislation—with no option to import slaves, enslavers further depended on reproductive control over enslaved women. As sociologist Rodney Coates writes, “with this shift, enslavers stepped up the forced breeding of enslaved women. White men raped

the Black women and girls they enslaved, and then enslaved the children born from those rapes. White men also forced the Black women and Black men they enslaved to have sex with one another to generate more babies, who would be born into slavery." Enslavers saw how vital reproduction was to the institution of slavery, and as a result they sought to control it. Founding father, slave owner, and President Thomas Jefferson highlighted this abuse by enslavers in an 1819 letter, stating, "a child raised every 2 years is of more profit than the crop of the best laboring man... it is not their labor, but their increase which is the first consideration with us." Slavery was built upon the reproduction of Black women, and enslavers sought to capitalize on slavery by controlling that reproduction.

Enslaved women found ways to resist this control of their bodies; many of these methods of resistance were supported and led by midwives. "Enslaved women understood that their childbearing and rearing lay at the foundation of slavery," writes historian Signe Fourmy. "Consequently, preventing pregnancy or terminating a pregnancy represented more than an exercise of bodily autonomy, which was an act of resistance in and of itself; it represented a refusal to perform the labor deemed necessary for enslaved women." "The social value of midwives' roles cannot be underestimated under the oppressions of slavery," write sociologists Keisha Goode and Barbara Katz Rothman. On the historical significance of midwives, the National Museum of African American History and Culture notes that "early African American midwives were important members of their community, even among enslaved individuals. Slave owners used these medical practitioners to ensure the health of their reproducing enslaved women and their newborn infants to expand their labor force." Midwives were integral in the plantation system because they provided essential care to enslaved women. Sometimes, this essential care included providing abortion and contraceptive services without the knowledge of enslavers, a practice which enslavers sought to disrupt. One such instance was in 1860 in Rutherford County, Tennessee, when enslavers and doctors hoping to remedy the enslaved women in the county's lack of reproduction met to discuss the issue. Politician John T. Morgan stated that efforts "to effect an abortion" included using "tansy, rue, roots and seeds of the cotton plant, pennyroyal, cedar gum, and camphor." Enslaved women, many led by midwives, found ways to resist the dehumanization and commodification of their bodies through enslavement by refusing to have children. The ensuing debate in Rutherford County "centered on whether instances of infertility resulted from enslaved women's 'want of attention and care,' their harsh working conditions, or, perhaps even more troubling to the planters and doctors, deliberate interference," explains Fourmy. An anonymous doctor told of a man who enslaved "four

to six slave women of the proper age to breed for twenty-five years” to whom “only two children had been born.” “Eventually,” writes Fourmy, “the enslaved women confessed and identified ‘the weed’ they used to obtain the desired effect. The same physician recounted that on another plantation an “old negro woman” admitted to having supplied ‘the remedy’ to fellow bondwomen.” Contraception and abortion represented a resistance to slavery for many enslaved women, and midwives helped to provide those services.

94

Because midwives often provided contraception and abortion services to enslaved women, enslavers began to lose trust in them and turn to white male doctors—this shift on plantations was in fact the violent origin of modern gynecology. Coates writes that enslavers made this change “to figure out why nearly half of enslaved infants were stillborn or died within their first year of life and why so many enslaved women were infertile.” They suspected that midwives had something to do with it. White male doctors soon attained a larger role in the plantation system. “Physicians collaborated with slave owners in efforts to increase fertility among slaves...Obstetric cases allowed physicians the opportunity to develop a burgeoning practice by experimenting and acquiring skills on the bodies of enslaved women,” write Goode and Rothman. This abusive involvement shaped the future of gynecology. White doctors not only “participated in the maintenance of the plantation regime and of labor increase by overseeing and interfering in the births of enslaved children,” explains historian Crystal Webster, but also “violently experimented on Black women without anesthesia or consent.” One of these white doctors, J. Marion Sims, known as the “father of modern gynecology,” conducted much of his research on slaves who were rarely given anesthesia. “Physician dominance of birth was beginning to take a strong hold,” write Goode and Rothman, “while in the beginning of the 19th century the majority...of white plantation births were attended by midwives...by 1860, an estimated 40-50 percent of plantation mistresses were delivered by physicians.” While midwives initially provided care to enslaved women, white male doctors soon replaced them to increase enslavers’ control—this was the origin of modern gynecology.

From the 1800s to the 1900s, the U.S. saw a larger shift: the medicalization of reproductive care, fueled by racism, misogyny, and economic greed; this medicalization began a larger trend of abortion bans and reproductive restrictions in the country and was deeply rooted in enslavement. Although white male doctors had started to replace midwives in the plantation system in the early nineteenth century, midwives still provided the vast majority of reproductive care in the United States through the early 1900s. “Skilled Black midwives represented both real competition for white men who sought to

enter the practice of child delivery, and a threat to how obstetricians viewed themselves. Male gynecologists claimed midwifery was a degrading means of obstetrical care. They viewed themselves as elite members of a trained profession with tools such as forceps and other technologies, and the modern convenience of hospitals, which excluded Black and Indigenous women from practice within their institutions," writes legal scholar Michele Goodwin. These physicians, who had learned much of their knowledge from violent and cruel experiments on enslaved women, felt threatened by midwives, especially Black midwives. The Planned Parenthood Action Fund has reported that "starting around the time of the Civil War, a coalition of male doctors...led a movement to push state governments to outlaw abortion across the board. The male-dominated medical profession wanted to take authority from the female-dominated profession of midwives, including the authority to provide abortion." White male doctors, many of whom were prejudiced against these midwives, saw how lucrative obstetrics could be. One institution, the American Medical Association, established in 1847, saw abortion as an easy target. "Their rhetoric was strategic," says Mary Fissell, a History of Medicine Professor at Johns Hopkins University. "You have to link those midwives to providing abortion as a way of kind of getting them out of business," Fissell says. "So organized medicine very much takes the anti-abortion position." White physician Horatio Storer wrote in 1866 that "induced abortions are not only a crime against life...against the mother...against nature and all natural instinct, and against public interests and morality, but that...they are so dangerous to the woman's health, her own physical and domestic best interests, that their induction, permittal, or solicitation by one cognizant of their true character, should almost be looked upon as proof of actual insanity." Storer, who was motivated by racist beliefs, made false statements such as this one in order to further restrict women's access to reproductive care. Fissell writes that "in 1857, the AMA took aim at unregulated abortion providers with a letter-writing campaign pushing state lawmakers to ban the practice. To make their case, they asserted that there was a medical consensus that life begins at conception, rather than at quickening...The campaign succeeded. At least 40 anti-abortion laws went on the books between 1860 and 1880." Such efforts by the medical community were the deciding factor in the initial banning of abortion in the United States. The Virginia State Board of Health wrote in a 1913 letter that if "the midwife is shown beyond question to be a source of danger and death, then the state cannot refrain from stepping in and protecting her citizens." Doctors were the force that brought about the first large-scale abortion bans and reproductive restrictions, effectively pushing out midwives from gynecology and medicalizing the field.

Doctors' efforts to ban abortion, and therefore replace midwives, were largely successful, but they continued to try to monopolize reproductive care by creating and perpetuating discriminatory misinformation and stereotypes against midwives. In the 1900s, these doctors began to carry out "successful racist and misogynistic smear campaigns, cleverly designed for political persuasion and to achieve legal reform," writes Goodwin. Physician Joseph Delee stated in a 1916 speech that "the midwife destroys obstetric ideals... The midwife is a relic of barbarism. In civilized countries the midwife is wrong, has always been wrong... The midwife has been a drag on the progress of the science and art of obstetrics. Her existence stunts the one and degrades the other." White male doctors continued to spread misinformation about midwives in order to monopolize care. In his 1926 journal article titled "The Development of Midwifery in Mississippi," Dr. Felix Underwood, a physician and the director of the Bureau of Child Hygiene for Mississippi, wrote, "what could be a more pitiable picture than that of a prospective mother housed in an unsanitary home and attended in this most critical period by an accoucheur, filthy and ignorant, and not far removed from the jungles of Africa, laden with its atmosphere of weird superstition and voodooism." Doctors were explicitly trying to undermine midwives, ban abortion, and perpetuate white supremacy, and they used racist rhetoric and stereotypes to further their agenda. Their strategy was successful: "gynecologists pushed women out of the field of reproductive health... Doing so not only undercut women's reproductive health, but also drove qualified Black women out of medical services," writes Goodwin. "Gynecologists explicitly revealed their motivations in undermining midwifery: They desired financial gains... and a monopoly. As DeLee wrote in a 1916 article published in the *American Journal of Obstetrics & Disease of Women & Children*, 'There is high art in obstetrics and... it must pay as well'... [Doctors] believed that men should be paid, but not women — particularly not Black women." White male doctors saw how lucrative obstetrics were, and they advocated against midwives, creating racist and misogynistic stereotypes and successfully pushing Black midwives out of obstetrics.

After white male doctors had successfully outlawed abortion in the US, the eugenics movement, which stemmed in slavery and white supremacy, furthered reproductive restrictions, especially on women of color. "The goal of eugenic science was knowledge of how various traits — emotional, physical, intellectual — were inherited, so that such information could be applied in order to advance the human race and preserve imagined racial superiority," writes University of Virginia Professor of Medicine P. Preston Reynolds. "While Jefferson is credited with the language, 'all men are created equal,'" Reynolds

Enslavement, Abortion, and "Race Suicide": Modern White Supremacist Reproductive Control writes, "he also argued 'any attempt to assimilate [blacks] with the American polity is a greater threat to the integrity of the republic than naturalizing immigrants.' Jefferson paved the way for eugenicists by providing a rationale that harmonized their theories... Just as Jefferson argued that 'self preservation' was the nation's highest moral imperative, and its 'first law of nature,'... eugenicists sought to deprive the procreative liberties of blacks, poor whites and the mentally defective to prevent them from destroying the lives of other Virginians (particularly, affluent whites) through genetic pollution." This racist ideology originated in the slavery era. Eugenics was a continuation of the white supremacist views that had attempted to justify enslavement for centuries. Storer wrote in 1866 that "abortion... strikes a blow at the very foundation of society itself," expressing his fears that white women weren't reproducing enough. These same eugenicist arguments were pervasive in the early 1900s, pushing governments to further regulate access to reproductive care. At the turn of the twentieth century, infertility became an obsession for the eugenics movement, and in 1903, President Theodore Roosevelt spoke openly about "race suicide," a perceived threat that white people faced in losing the birthing numbers game to immigrants and minorities. "From 1907 to 1932, 32 states passed explicit eugenics laws that allowed for the government to sterilize the 'insane,' the 'feebleminded,' the 'dependent' and the 'diseased.'" Many of these laws were used as an excuse to sterilize racial minorities, taking away people's ability to have children. The Equal Justice Initiative finds that these forced sterilization laws were "used as a tool of racialized population control. From the 1920s to 1970s, thousands of poor, Southern Black women were sterilized without their knowledge or consent... compulsory programs sterilized an estimated 65,000 individuals in more than 30 states, and the number is likely much higher." Virginia's 1924 Racial Integrity Act, yet another example of eugenicist policy, banned interracial marriage, defining a white person as having 'no trace of the blood of another race.'" This legislation further demonstrates people's fear of the idea of "race suicide." The eugenics movement, based in long-established white supremacist ideologies, perpetuated efforts to limit women of color's reproduction by forcing sterilization and increase white women's reproduction by banning abortion.

97

These efforts to control people's reproduction were not only "justified" by eugenics but also by xenophobic and anti-immigrant beliefs—again, attempts to curb access to reproductive care were motivated by white supremacist ideas. Historians Ramtin Arablouei and Rund Abdelfatah explain that when Dr. Storer had argued against abortion in the 1800s, "he had fears of... what was commonly referred to as race suicide, that the [white population] wasn't going to replenish itself fast enough to keep up with the swells of new

immigrants to the United States.” Goodwin writes that “the racist campaigns launched by doctors against Black midwives extended to anti-immigration legislative platforms targeted at Chinese and Japanese workers. The Page Act, which restricted Chinese women from entering the United States, is a part of this shameful legacy...DeLee and...Storer urged white women to ‘spread their loins’ across the nation, a dog whistle about the threat of too many Blacks and Asians in the U.S.” Xenophobia and fears of a decreasing white population contributed to reproductive restrictions. Alex Samuels and Monica Potts write that “laws limiting abortion, it was believed, would ultimately force middle- and upper-class white women...to bear more white children...this helped bolster flawed, racist arguments for a total ban of the procedure.” The anti-immigration movement, deeply rooted in white supremacy, pushed bans on abortion and reproductive restrictions in the early 1900s.

98

White supremacy has informed almost every reproductive restriction in United States history. White supremacist control over enslaved people’s reproduction during slavery, racist attacks against midwifery, and later eugenics and anti-immigration arguments all enabled abortion bans and reproductive restrictions. The subjugation of bodies in the United States, specifically of women of color, has a centuries-long legacy that did not end with the abolition of slavery. Today, huge inequities in access to abortion and reproductive care hurt low income and marginalized groups. The contemporary debate over abortion bans echoes the debates over slavery in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. “Like the battle over slavery, the fight over reproductive freedom raises questions about federal and state authority — in other words, who gets to make the rules,” writes historian Kate Masur. The overturning of *Roe v. Wade* “has created for pregnant women an analogous situation to the fugitive slave laws...where women may be prosecuted by the state in which they reside for obtaining an abortion beyond its borders. It will create legal chaos, triggering inter-state conflict, as fights over extradition and a state’s legal rights beyond its own borders will certainly erupt once more,” writes University of London Professor Sarah Churchwell. The debate over abortion today is reminiscent of the debates over slavery from centuries ago, because the two issues are very much intertwined: abortion bans have historically been rooted in white supremacy. Both debates, similarly to other contentious issues in our country’s history, have been driven by the desire of white men to maintain power.

CITATIONS

“Act Prohibiting the Importation of Slaves.” Southern New Hampshire University.

<https://libguides.snhu.edu/c.php?g=1184812&p=8902755#:~:text=The%201807%20Act%20to%20Prohibit,%2C%20Section%209%2C%20Clause%201.>

“African Slavery in Colonial British North America.” Thomas Jefferson’s Monticello.

Accessed April 10, 2024. <https://www.monticello.org/slavery/paradox-of-liberty/african-slavery-in-colonial-british-north-america/>.

Arablouei, Ramtin, and Rund Abdelfatah. “Abortion Was Once Common Practice in America. a Small Group of Doctors Changed That.” June 6, 2022. In History. Podcast,

audio, 08:06. Accessed March 7, 2024. <https://www.npr.org/2022/06/06/1103372543/abortion-was-once-common-practice-in-america-a-small-group-of-doctors-changed-th.>

Babic, Indira, and Emilie Richardson. “Abortion in America: A Visual Timeline.” ABC

News. Accessed April 4, 2024. <https://abcnews.go.com/Politics/abortion-america-visual-timeline/story?id=85588254.>

99

Baird, Robert P. “The invention of whiteness: the long history of a dangerous idea.” The

Guardian, April 20, 2021. Accessed April 18, 2024. <https://www.theguardian.com/news/2021/apr/20/the-invention-of-whiteness-long-history-dangerous-idea.>

Beeferman, Jason. “University of Illinois Prof. Hogarth talks eugenics and its roots in slavery.” The Daily Northwestern (Evanston, IL), February 10, 2020. Accessed March

8, 2024. <https://dailynorthwestern.com/2020/02/10/campus/university-of-illinois-prof-hogarth-talks-eugenics-and-its-roots-in-slavery/>.

Bowie, Jamelle. “What the Contradiction of Slavery Tells Us about Abortion Rights.” The

New York Times, September 2, 2023. <https://www.nytimes.com/2023/09/02/opinion/slavery-abortion-rights-laws.html.>

CITATIONS

“A Brief History of Midwifery in America.” Oregon Health and Science University. Accessed April 9, 2024. <https://www.ohsu.edu/womens-health/brief-history-midwifery-america#:~:text=In%20the%20early%20parts%20of,United%20States%20births%20in%202020.>

Buck v. Bell, 200 U.S. (May 2, 1927). Accessed March 28, 2024. <https://supreme.justia.com/cases/federal/us/274/200/>.

Churchwell, Sarah. “Body politics: the secret history of the US anti-abortion movement.” The Guardian. Accessed March 7, 2024. <https://www.theguardian.com/books/2022/jul/23/body-politics>.

Coates, Rodney. “White men have controlled women’s reproductive rights throughout American history – the post-Dobbs era is no different.” The Conversation, September 1, 2023. Accessed March 7, 2024. <https://theconversation.com/white-men-have-controlled-womens-reproductive-rights-throughout-american-history-the-post-dobbs-era-is-no-different-206706>.

Craven, Christa, and Mara Glatzel. “Downplaying Difference: Historical Accounts of African American Midwives and Contemporary Struggles for Midwifery.” *Feminist Studies* 36, no. 2 (2010): 330-58. JSTOR.

Dawson, Shay. “Mary Treadwell.” National Women’s History Museum. Accessed February 29, 2024. <https://www.womenshistory.org/education-resources/biographies/mary-treadwell>.

Delee, Joseph B. “Progress toward Ideal Obstetrics.” *The American Journal of Obstetrics and Diseases of Women and Children* (1869-1919) 73, no. 3 (1916). <https://www.proquest.com/openview/35c075d58b5f79bfa12ba4fbb5d0c5be/1?c-bl=39586&pq-origsite=gscholar&parentSessionId=UrvnMtxJ51RwdqCJntjq0qZQcyp-SEzl4VI8QTGO6uck%3D>.

Dyer, Justin Buckley. “Constitutional Confusion: Slavery, Abortion, and Substantive PRISM: YOUTH JOURNAL OF HISTORY AND SOCIAL SCIENCE

CITATIONS

Constitutional Analysis.” *The American Journal of Economics and Sociology* 76, no. 1 (2017): 33-64. JSTOR.

Elliott, Mary, and Jazmine Hughes. “A Brief History of Slavery That You Didn’t Learn in School.” *The New York Times*, August 19, 2019. Accessed April 8, 2024. <https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2019/08/19/magazine/history-slavery-smithsonian.html>.

The Fertility Race. Aired on Minnesota Public Radio. Accessed April 19, 2024. http://news.minnesota.publicradio.org/features/199711/20_smiths_fertility/part1/f4.shtml.

Fourmy, Signe Peterson. “‘She Had Smothered Her Baby on Purpose’: Enslaved Women and Maternal Resistance.” *Age of Revolutions*. Accessed March 7, 2024. <https://ageof-revolutions.com/2022/07/25/she-had-smothered-her-baby-on-purpose-enslaved-women-and-maternal-resistance/>.

Goode, Keisha, and Barbara Katz Rothman. “African-American Midwifery, a History and a Lament.” *The American Journal of Economics and Sociology* 76, no. 1 (2017): 65-94. JSTOR.

101

Goodwin, Michele. “The Racist History of Abortion and Midwifery Bans.” *American Civil Liberties Union*. Last modified July 1, 2020. Accessed February 29, 2024. <https://www.aclu.org/news/racial-justice/the-racist-history-of-abortion-and-midwifery-bans>.

Hall, Stephanie. “Beyond 1619: Slavery and the Cultures of America.” *Library of Congress Blogs*. Entry posted August 28, 2019. Accessed April 10, 2024. <https://blogs.loc.gov/folklife/2019/08/beyond-1619/>.

“The Historical Significance of Doulas and Midwives.” *National Museum of African American History and Culture*. Accessed April 8, 2024. <https://nmaahc.si.edu/explore/stories/historical-significance-doulas-and-midwives#:~:text=Early%20African%20American%20midwives%20were,to%20expand%20their%20labor%20force>.

CITATIONS

“Hyde Amendment.” Planned Parenthood. Accessed February 29, 2024. <https://www.plannedparenthoodaction.org/issues/abortion/federal-and-state-bans-and-restrictions-abortion/hyde-amendment>.

Jefferson, Thomas. Letter to Joel Yancy, January 17, 1819. Accessed March 7, 2024. <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/03-13-02-0522>.

Katie Relf v. Casper Weinberger, 1 Justia Law (U.S.D.C. District of Columbia Mar. 15, 1974). Accessed March 8, 2024. <https://www.splcenter.org/seeking-justice/case-docket/relf-v-weinberger>.

Lockhart, P.R. “New York just removed a statue of a surgeon who experimented on enslaved women.” Vox. Last modified April 18, 2018. Accessed February 29, 2024. <https://www.vox.com/identities/2018/4/18/17254234/j-marion-sims-experiments-slaves-women-gynecology-statue-removal>.

102

Masur, Kate. “What Pre-Civil War History Tells Us about the Coming Abortion Battle.” The Washington Post, July 14, 2022. Accessed February 28, 2024. <https://www.washingtonpost.com/made-by-history/2022/07/14/what-pre-civil-war-history-tells-us-about-coming-abortion-battle/>.

The midwife in Virginia. Richmond: Commonwealth of Virginia, State Board of Health, Bureau of Vital Statistics, 1913. [archive.org](https://www.archive.org/details/midwifeinvirginia).

Nayak, Anika. “The History That Explains Today’s Shortage of Black Midwives.” Time, February 29, 2024. Accessed April 1, 2024. <https://time.com/6727306/black-midwife-shortage-history/>.

“Negro womens children to serve according to the condition of the mother”, No. XII, 1662 Va. Acts. Accessed April 8, 2024. <https://encyclopediavirginia.org/1448-130aa14e39d5a5a/>.

CITATIONS

The New Virginia Law to Preserve Racial Integrity, Va. Acts (Mar. 8, 1924). Library of Virginia.

New-York Historical Society. "Legislating Reproduction and Racial Difference." Women and the American Story. Accessed April 15, 2024. <https://wams.nyhistory.org/early-encounters/english-colonies/legislating-reproduction-and-racial-difference/#:~:text=The%201662%20law%20stated%20that,white%20men%20and%20enslaved%20women.>

The New York Times. "News York Medical Society." February 9, 1860. Accessed April 1, 2024. <https://www.nytimes.com/1860/02/09/archives/news-york-medical-society.html?searchResultPosition=25>.

Planned Parenthood Action Fund. "Abortion Is Central to the History of Reproductive Health Care in America." Planned Parenthood Action Fund. Accessed February 28, 2024. <https://www.plannedparenthoodaction.org/issues/abortion/abortion-central-history-reproductive-health-care-america>.

"Racial Eugenics." Equal Justice Initiative. Last modified October 1, 2013. Accessed March 28, 2024. <https://eji.org/news/history-racial-injustice-racial-eugenics/>.

Reynolds, P. Preston. "UVA and the History of Race: Eugenics, the Racial Integrity Act, Health Disparities." UVA Today. Accessed April 5, 2024. <https://news.virginia.edu/content/uva-and-history-race-eugenics-racial-integrity-act-health-disparities>.

Samuels, Alex, and Monica Potts. "How The Fight To Ban Abortion Is Rooted In The 'Great Replacement' Theory." FiveThirtyEight, July 25, 2022. Accessed April 4, 2024. <https://fivethirtyeight.com/features/how-the-fight-to-ban-abortion-is-rooted-in-the-great-replacement-theory/>.

Shah, Khushbu, and Juweek Adolphe. "400 years since slavery: a timeline of American history." The Guardian, August 16, 2019. Accessed April 10, 2024. <https://www.theguardian.com/news/2019/aug/15/400-years-since-slavery-timeline>.

CITATIONS

Smith, Margaret Charles, and Linda Janet Holmes. *Listen to Me Good: The Life Story of an Alabama Midwife*. Columbus: Ohio State University Press, 2021. Accessed March 4, 2024. <https://ohiostatepress.org/books/titles/9780814207000.html>.

Solinger, Rickie. "Politics of Reproductive Rights in 20th-Century America." *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of American History*, 2017. <https://doi.org/10.1093/acrefore/9780199329175.013.430>.

Storer, Horatio Robinson. *Why Not? A Book for Every Woman*. Boston: Lee and Shepard, 1866. [Archive.org](https://archive.org/details/why-not-a-book-for-every-woman-1866/page/n5/mode/2-up).

Villarosa, Linda. "The Long Shadow of Eugenics in America." *The New York Times*, June 8, 2022. Accessed March 8, 2024. <https://www.nytimes.com/2022/06/08/magazine/eugenics-movement-america.html>.

104

"Virginia Health Bulletin: The New Virginia Law to Preserve Racial Integrity." *Library of Virginia*. <https://edu.lva.virginia.gov/dbva/items/show/226>.

Webster, Crystal. "Enslaved Women's Sexual Health: Reproductive Rights as Resistance." *Black Perspectives*. Last modified December 1, 2021. Accessed March 7, 2024. <https://www.aaihs.org/enslaved-womens-sexual-health-reproductive-rights-as-resistance/>.

Winny, Annalies. "A Brief History of Abortion in the U.S." *Hopkins Bloomberg Public Health*. <https://magazine.jhsph.edu/2022/brief-history-abortion-us>.

TRACKING THE FORMATION OF A CULTURE OF EXTERMINABILITY IN ARMENIA FROM 1878 TO 1915

SISSI MA

Milton Academy '26

Ghassan Hage, Professor of Anthropology at the University of Sydney, coined the concept of the Culture of Exterminability in 2007. He defines it as the social state before extermination where a particular group is systematically prepared for extermination at the hands of a violent authority. In a 2019 blog post, Hage argues that “the Western world is already living in such a culture of [...] [in which] the exterminable is located in the dominant imaginary of the Muslim other.” Similarly, such a state of Exterminability afflicted Armenians in the Ottoman Empire during the lead up to the Armenian Genocide, from 1878 to 1915. Indeed, Abdul Hamid II’s regime, aided by the Committee of Union and Progress (CUP), contributed to a Culture of Exterminability via actions which escalated from legislation to direct violence towards the Armenians from 1878 to 1908. In the end, both Hamid’s government and the CUP, albeit differently, created an environment of Exterminability for Armenians by marginalizing and socially discriminating against them, to the end of prepared them for genocide.

105

In the beginning, from 1878 to 1894, the Ottoman Empire under Hamid used economically marginalizing legislation and religious restrictions to create an environment of Armenian Exterminability. Economically, Hamid imposed a violently enforced and repressive taxation regime targeting Armenians. In particular, in establishing the Hamidiye cavalry, which was made up of Kurds and Turks who volunteered to help collect Armenians’ taxes through harassment, empowered Kurds to violently impose their own interests upon Armenian communities. Simultaneously, Kurdish tribal leaders had recently lost control of their land and its profits due to a shift from the old feudal landowning system to a centralized one during the early 19th century, a shift which forced them to replace their

income by imposing additional taxes on Armenian peasants. Then, after Hamid formed the Hamidiye Cavalry regiments in 1890, more Kurds thought it was justified to impose “double taxation” on Armenians, which meant they would need to pay both Kurdish taxation and Ottoman taxation. Armenians in the village of Sassoun were specifically harmed as the Hamidiye Kurds were taking their lands and imposing even more arbitrary taxes on the peasants. These taxes confined Armenian communities under accumulating debts and a broader sense of social inferiority. In terms of religion, the Armenians, who were Christian rather than Muslim, were also discriminated against in courts and through laws. Historically, the Ottoman Empire has widely used legal systems called the qadi courts since the 7th century until 1922. In this system, if a Muslim is a part of the court, the testimony of a Christian would not be taken into account because the court would not trust people who didn’t believe in Islam. A Muslim jurist explained, “the word of a dishonest Muslim [was] more valuable than that of an honest dhimmi (a non-Muslim)”: even if an Armenian was telling the truth, they would still be rejected. Similarly, the sharia law of the Quran suggested, according to a British diplomat in 1894 Urfa, that “if the rayah [subject] Christian attempts...to overstep the limits of privileges allowed them by their Mussalman [Muslim] masters... their lives and property are to be forfeited.” In Sharia, there is a significant imbalance of power for the Muslims to be masters and the Christian Armenians to be the ones whose lives and properties were being controlled. Both of these long-lasting religious prejudices spanning more than 1000 years ingrained into Armenian culture a sense of inadequacy, making them believe that they were less than Muslims. Even though the Tanzimat reforms, which sought to progress in equality for minority groups like Armenians, ended in 1876 right before Hamid became Sultan, he still didn’t abolish this discriminatory qadi court nor the sharia law, inaction that continued the environment of injustice. Therefore, both religion and economic legislation that were widespread in the Ottoman Empire oppressed Armenians to make them feel inferior and instill a Culture of Exterminability.

Intensified by Hamid’s legislation, the tension between Armenians and the Ottoman regime culminated in Abdul Hamid II’s employing violence to establish a Culture of Exterminability from 1894 to 1896. The unfair taxation and the religious discrimination both created societal tension leading up to 1894. In August 1894, the refusal of Armenian villagers in the vilayet of Sassoun to pay “double taxation” prompted Hamidiye Cavalry regiment leader Zeki Pasha to intervene, starting a massacre that killed 7,000 Armenians in just the month of August. Though Hamid signed to organize reforms in October of 1895, he continued massacres in at least 29 vilayets, including in large regions of Van,

Erzurum, and Bitlis, from October to December. In just under three months, there were 200,000 deaths, which was 8% of the entire Armenian population and an average rate of 2000 deaths per day. In Aintab, Armenia on November 18th, 1895, a college eye-witness described “a great noise of shouting and firing of guns, telling us that the work of blood and plunder had begun here, also.” An image published in Harper’s Weekly in December of 1895 displaying the undignified and ghastly burial of tens and hundreds of Armenians lined up row after row encapsulates the dehumanization of the Armenian populace (see Image 1). Both the rate at which Armenians were killed in 1895 as well as the human accounts of the massacres served as indications of the even larger scale of genocide that was about to happen in 1915. Therefore, this final explosion of escalating legislative, religious, and economic tensions presented itself in violence orchestrated by Hamid in the Hamidian Massacres, directly intensifying the climate of Exterminability.



Image 1: An image of the burial of Armenians killed in the Hamidian Massacres in Erzeroum, published in Harpers Weekly in December 1895.

107

While the Ottoman Empire and Hamid’s acts of harm escalated, the CUP’s legislation and violence coexisted from 1909 to 1915, maintaining the Culture of Exterminability. In 1908, Abdul Hamid was deposed by the Young Turks, a movement that emphasized scientific advancement, state modernity, and elite rule. Then, in the next year, the Young Turks established conscription laws that allowed Armenians, who were previously banned from serving in the military, to serve. Although this legislation was a positive change for Armenians, it was a harm in disguise, causing the installation of 50,000 Armenian men to 100 labor battalions. From 1909 to 1915, these labor battalions worked and lived in atrocious conditions, which were deliberately designed so to the end of killing Armenian

laborers; food supplies were scarce, there was no medical care, and many soldiers abused the conscripts. Soon, after the January 1915 defeat in the Battle of Sarikamis, the Minister of War and CUP leader Ismail Enver blamed the Armenians in these battalions as a major reason for their loss. A directive was published in the next month, turning battalion camps into concentration camps and ordering all Armenians to be killed. The inhumane treatment and order of murder of Armenians as a result of their joining the labor camps due to the conscription laws contributed to the culture of hostility, extreme maltreatment, and Exterminability. During this same time period of the CUP, there were also mass displays of violence. In 1909, the Adana Massacres broke out in Adana - organized by the CUP, it was largely due to the unstable political framework in the Ottoman Empire as the Young Turks Revolution occurred in July of 1908. In just more than one month, 4437 Armenian homes were burned, while 30,000 civilians, 2% of the entire Armenian population, were murdered. Rose Lambart, who was a Christian missionary in Hadjin, Adana, detailed in her eye-witness account that "space will not permit to write in detail of the many who were crucified, thrown into the river, killed with swords and axes, burned by the thousands." She specifically noted the various types of torture and inhumane deaths committed against the Armenians and expressed deep sadness and anger for the tragedy. Hence, both the immense rate of death and first-person accounts point towards a culture of discrimination and Exterminability. The tensions of the current revolution as well as previous hostility had already intensified the massacres, thus causing the coexistence of acts of harm that were on different levels of hostility. Therefore, the conscription laws and the Adana Massacres by the CUP overlapped from 1909 to 1915; both legislation and violence were simultaneous in deepening the Culture of Exterminability.

Escalating from discriminatory legislation to violence, the Ottoman Empire led by Hamid fostered a Culture of Exterminability in Armenia, while the CUP continued to exacerbate this culture. Ultimately, Hage explicates the significance of this Culture of Exterminability. He explained that many would call him alarmist and refuse to accept the jarring idea of people preparing for other peoples' extermination. Yet, observing and reckoning with the existence of this culture and its origins is integral to our understanding of history. Perhaps more importantly, tracking Exterminability is integral to making sure that the genocidal tragedies of history do not repeat themselves.

CITATIONS

Bliss, Edwin M. *Turkey and the Armenian Atrocities*. Keystone Pub., 1896. Digital file.

Editors, White Ink. "He Organized His 'Knights' to Kill Innocent People: Abdul Hamid II." White Ink. Accessed September 29, 2024. <https://whiteink.info/he-organized-his-knights-to-kill-innocent-people-abdul-hamid-ii-started-the-armenian-massacres/?lang=en>.

Hage, Ghassan. "Arendt, Foucault and Cultures of Exterminability." Hage Ba'a (blog), March 19, 2019. Accessed October 2, 2024. <https://hageba2a.blogspot.com/2019/03/arendt-foucault-and-cultures-of.html>.

Harper's Weekly. *The Erzeroum Armenian victims of the massacres are buried in a mass grave in Erzeroum cemetery*. Photograph. Accessed October 2, 2024. <https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Armenia22hamidian.jpg>.

Harvard Divinity School. "Young Turks, The." <https://rpl.hds.harvard.edu/faq/young-turks>.

Kévorkian, Raymond. "The Origins And Evolution of the Armenian Genocide." *AGBU Magazine*, April 2015. Accessed October 2, 2024. <https://agbu.org/remembering-past-redefining-future/origins-evolution-armenian-genocide>.

Lambert, Rose. *Hadjin And The Armenian Massacres (1911)*. Fleming H. Revell company, 1911. Digital file.

Martirosyan, Tigran. "Labour Battalions (Ottoman Empire/Middle East)." *International Encyclopedia of the First World War*. Last modified October 25, 2022. <https://encyclopedia.1914-1918-online.net/article/labour-battalions-ottoman-empiremiddle-east/#easy-footnote-bottom-5-1088339>.

Matossian, Bedross Der. "From Bloodless Revolution to Bloody Counterrevolution: The Adana Massacres of 1909." *Faculty Publications, Department of History*, Summer 2011, 152-73. Digital file.

CITATIONS

Movsesian, Mark. "Elusive Equality: The Armenian Genocide and the Failure of Ottoman Legal Reform." St. John's Law Scholarship Repository, 2010, 1-17. Digital file.

Tashjian, Yeghia. "The Class Struggle in the Ottoman Empire and the Armenian Genocide." The Armenian Weekly. Last modified April 21, 2021. Accessed October 2, 2024. <https://armenianweekly.com/2021/04/21/the-class-struggle-in-the-ottoman-empire-and-the-armenian-genocide/>.

Yavuz, M. Hakan, and Peter Sluglett. War and Diplomacy : the Russo-Turkish War of 1877-1878 and the Treaty of Berlin. Salt Lake City, UT: University of Utah Press, 2011. Digital file.

prism

A Youth Journal of History and
Social Science

Volume 4, Issue 1

Fall 2024

Editors-in-Chief

Molly O'Brien • Haotong Xue

Editorial Board

Oliver Sin • Anaïs Bricout

Avaneesh Siruvuri • Sissi Ma

Zidan Graham • Emlyn Joseph

Henry Mannino

Faculty Advisor

Joshua Emmott

Cover Image: United States Capitol Building - Andy Feliciotti